Mauiza

Mauiza

A road map of life, from before marriage to the last days, with guidance from the life of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh)

Abdullah

Mauiza
A road map of life, from before marriage to the last days, with guidance from the life of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh)

By Abdullah.

No restriction. The author gives full permission to anyone to use, copy, print and share the content of this book.

The problems described in each stage come from books on human development. The guidance comes only from the life of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh): his sayings, his actions and what he approved. Every narration is quoted in full, with its source and its grade as printed in the edition used. Reports from the seerah that carry no grade are marked as such and are not counted as hadith.

Contents

- Introduction vii
- How to read this book ix
- Where are you? xi
- The road map of life xii

01 **Before Marriage** Before marriage 1
02 **Before the First Child** Married, before the first child 29
03 **The New Baby** Birth to 4 weeks 42
04 **The First Year** 1 to 12 months 61
05 **The Second Year** 13 to 24 months 80
06 **Early Childhood** 2 to 6 years 101
07 **Middle Childhood** 7 to 12 years 124
08 **The Teenage Years** 13 to 18 years 151
09 **Young Adulthood** 18 to 30 years 171
10 **Settling Down** 30 to 45 years 193
11 **Middle Age** 45 to 65 years 218
12 **Later Life** 65 to 80 years 241
13 **The Last Part of Life** 80 and beyond; the last days; grief 259

Introduction

I belong to the modern world. For a long time I had no clue what I was doing with my life, or what it was for, and my parents did not know either. It felt like a loop that every parent and every child is stuck in: get this degree, get this job, get this house. In the end I asked myself one question: what next? Was this the whole purpose of my life, to achieve these things? And then what, after all of it?

I came to the conclusion that the problem starts at the roots. My story could have been different if I had been raised with a purpose that matches my original identity as a Muslim.

So I decided to make a book with one core purpose: to build the next generation on the standards of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh).

In sha Allah, I pray that for anyone who understands the world we are living in, and is ready to do anything to return to the original, Allah will open the doors. Ameen.

Abdullah

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to read this book

This book is a road map of a whole life in thirteen stages, from before marriage to the last days. Each stage is a short book of its own. Read the stage you are in now. You do not have to read the book from the start.

Two rules run through every page

WHAT HAPPENS

The problems and changes at each age come only from books on human development.

WHAT TO DO

The guidance comes only from the life of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh), and every narration is quoted in full with its grade.

How each stage is arranged

1. **The first page**

   A strip of thirteen bars shows where this stage sits on the road of life. Below it is the stage title, who the stage is for, and a short list called "Go in this order".

2. **Start here, then, last**

   The factors are grouped under a few headings. Begin with the group marked START HERE, go on to each group marked THEN, and finish with the one marked LAST.

3. **Each factor**

   Every factor has a number, which runs on through the whole stage. It starts with what happens at this age, as the books describe it.

4. **Guidance from the life of the Prophet (pbuh)**

   Each lettered point is followed by the full narration, then its source and grade on one line.

5. **How to do it**

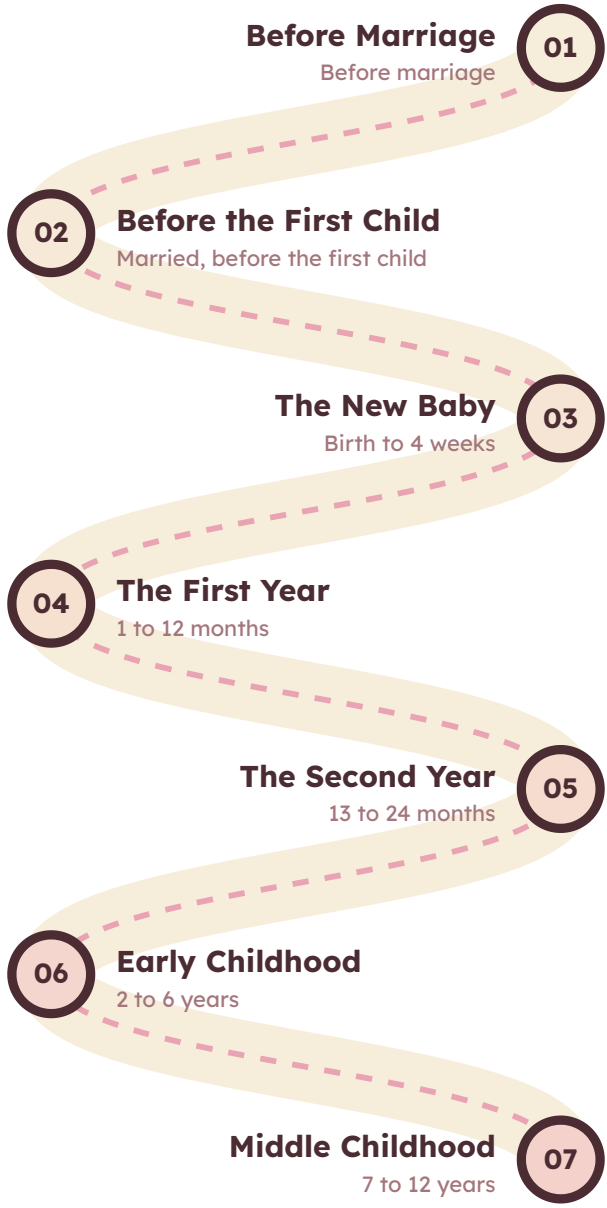
   After all the guidance comes a box of numbered steps to follow, and lines marked "Avoid" for what to stay away from.

Where are you?

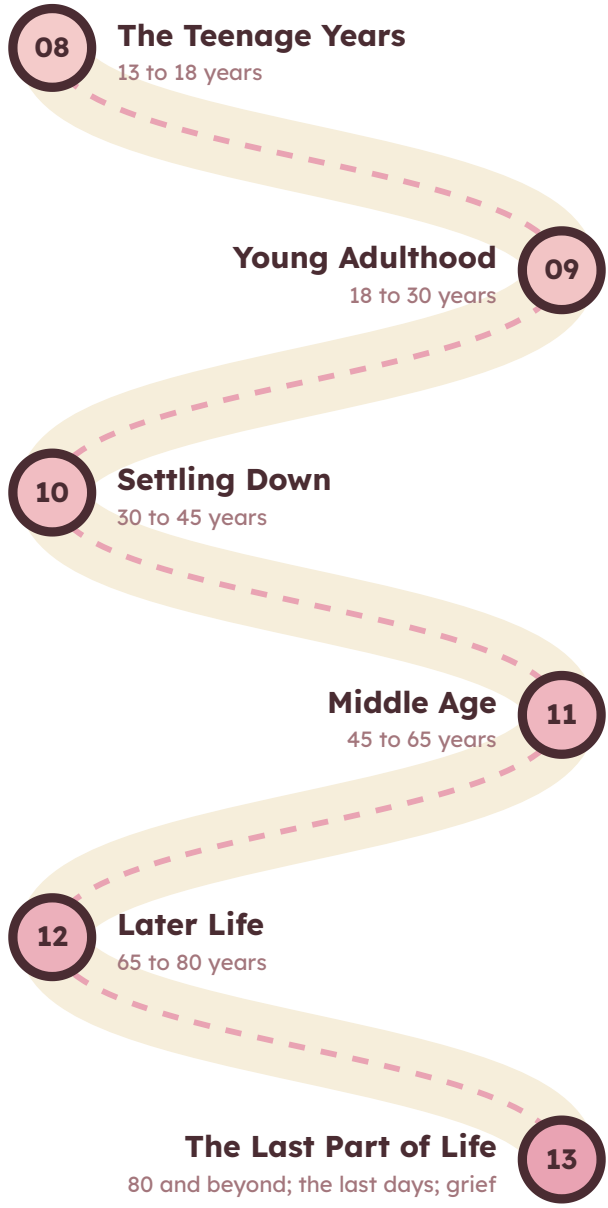
Find your child's age, or your own, and go to that stage.

Before marriage	**Stage 01** Before Marriage
Married, before the first child	**Stage 02** Before the First Child
Birth to 4 weeks	**Stage 03** The New Baby
1 to 12 months	**Stage 04** The First Year
13 to 24 months	**Stage 05** The Second Year
2 to 6 years	**Stage 06** Early Childhood
7 to 12 years	**Stage 07** Middle Childhood
13 to 18 years	**Stage 08** The Teenage Years
18 to 30 years	**Stage 09** Young Adulthood
30 to 45 years	**Stage 10** Settling Down
45 to 65 years	**Stage 11** Middle Age
65 to 80 years	**Stage 12** Later Life
80 and beyond; the last days; grief	**Stage 13** The Last Part of Life

From before marriage...



...to the last days



STAGE 01

Before Marriage

Preparing yourself and choosing a spouse

This stage is for every young man and woman moving toward marriage, and for their parents too. It has no fixed age. It begins when the thought of marriage arises, and it ends with the nikah.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Self-preparation

1. Identity and purpose
2. Control of emotions
3. Taking health lightly in youth
4. Intoxicants and smoking (both men and women)
5. Sleep
6. Weight and exercise
7. Hard work and responsibility
8. Standing on your own feet first
9. Friends and loneliness
10. The skill of talking and resolving conflict

THEN

Criteria for choosing

11. Choosing for the wrong reason
12. Similarity

THEN

Proposal and inquiry

13. Matches through the family

THEN

Consent and decision

14. One's own will and closeness
15. Infatuation and lasting love

LAST

Nikah

16. The financial burden of the nikah

START HERE

Self-preparation

Mind and emotions

FACTOR 1

Identity and purpose

The real test of youth is intimacy (a true close relationship) or isolation, and true intimacy is possible only once one's own identity has formed to some degree. A young person who is unsure of their own identity either shies away from intimacy or jumps into relationships without real commitment. Identity forms slowly: at 18 about 1 in 5 have it, at 21 about 2 in 5, and by 24 more than half. Most young people want work that is enjoyable and does some good (about 8 to 9 out of 10). A life built only on other people's expectations ("this is what you should do") is not truly one's own.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Make your intention and purpose clear before marriage.

> Umar bin al-Khattab said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Deeds are by intentions, and every person gets only what he intended. So whoever's emigration was to Allah and His Messenger, his emigration is to Allah and His Messenger; and whoever's emigration was for some worldly thing he would gain, or for a woman he would marry, his emigration is to that for which he emigrated."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Iman, hadith 54 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Before starting a proposal, ask yourself: who is this marriage for?
2. If the intention is only for the world or only for a person, turn it toward Allah's pleasure, because each person gets what he intended.

FACTOR 2

Control of emotions

A person who flares up quickly, or is always anxious and restless, finds this habit proves toxic for a relationship.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Learn to control yourself in anger. This is the real strength.

> Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) asked: "Whom do you count as a wrestler among you?" We said: the one whom men cannot throw down. He said: "No, rather the wrestler is the one who controls himself in anger."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Birr, narration 6600 (common number 2608) · Grade: Sahih

> Sulayman bin Surad (RA) said: I was sitting with the Prophet (pbuh) and two men were abusing each other; one of them had a red face and swollen veins. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "I know a word which, if he said it, what he feels would go away; if he said: 'A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim', his anger would go." People told him: "The Prophet (pbuh) has said: seek refuge in Allah from Satan the accursed."

Riyad al-Salihin, narration 46 · Grade: muttafaq alayh

Ibn Abbas (RA) said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Teach and make things easy, do not make them hard; and when one of you is angry, let him be silent."

Bukhari, al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 245 · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih li-ghairihi"

b Build the habit of patience. Patience is the greatest blessing.

Abu Sa'id al-Khudri said: some of the Ansar asked the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and he gave them, then they asked and he gave, until what he had ran out. He said: "Whatever good I have I will not keep back from you; whoever refrains from asking, Allah keeps him from it; whoever shows self-sufficiency, Allah makes him rich; whoever strives to be patient, Allah grants him patience; and no one has been given anything better and wider than patience."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Zakat, narration 2408 (common number 1053) · Grade: Sahih

Umm Salama (RA) heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "No Muslim is struck by a calamity and says what Allah commanded: 'Inna lillahi wa inna ilayhi raji'un', (and says) 'O Allah, reward me in my calamity and give me something better in its place', except that Allah gives him something better." Umm Salama said: when Abu Salama died I thought, which Muslim is better than Abu Salama? Then I said this prayer, and Allah gave me the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) in his place.

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Jana'iz, narration 2109 (common number 918) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When anger comes, say at once "A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim".
2. In anger, become silent and say nothing.
3. When a calamity or loss comes, say: "Inna lillahi wa inna ilayhi raji'un. O Allah, reward me in my calamity and give me something better in its place."
4. Instead of asking, refrain and show self-sufficiency; whoever strives for patience, Allah gives him patience.

Health and body

FACTOR 3

Taking health lightly in youth

Ages 20 to 34 are the healthiest period of life. But the biology of aging begins in this very period: smoking, alcohol, inactivity and stress speed up this process, and good habits can slow it down.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Value youth, health and free time, and do not waste them.

> Ibn Abbas said, the Prophet (pbuh) said: "There are two blessings in which many people are at a loss: health and free time."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Riqaq, hadith 6049 · Grade: Sahih

Amr ibn Maymun al-Awdi said that the Prophet (pbuh), advising a man, said: "Take advantage of five before five: your youth before your old age, your health before your sickness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before your busyness, and your life before your death."

Ibn al-Mubarak, al-Zuhd, narration 2 · Grade: the author gave no ruling; a Tabi'i narrates directly from the Prophet (mursal)

HOW TO DO IT

1. Each day take account of these five: youth, health, wealth, free time and life; which of them did I put to use today?

FACTOR 4

Intoxicants and smoking (both men and women)

Substance use peaks between 19 and 25. Lifelong smoking takes about 11 years off life. 7 in 10 smokers want to quit, but 9 in 10 relapse within six months. Alcohol and risky sexual decisions often go together.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give up every intoxicant, whatever it is made from.

Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that when the Prophet (pbuh) sent him to Yemen, he asked about the drinks made there. He said: "What are they?" He said: "Bit' and Mizr" (drinks made from honey and barley). He said: "Every intoxicant is forbidden."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Maghazi, hadith 4087 · Grade: Sahih

FACTOR 5

Sleep

Deep sleep is greatest in the 20s. With lack of sleep, the brain's anger-and-fear centre reacts about 60% more strongly. Even one night of short sleep raises the blood pressure of young, healthy people, and learning without sleep is about 40% lower.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give sleep its full due, and sleep on your right side after wudu.

> Abdullah bin Amr said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came to me and said: "Have I not been told that you stand in prayer all night and fast every day?" I said yes. He said: "Do not do so: pray and also sleep, fast and also break your fast, for your body has a right over you, your eyes have a right over you, your guest has a right over you, and your wife has a right over you."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5783 · Grade: Sahih

> al-Bara bin Azib said: the Prophet (pbuh) said: "When you come to your bed, make wudu as for prayer, then lie on your right side, then say: 'O Allah! I have submitted my face to You, entrusted my affair to You, and leaned my back on You...'"
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 244 · Grade: Sahih

> Abu Barza reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) disliked sleeping before Isha and talking after it.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab Mawaqit al-Salat, hadith 543 · Grade: Sahih

> Abu Hurayra said: "My close friend (pbuh) advised me of three things: fasting three days every month, two rak'ahs of Duha, and that I pray witr before sleeping."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Sawm, hadith 1880 · Grade: Sahih

> Ali (RA) said: Fatima complained of the pain the hand-mill caused her hand, and came to the Prophet (pbuh) to ask for a servant. The Prophet came to us when we had already lain down in our beds, and said: "Shall I not tell you both of something better for you than a servant? When you go to your bed, say Allahu akbar 33 times, Subhan Allah 33 times and Alhamdulillah 33 times; this is better for you than a servant." (In the words of Ibn Sirin the tasbih is 34.)
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Da'awat, hadith 5959 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Do not sleep before Isha, and leave idle talk after Isha.
2. Pray witr before sleeping.
3. Make wudu, lie on your right side, and recite the sleep prayer.
4. In bed say Subhan Allah 33 times, Alhamdulillah 33 times and Allahu akbar 33 (or 34) times.
5. Even in eagerness for worship, do not deny sleep and the body their due.

FACTOR 6

Weight and exercise

Most people regain lost weight within 2 years. People who exercise for health and enjoyment keep it up. Those who do it only for a temporary goal (such as losing weight for a wedding) regain the weight. Exercise is linked to lower mortality and less anxiety.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep the body strong: make movement like running and archery part of life.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong believer is better and more beloved to Allah than the weak believer, and in each there is good. Be eager for what benefits you, seek help from Allah and do not give up. And if something befalls you, do not say: 'If only I had done this, such and such would have happened', but say: 'Allah decreed, and He did what He willed', for 'if only' opens the door to the work of Satan."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Qadar, narration 6732 (common number 2664) · Grade: Sahih

Salama bin al-Akwa' said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by some people of Aslam who were competing in archery. He said: "O Banu Isma'il, shoot, for your father was an archer. Shoot, and I am with the son of so-and-so." One group held back their hands: "How can we shoot when you are with them?" He said: "Shoot, I am with all of you."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2743 · Grade: Sahih

Aisha (RA) was with the Prophet (pbuh) on a journey. She said: I raced him and got ahead of him; then when I had put on weight I raced him and he got ahead of me. He said: "This is for that race."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 2588 (common number 2578) · Grade: not stated in the edition

Ibn Umar said: the Prophet (pbuh) held a race of trained horses from Hafya' to Thaniyyat al-Wada', and of untrained horses from Thaniyya to the Masjid of Banu Zurayq; and Ibn Umar was among those who raced.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jihad, hadith 2713 · Grade: Sahih

b Eat little: a third of the stomach for food, a third for water, a third for breath.

> al-Miqdam bin Ma'dikarib said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "No man fills a vessel worse than his stomach. A few morsels that keep his back straight are enough for the son of Adam; and if he must, then a third for food, a third for drink and a third for breath."

Jami' Tirmidhi, narration 2382 (common number 2380) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

> Umar bin Abi Salama (RA) said: I was a child under the care of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), and my hand used to wander about the dish. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to me: "O boy! Say Allah's name, eat with your right hand, and eat from what is in front of you." After that this was always my way of eating.

Riyad al-Salihin, narration 299 · Grade: muttafaq alayh

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make practice like archery a habit, and compete with friends.
2. Take part in horse racing and running competitions.
3. Do movement like running with your family too.
4. Say Allah's name before eating, eat with the right hand, and eat from what is in front of you.
5. Think of the stomach in three parts: a third food, a third water, a third empty.

Work, livelihood and money

FACTOR 7

Hard work and responsibility

A responsible, hardworking temperament is the best predictor of success in almost every profession.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek knowledge, and eat from the lawful earnings of your own hands.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Seeking knowledge is an obligation on every Muslim."

Sunan Ibn Majah, narration 224 · Grade: not stated in the edition

> Miqdam said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "No one has ever eaten any food better than eating from the work of his own hands; and Allah's prophet Dawud (AS) used to eat from the work of his own hands."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1966 · Grade: Sahih

> Uqba bin Amir said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came to us while we were in the Suffa and said: "Which of you would like to go each morning to Buthan or Aqiq and bring back two great-humped she-camels, without sin and without cutting ties of kinship?" We said: "All of us, O Messenger of Allah." He said: "For one of you to go to the mosque every day and learn two verses of the Book of Allah is better for him than two she-camels, three verses better than three, and so on for the number of verses in camels."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 1459 (common number 1456) · Grade: not stated in the edition

> Zayd bin Thabit said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) ordered me to learn some words of the language of the Jews for him. He said: "By Allah, I do not trust the Jews with my writing." Zayd said: half a month had not passed before I had learned it. Then when the Prophet wrote to the Jews I would write, and when they wrote I would read their letter to him.
>
> Jami' Tirmidhi, narration 2718 (common number 2715) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

> Abu Hurayra reported from the Prophet (pbuh): "Allah did not send any prophet except that he herded goats." The Companions asked: "And you too?" He said: "Yes, I used to herd the goats of the people of Makkah for a few qirats (wages)."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Ijara, hadith 2143 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Learn a little every day, even if only two or three verses.
2. Learn a needed new skill or language with effort; Zayd bin Thabit learned one in half a month.
3. Do not consider any lawful work small; the Prophet (pbuh) herded goats for wages.

FACTOR 8

Standing on your own feet first

Most young people who want to marry (about 9 in 10) want to be financially settled before marriage. But a stable job does not come right after education: many stay unemployed or work below their level of education.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Avoid debt, and do not go near interest.

> Aisha (RA) reported: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray in his prayer: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from the punishment of the grave, I seek refuge in You from the trial of the False Messiah, and I seek refuge in You from the trials of life and death; O Allah, I seek refuge in You from sin and debt." Someone said: "How often you seek refuge from debt!" He said: "When a man is in debt, he speaks and lies, and he promises and breaks his promise."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adhan, hadith 798 · Grade: Sahih

> Jabir said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) cursed the one who consumes interest, the one who pays it, the one who writes it down and its two witnesses, and said: "They are all equal."

Sahih Muslim, narration 4062 (common number 1598) · Grade: Sahih

> Abu Hurayra said: a man was owed a camel by the Prophet (pbuh); he came demanding it and was harsh. The Companions moved against him, but the Messenger of Allah said: "Leave him, for the one with a right has the right to speak." Then he said: "Give him a camel of its age." They said: "O Messenger of Allah, we find only one better than it." He said: "Give it to him, for the best of you are those best in repaying."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Wakala, hadith 2182, 2183 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. In prayer, before the salam, seek Allah's refuge from debt.
2. If you must take a loan, repay it on time and in a good way, even better than you took.

Relationships and community

FACTOR 9

Friends and loneliness

Loneliness is felt most between ages 20 and 40. Loneliness puts as much stress on the body as a physical assault, and often comes before depression. One deep, trustworthy friend is better than many friends. Good relationships in youth predict later happiness even better than academic success.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Choose friends carefully, because a person is on the religion of his friend.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A man is upon the religion of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."

Jami' Tirmidhi, narration 2380 (common number 2378) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

> Abu Musa al-Ash'ari (RA) reported from the Prophet (pbuh): "The example of a good companion and a bad companion is that of one carrying musk and one blowing a furnace. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy from him, or you will find a pleasant scent from him. And the one blowing the furnace will either burn your clothes, or you will find a foul smell from him."

Riyad al-Salihin, narration 363 · Grade: muttafaq alayh

HOW TO DO IT

1. Sit with people whose company brings good, as sitting near a perfume seller brings fragrance.
2. Stay away from bad company, as near a blacksmith's furnace there is the risk of burnt clothes.

FACTOR 10

The skill of talking and resolving conflict

In the first years of marriage a relationship breaks down through four things: criticism, contempt (looking down on the other), defensiveness at every point, and going silent like a wall. Of these, contempt is the biggest sign. The biggest reason for breakdown in the first 5 years is not conflict but failing to pay attention to each other. About half of divorces in first marriages happen in the first 7 years.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Avoid taunting, cursing, obscene talk and foul language.

> Abdullah ibn Umar (RA) reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The believer is not one who taunts, curses, speaks obscenely or uses foul language."

Bukhari, al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 313 (chapter: the believer is not a taunter) · Grade: editor's ruling: Sahih

b Stop correcting every little thing and saying "why did you do that"; speak gently.

> Anas (RA) said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years, and he never once said 'uff' to me; never about something I did did he say why did you do it, and never about something I did not do did he say why did you not do it. He had the best character of all people."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 2016 · Grade: Tirmidhi said hasan sahih

> Aisha (RA) said: a group of Jews came to the Prophet (pbuh) and said "as-saam alayka" (death be upon you). The Prophet (pbuh) said: "And upon you." Aisha said: rather upon you be death and curse. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "O Aisha! Allah loves gentleness in every matter." Aisha said: did you not hear what they said? He said: "I already replied: and upon you."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Isti'dhan wa al-Adab, narration 2704 · Grade: Tirmidhi said hasan sahih

c Do not stop speaking out of anger; do not turn away for more than three days.

> Abu Ayyub al-Ansari (RA) reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is not lawful for a Muslim to cut off his brother for more than three days, such that when they meet this one turns away and that one turns away; and the better of the two is the one who begins with the greeting of salam."

Bukhari, al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 409 (chapter al-muhtajirin) · Grade: editor's ruling: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Drop the habit of saying "why did you, why didn't you" at the other person's mistakes.
2. Even if the other person speaks harshly, do not answer with taunts or curses; keep your words gentle and brief.
3. After a quarrel do not become a wall of silence; within three days, give salam yourself and restart the conversation.

THEN

Criteria for choosing

FACTOR 11

Choosing for the wrong reason

Do not choose a match to "fix" a lack inside yourself. Choosing a spouse is really choosing your future family. A temperament that flares up quickly and is always anxious is toxic for a relationship.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When choosing a match, look at faith first.

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A woman is married for four things: for her wealth, for her lineage, for her beauty and for her religion; so win the one with religion, may your hands be covered in dust."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Rada', narration 3604 (common number 1466) · Grade: Sahih

b Accept the proposal of one whose faith and character please you.

> Abu Hatim al-Muzani (RA) said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "When someone comes to you whose religion and character please you, marry him; if you do not, there will be trial on earth and great corruption." The Companions said: O Messenger of Allah, and if there is (some shortcoming) in him? He repeated the same words three times.

Ibn Abi al-Dunya, al-Iyal, narration 118 · Grade: the author gave no ruling; editor: its chain includes Abdullah ibn Hurmuz, who is weak, and there is disagreement over Abu Hatim being a Companion; Tirmidhi called it hasan

c Choose a match intending a loving home with children.

> Ma'qil bin Yasar said: a man came to the Prophet (pbuh) and said: "I have found a woman of good family and beauty, but she cannot bear children; should I marry her?" He said: "No." He came a second time and he forbade him; he came a third time and he said: "Marry the loving one who bears many children, for I will take pride in your numbers before the other nations (on the Day of Judgement)."

Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 2055 (common number 2050) · Grade: not stated in the edition

FACTOR 12

Similarity

People usually marry those of a similar background. The three foundations of a successful marriage are maturity, similarity and equality between the two.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Look for a match among equals (kufu).

> Aisha (RA) said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Choose (a good place) for your offspring, marry equals (kufu) and give them in marriage too." In another chain: "Let each of you see where he is placing his offspring; marry equals and give equals in marriage."

Ibn Abi al-Dunya, al-Iyal, narration 130-131 · Grade: the author gave no ruling; the editor called it weak (Abu Hatim and Abu Zur'a: "this hadith is not sound"; al-Khatib: "all its routes are weak"); on narration 131: "weak hadith, its chain includes Ikrima ibn Ibrahim, who is not relied upon"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When looking at a match, look for equality, and give the girls of your own home in marriage to equals too.

THEN

Proposal and inquiry

FACTOR 13

Matches through the family

Satisfaction in a match arranged through the family can be equal to or greater than in a self-chosen one.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Move the proposal forward through the family and with dignity, as the Prophet's (pbuh) own nikah happened.

When Khadija heard of the Prophet's (pbuh) truthfulness, great trustworthiness and good character, she invited him to take her goods to Syria and gave him a better wage than other traders. The Prophet (pbuh) accepted. Then Khadija said: "O son of my uncle, I have become interested in you because of your kinship, your honour among your people, your trustworthiness, your good character and your truthfulness," and she sent a proposal of nikah. The Prophet (pbuh) told this to his uncles; Hamza went along, asked for her hand, and the nikah took place. At that time the Prophet (pbuh) was 25 years old.

Seerat Ibn Hisham, j2:5-8 · Grade: not stated in the edition

In the narration of Ibn Sa'd, Nafisa, at Khadija's request, asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Why do you not marry?" He said: "I have nothing for marriage." She asked: "What if you were offered a match with beauty, wealth, honour and equality?" "Who?" "Khadija." "How could that be for me?" "Leave that to me." "Then I am ready." Then Khadija called her uncle Amr bin Asad, and Banu Hashim came, and the nikah took place.

Ibn Sa'd, al-Tabaqat, j1:104-105 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Do not send your proposal over someone else's proposal.

> Abu Hurayra reported from the Prophet (pbuh): "A man should not propose over his brother's proposal, nor bid over his brother's bid; a woman should not be married together with her paternal or maternal aunt; and a woman should not demand the divorce of her sister (co-wife) to empty her vessel and marry in her place; she will get what Allah has written for her."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3412 (common number 1408) · Grade: Sahih

> Ibn Umar used to say: the Prophet (pbuh) forbade any of you to sell over another's sale, and a man to propose over his brother's proposal until the first proposer withdraws or gives him permission.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Nikah, hadith 4848 · Grade: Sahih

c See your future spouse before the nikah.

> Abu Hurayra said: I was with the Prophet (pbuh) when a man came and said that he had married a woman of the Ansar. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to him: "Did you look at her?" He said: no. He said: "Go and look at her, for there is something in the eyes of the Ansar."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3454 (common number 1424) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Send the proposal through a trustworthy person, as Khadija sent Nafisa.
2. Tell the elders of the family about the proposal, as the Prophet (pbuh) told his uncles.
3. Let the family elders go together to ask for the hand, as Hamza went along.
4. Let the nikah take place in the presence of the elders of both families.
5. First find out whether someone else's proposal is already in progress.
6. If it is, wait until the first proposer withdraws or gives permission.
7. Before finalising the match, go and see for yourself.

THEN

Consent and decision

FACTOR 14

One's own will and closeness

A strong marriage needs two things: each person's own will (autonomy) and closeness between them. Couples who have both together have more satisfaction.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Ask the woman. Do not marry her without her consent.

Abu Hurayra said, the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A previously married woman is not to be married without consulting her, and a virgin is not to be married without her permission." The Companions asked: "O Messenger of Allah! How is her permission given?" He said: "That she stays silent."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3442 (common number 1419) · Grade: Sahih

Aisha (RA) said: "I asked the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) about a girl whose family arranges her marriage: should she be consulted or not?" The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Yes, she should be consulted." Aisha said: "I said: but she is shy." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Then that is her permission, when she stays silent."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3444 (common number 1420) · Grade: Sahih

b Do not force a marriage. Such a marriage is annulled.

Khansa bint Khidham al-Ansariyya reported that her father married her off while she was a widow, and she disliked it. She came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), and he annulled that marriage.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Nikah, hadith 4845 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Ask the woman directly; take her opinion.
2. If a never-married woman stays silent out of shyness, her silence is consent; a previously married woman gives consent in her own words.

FACTOR 15

Infatuation and lasting love

There are two common mistakes: marrying in a state of infatuation, and ending the relationship when the infatuation fades. A year after marriage, expressions of love often fall to about half. Love has three parts: passion, intimacy and commitment. Commitment makes love grow.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Make istikhara before deciding.

Jabir bin Abdullah said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to teach us istikhara in all matters as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an. He would say: 'When one of you intends some matter, let him pray two rak'ahs other than the obligatory prayer, then say: O Allah! I seek good from You by Your knowledge, I seek ability from You by Your power, and I ask You of Your great bounty; for You are able and I am not, You know and I do not know, and You are the Knower of the unseen. O Allah! If You know that this matter is better for my religion, my livelihood and my end, then decree it for me and make it easy, then bless me in it; and if You know that this matter is bad for my religion, my livelihood and my end, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree good for me wherever it is, then make me content with it.' And he said: 'Name your need.'"

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Tatawwu', hadith 1109 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Pray two voluntary rak'ahs besides the obligatory prayer.
2. Then recite the istikhara prayer.
3. In the prayer, name your need, that is, mention this match.
4. Then be content with whatever decision Allah makes easy.

LAST

Nikah

FACTOR 16

The financial burden of the nikah

Most young people who want to marry (about 9 in 10) want to be financially settled before marriage. (This is the same factor as in 1.3.1; here is its part at the time of the nikah.)

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep the mahr easy, within what both can afford.

> Sahl bin Sa'd said: a woman came to the Prophet (pbuh) and said: "O Messenger of Allah, I have come to give myself to you." He raised his eyes and looked at her, then lowered his gaze and bowed his head. When the woman saw that he had made no decision about her, she sat down. One Companion said: "If you have no need of her, marry her to me." He said: "Do you have anything?" He said: "No, by Allah." He said: "Go to your family and see if you find something." He went, came back and said: "I found nothing." He said: "Look, even if it is an iron ring." He went back again: "Not even an iron ring." He said: "What do you have of the Qur'an?" He said: "Such and such." He said: "I have married her to you for what you have of the Qur'an."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab Fada'il al-Qur'an, hadith 4741, 4742 · Grade: Sahih

In another narration the man said that he had seen her. He said: "For how much (mahr) did you marry?" He said: for four uqiyas (of silver). The Prophet (pbuh) said: "For four uqiyas? It is as if you are carving silver from the side of this mountain! We have nothing to give you, but perhaps we will send you on an expedition from which you will get something."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3455 (common number 1424) · Grade: Sahih

b Hold the walima simply: whoever has something, let him bring it.

Anas related the event at Khaybar: the Prophet (pbuh) freed Safiyya bint Huyayy and married her; her mahr was her freedom. On the way Umm Sulaym prepared her. In the morning he said: "Whoever has something, let him bring it." A leather mat was spread; someone brought dates, someone ghee, and perhaps sawiq too. They made food from these, and this was the walima of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh).

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Salat, hadith 364 · Grade: Sahih

Ali (RA) said: "When I intended to marry Fatima, the daughter of the Messenger of Allah, I arranged with a goldsmith of Banu Qaynuqa' that he would go with me and we would bring idhkhir (grass), which I wanted to sell to the goldsmiths and use to help pay for my walima."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Buyu', hadith 1983 · Grade: Sahih (Ali's (RA) statement)

Abd al-Rahman bin Awf emigrated to Madinah and stayed with Sa'd bin al-Rabi'. Sa'd offered him half his wealth. Abd al-Rahman prayed for him and said: show me the way to the market. He went to the market, earned cheese and ghee, and married. The Prophet (pbuh) saw the trace of marriage on him and asked: "How much mahr did you give?" He said: "Gold the weight of a date stone." He said: "May Allah bless you. Hold a walima, even with one sheep."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Nikah, hadith 4858, 4860, 4872 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Give as mahr whatever you have: clothing, even an iron ring.
2. If there is nothing, teaching the Qur'an can also be the mahr.
3. Do not take on a mahr beyond your means.
4. Be sure to hold a walima, even with one sheep.
5. Everyone together brings what they can: dates, ghee, sawiq.
6. Save for the walima from your own work, as Ali (RA) planned the walima by selling idhkhir.

STAGE 02

Before the First Child

Preparing the home and the environment

This stage is for a married couple: after the nikah and before the first child. It has no fixed age. It begins with the nikah and ends when a baby is on the way.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

The couple's relationship

1. Friendship and attention
2. Not every problem gets solved

THEN

Running the home

3. The relationship and housework after a child

THEN

Money and livelihood

4. The effect of poverty on a child

THEN

Health before a baby

5. The mother's weight before a baby comes
6. Both mother and father give up intoxicants

THEN

Family and support

7. Support from relatives
8. Neighbours and social ties

LAST

Knowledge and intention

9. Wanting a child together
10. Knowing about parenting in advance

START HERE

The couple's relationship

FACTOR 1

Friendship and attention

About 70% of satisfaction in marriage comes from the quality of the friendship between husband and wife. Couples who turn toward each other's small words and efforts keep their relationship. For every bad act there should be at least 5 good ones. Husbands who know the details of their wife's life (her likes, worries and dreams) keep their satisfaction even after a child arrives.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be the best to your family.

> Aisha (RA) said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family; and when your companion dies, leave him (do not speak of his faults)."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Manaqib, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

> Aisha (RA) said: "I never felt as much jealousy toward any of the Prophet's (pbuh) wives as I did toward Khadija, even though I never saw her. The only reason was that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) spoke of her so often. And when he slaughtered a sheep, he would seek out Khadija's friends and send them a gift."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 2018 (common number 2017) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih gharib"

> Aisha (RA) was with the Prophet (pbuh) on a journey. She said: I raced him and got ahead of him; then when I had put on weight I raced him and he got ahead of me. He said: "This is for that race."
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 2588 (common number 2578) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Even a small service to your spouse is worship.

> Sa'd bin Abi Waqqas (RA) reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whatever you spend seeking the pleasure of Allah, you will be rewarded for it, even the morsel you put in your wife's mouth."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Iman, hadith 56 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember your spouse's likes and the people they love, and look after them, as the Prophet (pbuh) used to speak of Khadija (RA) and send gifts to her friends.
2. Spend time together, and share joys such as play and racing.
3. Feed your spouse with your own hand, and in every expense and service keep the intention of pleasing Allah.

FACTOR 2

Not every problem gets solved

About 69% of problems in marriage are lasting ones. They cannot be ended; you have to learn to live with them.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a If you dislike one habit, look at another good one.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Let no believing man hate a believing woman; if he dislikes one of her habits, he will be pleased with another."
>
> Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Rada', narration 3617 (common number 1469) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When one of your spouse's habits feels bad, at that very moment remember one of their good habits and be content with it.

THEN

Running the home

FACTOR 3

The relationship and housework after a child

After the first child, satisfaction falls quickly for most couples (about 67%), and more so for women. The difference does not come from the child's temperament, but from whether the husband stayed with his wife through this change. Once they become parents, the load of housework often falls on the woman (in one survey, about 17–18 hours a week for the woman and about 10 hours for the man). Deciding the share of housework before the child reduces quarrels.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Help with the housework.

> al-Aswad bin Yazid said: I asked Aisha (RA): what did the Prophet (pbuh) do when he was at home? She said: "He used to be busy with the work of his family, and when the time for prayer came he would get up and pray."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab Sifat al-Qiyama, narration 2492 (common number 2489) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When you are at home, take part in the work of your family.
2. When the time for prayer comes during the work, put the prayer first.

THEN

Money and livelihood

FACTOR 4

The effect of poverty on a child

Poverty reaches a child even before birth: the mother's poor food, more stress and sadness, and less care. In poor homes, low-weight births and child deaths are about 1.7 times higher, and when income rose while the mother was expecting the child's health got better. Money pressure makes parents sad, and their parenting becomes harsher and less warm.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Spend on your family; this has the greatest reward.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A dinar you spend in the way of Allah, a dinar you spend to free a slave, a dinar you give in charity to a poor person, and a dinar you spend on your family: of these, the greatest reward is for the one you spend on your family."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Zakat, narration 2297 (common number 995) · Grade: Sahih

b Do not hold back the provision of those you are responsible for.

> Khaythama said: we were sitting with Abdullah bin Amr when his steward came. He asked: "Have you given the servants their provision?" He said: "No." He said: "Go and give it to them." Then he said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is enough of a sin for a man to hold back the provision of those whose provision he controls."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Zakat, narration 2298 (common number 996) · Grade: Sahih

c Keep your family's needs for the whole year aside in advance.

> Umar (RA) reported that the Prophet (pbuh) used to sell (the produce of) the date-palm gardens of Bani Nadir and keep back his family's food for the whole year. In another narration Umar (RA) said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to spend a whole year's expenses on his family from this wealth, then he placed what was left where Allah's wealth is placed; the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) did this all his life."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Nafaqat, hadith 5042, 5043 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When income comes, first set aside your family's food and expenses for the whole year.
2. Put what is left into work in the way of Allah.

THEN

Health before a baby

FACTOR 5

The mother's weight before a baby comes

Before a baby comes, the mother's weight should be neither too high nor too low. Too much weight raises the risk of high blood pressure while expecting (preeclampsia) by more than three times, and also of diabetes, early birth and operation; for a very thin mother it is hard to conceive.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Eat little: a third of the stomach for food, a third for water, a third for breath.

> al-Miqdam bin Ma'dikarib said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "No man fills a vessel worse than his stomach. A few morsels that keep his back straight are enough for the son of Adam; and if he must, then a third for food, a third for drink and a third for breath."

Jami' Tirmidhi, narration 2382 (common number 2380) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

> Umar bin Abi Salama (RA) said: I was a child under the care of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), and my hand used to wander about the dish. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to me: "O boy! Say Allah's name, eat with your right hand, and eat from what is in front of you." After that this was always my way of eating.
>
> Riyad al-Salihin, narration 299 · Grade: muttafaq alayh

HOW TO DO IT

1. Say Allah's name before eating, eat with the right hand, and eat from what is in front of you.
2. Think of the stomach in three parts: a third food, a third water, a third empty.

FACTOR 6

Both mother and father give up intoxicants

A father's sperm takes about 2–3 months to form, so the father too should give up smoking and alcohol 2–3 months before trying for a baby. A father's smoking slightly raises heart and limb defects in the child. For the mother: no alcohol, no cigarettes (not even other people's smoke in the home) and no drugs at all.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give up every intoxicant, whatever it is made from.

> Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that when the Prophet (pbuh) sent him to Yemen, he asked about the drinks made there. He said: "What are they?" He said: "Bit' and Mizr" (drinks made from honey and barley). He said: "Every intoxicant is forbidden."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Maghazi, hadith 4087 · Grade: Sahih

THEN

Family and support

FACTOR 7

Support from relatives

A human child is not raised by the mother alone: the mother gives about half the care, and the rest comes from brothers and sisters, grandparents, the father and other relatives. This saves the mother's strength and gives the child many examples. The maternal grandmother was often found to be the most useful helper, and where the mother was cut off from her relatives, newborn deaths were higher.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Stay connected with your relatives (sila rehmi).

> Anas bin Malik said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Whoever would like his provision to be made wide and his life to be blessed, let him keep ties with his relatives."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Buyu', hadith 1961 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep in touch with relatives and visit them, with the intention of blessing in provision and life.

FACTOR 8

Neighbours and social ties

The rich have the support of money; the poor have only relationships. In poor neighbourhoods that were alike, where social ties were strong there was less abuse of children, and a child was three times more likely to have a father at home. Among children at risk, the biggest reason for those who came through was the mother's circle of support and her religious community.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give the neighbour his right.

> Ibn Umar and Aisha (RA) reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Jibril kept advising me about the neighbour until I thought he would make him an heir."

Riyad al-Salihin, narration 303 · Grade: muttafaq alayh

> Abu Dharr (RA) said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "O Abu Dharr! When you cook broth, add more water to it and look after your neighbours." In another narration of Muslim, Abu Dharr says: my dear friend (pbuh) advised me: "When you cook broth, add more water, then look to the families of your neighbours and give them some of it in a good way."

Riyad al-Salihin, narration 304 · Grade: Nawawi wrote "narrated by Muslim"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When you cook, make a little extra and take it to your neighbours' families in a good way.

LAST

Knowledge and intention

FACTOR 9

Wanting a child together

Both wanting a child is the biggest predictor of a marriage lasting; if one of them said yes with difficulty, separation often comes within 5 years. Many babies come unplanned (35% in one survey).

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep the intention of a righteous child.

> Abu Hurayra said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "When a person dies, his deeds come to an end except for three: ongoing charity, knowledge that benefits others, or a righteous child who prays for him."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Wasiyya, narration 4192 (common number 1631) · Grade: Sahih

b Husband and wife say the dua before coming together.

> Ibn Abbas said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "If any of you, when he intends to go to his wife, says: 'In the name of Allah; O Allah, keep Satan away from us and keep Satan away from what (child) You grant us', then if a child is decreed for them from this, Satan will never harm it."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Nikah, narration 3502 (common number 1434) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. In wanting a child, keep the intention that the child becomes righteous and prays for you even after death.
2. When you intend to go to your wife, say: "Bismillah, Allahumma jannibna al-shaytan wa jannib al-shaytan ma razaqtana."

FACTOR 10

Knowing about parenting in advance

Parenting has two separate sides: warmth (love, listening, acceptance) and structure (limits, watching over, rules with reasons). Where both are present children turn out best, and where neither is present (neglect) they turn out worst. Warmth and limits do not replace each other; each does a different job.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a See your family as your responsibility; you will be asked about them.

> Abdullah bin Umar said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Each of you is a shepherd and each of you will be asked about his flock: the imam is a shepherd and responsible for his flock; a man is the shepherd of his family and responsible for his flock; a woman is the shepherd of her husband's house and responsible for her flock; a servant is the shepherd of his master's wealth and responsible for his flock."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jumu'a, hadith 853 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Before the child, husband and wife both decide who is responsible for what in the home.

STAGE 03

The New Baby

The first four weeks after birth

This stage is for a mother and father in the first four weeks after their baby is born, and for the family around them. It begins on the day of birth and ends when the baby is about one month old.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

The first day

1. Staying close: voice and touch
2. The father and the family

LAST

The first four weeks

3. Answering the cry, and holding the baby
4. Smiles, eye contact and play
5. The mother's feelings
6. Tiredness and anger
7. The father's share, and the marriage
8. Guests and relatives
9. Older brothers and sisters
10. The baby's own nature, and a good name

START HERE

The first day

FACTOR 1

Staying close: voice and touch

The first hour is a time when the baby is alert: stroke the baby and talk to the baby. A newborn can tell the mother's voice apart from other women's voices, having learned it before birth, and hearing is far more ready than sight.

The idea of a "bonding window" is a myth. The first hour matters for life and for milk, but it is not the last chance for love: love has no time limit, even if the first hour is missed for any reason. Pressing a mother to feel love at once can bring on sadness.

Keeping mother and baby apart delays the milk; when they stay in the same room, feeding whenever the baby asks is easier. Within about two days a mother knows her own baby's cry.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give the adhan in the baby's ear: the first words the baby hears.

> Ubaydullah bin Abi Rafi' reported from his father: I saw the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) give the adhan of prayer in the ear of Hasan bin Ali when Fatima gave birth to him.

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Adahi, narration 1517 (common number 1514) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

b Pray for blessing for the baby.

> Aisha said: children used to be brought to the Prophet (pbuh) and he would pray for them. A child was brought, and it urinated on his clothes; he asked for water and poured it over the place, and did not scrub it.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Da'awat, hadith 5994 · Grade: Sahih

c Do not separate a mother from her child.

> Abu Ayyub said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Whoever separates a mother from her child, Allah will separate him from his loved ones on the Day of Resurrection."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Buyu', narration 1285 (common number 1283) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

d A mother holding her baby close and feeding it is a natural mercy.

> Umar bin al-Khattab said: some captives were brought to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). Among them was a woman searching (for her child); whenever she found a child among the captives, she picked it up, held it close to her and fed it. The Messenger of Allah said to us: "Do you think this woman would throw her child into the fire?" We said: "No, by Allah, not while she is able not to." He said: "Allah is more merciful to His servants than this woman is to her child."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Tawba, narration 6935 (common number 2754) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. On the first day: the adhan in the baby's ear, a dua of blessing, and sharing the good news.
2. Keep mother and baby together.
× **Avoid:** Separating mother and baby.

FACTOR 2

The father and the family

In the first days a father is often taken up with the baby: the baby looks perfect to him, and he longs to touch and hold the baby. Fathers often hold and play with a newborn as much as mothers do, or more: this is very much his baby too.

A human mother watches her baby closely but does not keep it to herself. Other people touch and hold the baby from the first day, though the mother holds the baby most and the baby stays with her at night. The grandmother on the mother's side is the most reliably helpful of all.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Show joy at the birth, reward the one who brings the good news, and choose a name.

> Anas said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Tonight a boy was born to me, and I have named him after my father, Ibrahim."

Ibn al-Qayyim, Tuhfat al-Mawdud, chapter 8 · Grade: Ibn al-Qayyim says it is in Sahih Muslim

Salma, a freed woman of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), was the midwife of Maria. She went to her husband Abu Rafi′ and told him that Maria had given birth to a boy. Abu Rafi′ came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and gave him the good news, and the Prophet (pbuh) gave him a servant as a gift.

Ibn al-Qayyim, Tuhfat al-Mawdud, chapter 8 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Kiss the baby, smell the baby, and hold the baby; show a father's love.

Anas said: "I have never seen anyone more merciful to his family than the Messenger of Allah (pbuh)." Ibrahim was given to be nursed in the higher part of Madina. The Prophet would go there, and we went with him; he would enter the house, which was full of smoke because the nurse's husband was a blacksmith, take the child, kiss him, and then return. When Ibrahim died, the Messenger of Allah said: "Ibrahim is my son, and he died while still nursing; he has two nurses who will complete his nursing in Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 5984 (common number 2316) · Grade: Sahih

Abu Hurayra said: al-Aqra′ bin Habis saw the Prophet (pbuh) kissing Hasan and said: "I have ten sons, and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 5986 (common number 2318) · Grade: Sahih

c The elder of the family prays and gives thanks, and arranges help for the mother.

Amina sent word to the grandfather, Abd al-Muttalib, that a grandson had been born in his house. Abd al-Muttalib came and saw the baby, and Amina told him of her dream and the name. The grandfather took the baby inside the Ka'ba, prayed and gave thanks, then handed the baby back to his mother and looked for a nurse to feed him.

Ibn Hisham, al-Sira, vol. 1, p. 295-296 · Grade: not stated in the edition

d Give the mother's sister the place of a mother.

Al-Bara said: when the Prophet (pbuh) left (Makka after the umra), the daughter of Hamza followed him calling "O uncle, O uncle". Ali picked her up, took her hand and said to Fatima: "Take your uncle's daughter, look after her." Ali, Zayd and Ja'far disputed over her: Ali said "I have more right, she is my uncle's daughter." Ja'far said "She is my uncle's daughter, and her aunt (her mother's sister) is my wife." Zayd said "She is my brother's daughter." The Prophet (pbuh) judged in favour of her mother's sister and said: "The mother's sister is in the place of the mother."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Sulh, hadith 2552 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. On the first day, share the good news with joy, and choose a good name.
2. Father: hold the baby, kiss the baby, and show your love openly.
3. Let close family, such as the grandmother and the mother's sister, help the mother.

LAST

The first four weeks

FACTOR 3

Answering the cry, and holding the baby

A newborn cries for one to four hours a day, most often from hunger. When the baby is not hungry, cold or in pain, a voice calms a little, sucking calms more, and rocking calms most; some cries stop the moment the baby is picked up. Carrying the baby on the shoulder and walking works best, and babies who are held more cry about a third less in the early months.

You cannot spoil a young baby by giving attention. Babies whose calls for help are answered cry less overall, and over the long run they cry and cling to their parents less. The old advice to let a baby "cry it out" is rejected by the books. Touch may be the newborn's most important sense.

Crying grows in the first weeks, is highest at about six weeks, and then falls, in all human babies: it gets better.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When you hear the baby cry, answer it: the Prophet (pbuh) shortened his prayer so the mother would not suffer.

Abu Qatada reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "I stand in prayer and want to make it long, then I hear a baby crying, so I shorten my prayer so as not to make things hard for his mother." Anas bin Malik said: I never prayed behind any imam a lighter and more complete prayer than the Prophet's; when he heard a baby crying he would lighten the prayer, fearing that its mother would be distressed. And the Prophet said: "I begin the prayer intending to make it long, then I hear a baby crying, so I shorten my prayer, because I know how much its crying grieves its mother."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jama'a, hadith 675-678 · Grade: Sahih

b Take the baby in your arms, hug the baby, kiss the baby, and pray for the baby.

Abu Hurayra said: the Prophet (pbuh) went out at a time of day, and he did not speak to me nor I to him, until he came to the market. He sat in the courtyard of Fatima's house and said: "Is the little one there? Is the little one there?" She kept him back for a while (I thought she was putting a necklace on him or washing him). Then he came running, and the Prophet hugged him, kissed him and said: "O Allah, love him, and love whoever loves him."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Buyu', hadith 2016 · Grade: Sahih

c Carry the baby even while you do your own work.

> Abu Qatada al-Ansari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray while carrying Umama, the daughter of Zaynab, the daughter of the Messenger of Allah; when he went into prostration he would put her down, and when he stood up he would pick her up.

Sahih Bukhari, Abwab Sutra al-Musalli, hadith 494 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Answer the baby's cry as soon as you hear it.
2. Take the baby in your arms; kiss and hug the baby.

FACTOR 4

Smiles, eye contact and play

At around two weeks the first smiles begin, at first for everyone. Long before a baby understands a word, the baby understands your moods and feelings from the way you touch.

From about three and a half weeks the baby begins to meet your eyes. Parents say "now the baby can see me", and play grows. The first smile in answer to you comes near the end of the first month for some babies and at six to ten weeks for others: no smile at four weeks is not "late". When smiles and babbling begin, they lift the mother like a spark, and she becomes more responsive.

Play is like a dance: you take turns leading and following. Answering the baby's signals tells the baby that he can affect the world around him, and this message is vital for his growing self-esteem.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Play with the baby: catch the baby laughing, and hold the baby close.

Ya'la bin Murra (RA) said: we went out with the Prophet (pbuh), invited to a meal. On the way Husayn was playing. The Prophet (pbuh) hurried ahead of the people and opened his arms. The boy ran here and there, and the Prophet kept making him laugh until he caught him; he put one hand under his chin and the other on his head, and hugged him. Then the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Husayn is from me and I am from Husayn. Whoever loves Hasan and Husayn, Allah loves him."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 367 (common number 364) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

b Hold the children close together, and pray for mercy for them.

Usama bin Zayd said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to take me and sit me on one of his thighs, and sit Hasan on the other thigh, then hold us both together and say: "O Allah, have mercy on them, for I have mercy on them."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5657 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Play with the baby: catch the baby laughing, hold the baby close, and show your love.

FACTOR 5

The mother's feelings

In the first days about half of mothers or more have the "baby blues" as hormones fall: joy, pain, utter exhaustion and worry all at once. "This, too, shall pass." Worrying thoughts are common as well, such as checking again and again that the baby is breathing.

The blues should be over by the second week; sadness that lasts more than two weeks may be depression. Lack of support, money worries and a hard birth are among its causes. Its central thought is "I am not a good mother", which brings guilt and less care for the baby, and shame stops many mothers asking for help.

A mother who is unwell talks with the baby and connects with the baby less, and the baby then asks for less. A quiet baby can wrongly look like a "good" baby.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Say the Prophet's dua against worry and grief.

> Anas said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to say: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from helplessness and laziness, from cowardice and miserliness, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Da'awat, hadith 6008 · Grade: Sahih

b Comfort the mother when she is crying: nothing is wrong with her.

> Aisha said: we went out with the Messenger of Allah in the months of Hajj, and stopped at Sarif. The Prophet came to me while I was crying and said, with a word of affection: "Why are you crying?" I said: "I heard what you said to your companions, and I have been kept from the umra." He said: "What is the matter with you?" I said: "I cannot pray." He said: "Then no harm will come to you. You are one of the daughters of Adam, and Allah has written for you what He has written for them. Stay in your Hajj; perhaps Allah will grant you (the umra)."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Hajj, hadith 1485 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Comfort the mother, and listen to her before you judge.
2. Say the dua against worry and grief.

FACTOR 6

Tiredness and anger

The parents' sleep is broken. Tired parents read the baby's face wrongly, toward fear, and anger flares: "I just snapped." Without sleep, control over feelings falls sharply.

Parents lose control most at the baby's high-pitched cry. Feeling alone, stressed and frustrated are the biggest reasons a baby is hurt. Never shake a baby, or let anyone else do it, ever. The crying is not personal: it is not because you are a bad parent.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give your body its right: do not ignore your tiredness.

Abdullah bin Amr said: I used to fast every day and recite (the Qur'an) every night. The Prophet was told of this (or he sent for me) and said: "Have I not been told that you fast every day and recite every night?" I said: "Yes, O Prophet of Allah, and I wanted only good by it." He said: "Three days of fasting each month is enough for you." I said: "O Prophet of Allah, I can do more than that." He said: "Your wife has a right over you, your guest has a right over you, and your body has a right over you." ... Abdullah said: "I was hard on myself, so it was made hard for me."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Siyam, narration 2703 (common number 1159) · Grade: Sahih

b Keep control of yourself in anger: that is real strength.

The Prophet (pbuh) asked: "Whom do you count as the strong wrestler among you?" They said: the one whom men cannot throw down. He said: "No, the strong one is the one who controls himself at the time of anger."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 155 · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

c When anger comes, seek refuge with Allah from Satan; the anger goes.

> Sulayman ibn Surad (RA) said: two men insulted each other in front of the Prophet (pbuh), and one of them became so angry that his face swelled and changed. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I know a word which, if he said it, what he feels would go away." A man went to him and told him what the Prophet had said, and said: "Seek refuge with Allah from Satan the outcast."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 438 (common number 434) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

d Be gentle: Allah is gentle and loves gentleness.

> The Prophet (pbuh) said: "O Aisha, Allah is gentle and loves gentleness, and He gives for gentleness what He does not give for harshness, nor for anything else."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 6560 (common number 2593) · Grade: Sahih

e Do not say even "uff", and do not keep asking "why did you do that".

> Anas said: "I served the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) for ten years. By Allah, he never said to me even 'uff', and he never said about anything: 'Why did you do this?' or 'Why did you not do that?'"

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 5969 (common number 2309) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. In anger: seek refuge with Allah, keep control of yourself, and speak gently.
2. Look after the mother's rest: her body has a right.

FACTOR 7

The father's share, and the marriage

The father takes part from the first day: holding the baby, changing, bathing and calming the baby. This is not only women's work, and the more involved he is, the more attached he becomes. When someone at home holds the father back, saying it is not a man's job, the bond weakens.

A father's warmth makes the mother more effective, and his support lessens her sadness. The quality of the marriage often falls in the baby's first year, because of lack of sleep, loneliness, unequal work and sadness.

A child's security depends most on the whole circle of people who care for the child, and in the first year most babies bond with both mother and father.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Help with the work of the home, so the mother can rest.

> Al-Aswad said: I asked Aisha what the Prophet (pbuh) used to do in his house. She said: he used to be busy with the work of his family, that is, serving his family, and when the time for prayer came he went out to pray.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jama'a, hadith 644 · Grade: Sahih

b Be the best to your family, and the mother's support.

> Aisha (RA) said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family; and when your companion dies, leave him (do not speak of his faults)."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Manaqib, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

c Do not hate your wife: if you dislike one habit, be pleased with another.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Let no believing man hate a believing woman; if he dislikes one of her habits, he will be pleased with another."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Rada', narration 3617 (common number 1469) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Father: help with the housework, so the mother can rest.
2. When there is strain, no hatred: be a better partner.

FACTOR 8

Guests and relatives

In the first two weeks keep visitors few, so the family can recover and enjoy the new baby.

Where a mother was cut off from her relatives and kept under strict watch, babies did worse.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A guest stays three days, and should not stay so long that it becomes a burden.

Abu Shurayh al-Adawi said: my ears heard and my eyes saw when the Prophet spoke: "Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his guest with his due." He was asked: what is his due, O Messenger of Allah? He said: "A day and a night. Hospitality is three days, and what is beyond that is charity from the host." In another narration: "It is not lawful for a Muslim to stay with his brother so long that he makes him sin." He was asked: how would he make him sin? He said: "He stays with him when he has nothing left to host him with."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Luqata, narration 4482 · Grade: Sahih

b Keep ties with relatives, but do not cut the mother off from them.

Anas bin Malik said: I heard the Messenger of Allah say: "Whoever would like his provision to be made wide, or his life to be lengthened, let him keep ties with his relatives."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Buyu', hadith 1961 · Grade: Sahih

Abu Hurayra said: a man came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and said: "Who among people has the most right to my good company?" He said: "Your mother." He said: "Then who?" He said: "Then your mother." He said: "Then who?" He said: "Then your mother." He said: "Then who?" He said: "Then your father."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 6459 (common number 2548) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Guests for three days; do not let hosting become a burden on the mother.

× **Avoid:** Cutting the mother off from those close to her.

FACTOR 9

Older brothers and sisters

Older children may feel jealous and go back to baby ways, such as wanting nappies again or having accidents. These are normal responses to stress and do not deserve punishment.

Children aged two to five are affected the most. A strong bond with the father helps, and so does special time with the older child every day.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be fair between your children: do not treat the older child as less.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father brought me to the Prophet (pbuh) and said: "I have given this son of mine a servant as a gift." The Prophet asked: "Have you given the same to all your children?" He said: "No." He said: "Then take it back." In another narration, my mother Amra bint Rawaha said: "I will not be content until you make the Messenger of Allah a witness." My father went to the Prophet, who asked: "Have you done this with all your children?" "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be just between your children." My father came back and took the gift back.

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Hibat, narration 4146 (common number 1623) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be just between your children in gifts and attention.

FACTOR 10

The baby's own nature, and a good name

Every newborn has a definite temperament of his own, and from birth a sense of self begins to emerge. As one book says: "We are meeting someone we know well for the very first time."

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Choose a good name.

> Abu Wahb (RA), a companion, reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Name your children after the prophets. The names most loved by Allah are Abdullah and Abd al-Rahman, the truest names are Harith and Hammam, and the worst names are Harb and Murra."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 831 (common number 814) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih" (except the sentence about the prophets)

> Samura said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A boy is held in pledge for his aqiqa: it is slaughtered for him on the seventh day, he is given his name, and his head is shaved."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Adahi, narration 1525 (common number 1522) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. On the seventh day: the aqiqa, the name, and shaving the head.

STAGE 04

The First Year

From one month to the first birthday

This stage is for the mother and father of a baby from one month old until the first birthday, and for the family around them. It begins when the first four weeks are over, and it ends when the baby is one year old.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Months 1 to 3

1. Answering the baby's cry
2. Smiling back: face-to-face time
3. The mother's feelings and the baby
4. Mother and father together
5. Tiredness and anger

THEN

Months 4 to 6

6. Talking back and forth
7. The baby's own temperament
8. A growing will, and the first anger
9. Crying when the mother leaves
10. Quarrels at home, and the mother's mood

THEN

Months 7 to 9

11. Few, steady carers
12. Fear of strangers, and clinging
13. Mother and father both

LAST

Months 10 to 12

14. Play, shared attention and talk
15. Obedience grows from trust, not harshness
16. A new baby, and fairness between children

START HERE

Months 1 to 3

FACTOR 1

Answering the baby's cry

Crying is at its highest at around 6 to 8 weeks, and then it falls by about 12 to 16 weeks. For parents this is the most tiring time of the whole year.

In the first three months, how much a baby cries does not depend on how the mother responds. But by the end of the year, babies whose mothers answered them quickly cry less. Babies in places where nobody answered them stopped crying altogether by three months.

Most parents answer sometimes and not at other times, and such babies become more irritable. The fear of "spoiling" a baby by answering in the first year has no basis.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When the baby cries, make what you are doing lighter, out of care for the mother.

> Abu Qatada reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "I stand in prayer and want to make it long, then I hear a baby crying, so I shorten my prayer so as not to make things hard for his mother." Anas bin Malik said: I never prayed behind any imam a lighter and more complete prayer than the Prophet's; when he heard a baby crying he would lighten the prayer, fearing that its mother would be distressed. And the Prophet said: "I begin the prayer intending to make it long, then I hear a baby crying, so I shorten my prayer, because I know how much its crying grieves its mother."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jama'a, hadith 675-678 · Grade: Sahih

b Hug the baby and kiss the baby: whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy.

> Abu Hurayra said: al-Aqra' bin Habis saw the Prophet (pbuh) kissing Hasan and said: "I have ten sons, and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 5986 (common number 2318) · Grade: Sahih

> Jarir bin Abdullah said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever does not show mercy to people, Allah does not show mercy to him."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 1924 (common number 1922) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the baby cries, make what you are doing lighter, and look after the mother.
2. Every day, hug the baby and kiss the baby.
- × **Avoid:** Being stingy with mercy and love for children.

FACTOR 2

Smiling back: face-to-face time

At around 2 months the baby begins to smile back and to coo. A home that responds works like this: the baby looks, the adult smiles widely, and the baby smiles again. This is how the bond is built.

In face-to-face play small mismatches happen every day; the real lesson is the repair, done within a few seconds. Good attention pauses when the baby looks away; chasing the baby's gaze only makes the baby look away more. A face that suddenly goes still and blank upsets a baby of 2 to 3 months.

At 3 to 4 months, timing between mother and baby that is far too tight or far too loose affects the bond at one year; a middle level of matching gives a secure bond.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Call the baby with love, open your arms, and pray for the baby.

Abu Hurayra said: I was with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) in a market of Madina. He turned back and I turned back with him. He said three times: "Where is the little one? Call Hasan bin Ali." Hasan bin Ali came walking, with a necklace of fragrance around his neck. The Prophet (pbuh) opened his arms like this, and Hasan opened his arms like this, then he hugged him and said: "O Allah, I love him, so love him, and love whoever loves him." Abu Hurayra said: after what the Messenger of Allah said, no one was dearer to me than Hasan bin Ali.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Libas, hadith 5545 · Grade: Sahih

b Carry the baby even while you are busy with your own work.

> Abu Qatada al-Ansari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray while carrying Umama, the daughter of Zaynab, the daughter of the Messenger of Allah; when he went into prostration he would put her down, and when he stood up he would pick her up.

Sahih Bukhari, Abwab Sutra al-Musalli, hadith 494 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Call the baby with love, and hug the baby.
2. Carry the baby, even while doing your own work.

FACTOR 3

The mother's feelings and the baby

Sadness after the birth affects about 1 to 2 mothers in every 10. When a mother does not connect with her baby or look at the baby, it can be a sign of this sadness. Babies of mothers who stay sad pay less attention and show more signs of stress.

In one group of families, babies of sad mothers seemed fine at 3 months, were doing less well at 6 months, and half were anxious by 12 months.

A warm bond with the father or with another carer protects the baby while the mother is low.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a In worry and grief, say the Prophet's dua.

> Anas ibn Malik (RA) said that the Prophet (pbuh) often made this dua: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry, from grief, from helplessness, from laziness, from cowardice, from miserliness, from the burden of debt, and from being overpowered by people."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 818 (common number 801) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. In worry and grief, say the Prophet's dua.

FACTOR 4

Mother and father together

In the baby's first year, the quality of the marriage falls for many couples. Strain between the parents makes caring for the baby harder, and even babies younger than 6 months sense the quarrels at home.

When the father or another carer keeps a warm bond, it protects both the mother and the baby.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be the best to your family.

> Aisha (RA) said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family; and when your companion dies, leave him (do not speak of his faults)."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Manaqib, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be the best to your family, and take part in the work of the home.

FACTOR 5

Tiredness and anger

Shaking the baby out of tiredness or anger is the greatest danger of these months; most serious harm to children under three happens this way. A baby must never be shaken.

Even one loving person in a child's life gives great strength, and a secure bond works as a shield against stress.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep control of yourself in anger: that is real strength.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong one is not the one who throws others down; the strong one is the one who controls himself at the time of anger."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5763 · Grade: Sahih

b Never raise your hand.

> Aisha said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) never struck anything with his hand, neither a woman nor a servant, except when fighting in the way of Allah; and he never took revenge for any harm done to him, except when something Allah made sacred was violated, then he took revenge for the sake of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 6008 (common number 2328) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When anger comes, keep control of yourself.
2. × **Avoid:** Raising a hand, or being harsh, in anger.

THEN

Months 4 to 6

FACTOR 6

Talking back and forth

From four to six months, talk becomes a back-and-forth of turns. When the baby's babbling is answered, the babbling doubles; when it is not answered, it fades.

When parents say a word, move the object and touch the baby at the same time, the baby links the word to the thing sooner. Around five months the baby knows his own name.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Mix with the children and talk with them, even about small things.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to mix with us so closely that he would say to a little brother of mine: "O Abu Umayr, what did the little bird (nughayr) do?"

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5778 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Talk with the baby and joke with the baby, as the Prophet (pbuh) did with little Abu Umayr.

FACTOR 7

The baby's own temperament

The baby's temperament becomes clear: about 1 in 5 babies react strongly to anything new, and about 2 in 5 react very little.

What matters is the fit between the baby's nature and the home: a baby who is slow to warm up, very sensitive or very active needs different things. Shielding the baby from every stress, or stirring the baby up too much, both make the bond less secure.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Make things easy, and do not make them hard.

> Abu Burda reported from his father Abu Musa: when the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) sent him and Mu'adh bin Jabal (to Yemen), he said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away; and agree with each other." Abu Musa said: "O Messenger of Allah, we are in a land where a drink called bit' is made from honey and one called mizr from barley." The Messenger of Allah said: "Every intoxicant is forbidden."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5773 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make things easy for the baby, not hard.
- × **Avoid:** Putting the baby into hardship, or forcing the baby.

FACTOR 8

A growing will, and the first anger

From four to six months a baby's anger begins to rise, and it keeps rising into the second year: the baby now acts on purpose and wants some control.

Whether to pick the baby up at every cry is something the books disagree on. For very sensitive babies, a clear but gentle limit lowered fear in one small study.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be gentle: Allah loves gentleness in every matter.

> Aisha said: a group of Jews came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and said "al-samu alaykum" (death be upon you). I understood and said: "And upon you be death and curses." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Gently, O Aisha! Allah loves gentleness in every matter." I said: "O Messenger of Allah, did you not hear what they said?" He said: "I said (in reply): and upon you."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5678 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the baby resists, answer with gentleness, not harshness.

FACTOR 9

Crying when the mother leaves

Around five months the baby begins to cry when the mother leaves, climbs on her, and greets her fully when she comes back. This is a sign of a strong bond.

From six to eight months the true bond begins: the mother becomes a safe base, and the baby protests at parting. Babies whose mothers were close and responsive were less upset by short separations.

Sensitivity can be learned. In one study, just three sessions with the mothers of irritable babies raised secure bonds from 28 to 68 babies in every 100.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The bond of mother and child is a picture of Allah's mercy.

Umar bin al-Khattab said: some captives were brought to the Prophet (pbuh). Among them was a woman whose breasts were full of milk; whenever she found a child among the captives, she held it to her and fed it. The Prophet (pbuh) said to us: "Do you think this woman would throw her child into the fire?" We said: "No, not while she is able not to." He said: "Allah is more merciful to His servants than this woman is to her child."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5653 · Grade: Sahih

b The mother's right comes first.

> Abu Hurayra said: a man came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and asked: "O Messenger of Allah, who has the most right to my good company?" He said: "Your mother." He asked: then who? He said: "Your mother." He asked: then who? He said: "Your mother." He asked: then who? He said: "Then your father."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5626 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep the mother's right first, and keep mother and baby close.
- × **Avoid:** Putting the mother's right in second place.

FACTOR 10

Quarrels at home, and the mother's mood

Even babies younger than six months sense the quarrels at home, and in homes with fighting babies show more signs of stress.

The mother's sadness is most risky for the baby from six to eighteen months. If it lifts by six months, the baby does not fall behind later.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Take part in the work of the home.

> Al-Aswad said: I asked Aisha what the Prophet (pbuh) used to do in his house. She said: he used to be busy with the work of his family, that is, serving his family, and when the time for prayer came he went out to pray.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Jama'a, hadith 644 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Take part in the housework.

THEN

Months 7 to 9

FACTOR 11

Few, steady carers

After seven months, a change of the main carer upsets every baby, so the people who care for the baby should be few and steady.

Many people sharing the care is fine, as long as one or two of them stay the same. In child care, the quality and the continuity of the care matter most; the books disagree about the rest.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a **The mother's sister is in the place of the mother.**

> Al-Bara said: when the Prophet (pbuh) was leaving Makka after the umra, the daughter of Hamza followed him calling "O uncle, O uncle". Ali picked her up, took her hand and said to Fatima: "Take your uncle's daughter, look after her." Ali, Zayd and Ja'far disputed over her. Ali said: "I have more right, she is my uncle's daughter." Ja'far said: "She is my uncle's daughter, and her aunt (her mother's sister) is my wife." Zayd said: "She is my brother's daughter." The Prophet (pbuh) judged in favour of her mother's sister and said: "The mother's sister is in the place of the mother."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Sulh, hadith 2552 · Grade: Sahih

b Keep the ties of family.

> The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Whoever wishes for his provision to be made wide and his life to be lengthened, let him keep the ties of kinship."

al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 56-57 · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

c Whoever cares for an orphan will be close to the Prophet (pbuh) in Paradise.

> Sahl said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "I and the one who cares for an orphan will be in Paradise like this," and he pointed with his index and middle fingers, keeping a little space between them.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Talaq, hadith 4998 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep in touch with relatives, and let familiar family help with the baby.

FACTOR 12

Fear of strangers, and clinging

Fear of strangers and crying at parting come together now. The baby swings between bold and clingy. People may say "you have spoiled the baby", but these worries are proof of a healthy bond.

Fear of strangers is much less when the baby is in the mother's lap, and shared care by several familiar people lowers it. Slipping away quietly, or leaving a baby who is tired or hungry, makes parting harder.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

Seek Allah's protection for the baby.

> Ibn Abbas said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to seek protection for Hasan and Husayn, and say: "Your forefather (Ibrahim) used to seek protection with these words for Isma'il and Ishaq: I seek refuge in the perfect words of Allah from every devil and every harmful creature, and from every evil eye."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab Ahadith al-Anbiya, hadith 3191 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Say the dua of protection over the baby.

FACTOR 13

Mother and father both

At seven to eight months babies are attached to mother and father equally. The father more often picks the baby up to play, and under stress the baby turns to the mother.

By one year, about 61 in 100 babies are attached to both mother and father. Fathers who change and care for the baby are closer to the baby. The biggest single factor in a secure bond is the parent's sensitive response from the first months.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Father: go to the baby, take the baby in your arms, and kiss the baby.

> Anas said: "I have never seen anyone more merciful to his family than the Messenger of Allah (pbuh)." Ibrahim was given to be nursed in the higher part of Madina. The Prophet would go there, and we went with him; he would enter the house, which was full of smoke because the nurse's husband was a blacksmith, take the child, kiss him, and then return. When Ibrahim died, the Messenger of Allah said: "Ibrahim is my son, and he died while still nursing; he has two nurses who will complete his nursing in Paradise."
>
> Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fada'il, narration 5984 (common number 2316) · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Father: take the baby in your lap and kiss the baby.

LAST

Months 10 to 12

FACTOR 14

Play, shared attention and talk

The more a parent and baby look at the same thing and play with toys together, the sooner pointing, words and vocabulary come.

Parents who talk with the baby during the everyday work of the home help the baby most, and homes differ greatly in how much they talk.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Play with the children, then kiss them and hold them close.

> Abdullah ibn al-Harith said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to line up Abdullah, Ubaydullah and Kathir (the sons of al-Abbas) and say: "Whoever reaches me first will have such and such." They would race to him and climb on his back and chest, and he would kiss them and hold them close.
>
> Musnad Ahmad, narration 1844 (common number 1836) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make time to play with the baby and talk with the baby.

FACTOR 15

Obedience grows from trust, not harshness

Doing as asked begins at twelve to eighteen months, and so does saying no. Secure babies go along about 81 times in 100: obedience comes from trust, not from harshness.

Hitting, shouting, long lectures, and punishment that hurts the body or the feelings do harm. Labels like "stubborn" or "bad" stick to a child. Say "no" only for real danger, clearly but not harshly.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Do not say even "uff", and do not keep asking "why did you do that".

> Anas said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came to Madina and had no servant. Abu Talha took my hand, brought me to the Prophet and said: 'O Messenger of Allah, Anas is a sensible boy; let him serve you.' I served the Prophet at home and on journeys, and he never said to me about anything I did, 'Why did you do it like this?', nor about anything I did not do, 'Why did you not do it like this?'"
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Wasaya, hadith 2616 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the child does not do as asked, be patient instead of scolding.
2. ✕ **Avoid:** Raising a hand to the child.

FACTOR 16

A new baby, and fairness between children

When a new baby comes, the older child's sense of security drops. A gap of about two years between children is healthier.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Fear Allah and be just between your children.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: his father brought him to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and said: "I have given this son of mine a servant as a gift." He said: "Have you given the same to all your children?" He said: "No." He said: "Then take it back." In another narration Nu'man said: my father gave me a gift, and Amra bint Rawaha said: "I will not be content until you make the Messenger of Allah a witness." He went to the Messenger of Allah, who said: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Then fear Allah and be just between your children." So he went back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Hiba, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be just between your children in gifts and attention.
2. × **Avoid:** Favouring one child over another.

STAGE 05

The Second Year

From the first birthday to the second

This stage is for the mother and father of a child from one year old until two years old, and for the family around them. In this year the child walks, begins to talk, says "no", and starts to know "me".

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Walking, and staying close

1. Walking, falling and getting up
2. Fear, clinging and crying when you leave
3. Showing your love openly

THEN

Words and play

9. First words
10. Playing together
11. Toys, friends and greeting

THEN

A will of their own

4. Exploring everything, and putting things in the mouth
5. "No", pushing and tantrums
6. Never "uff", never a hand
7. Your own anger
8. Accidents and mess

LAST

"Me", fairness and the family

12. "Me", a good name, and keeping promises
13. Fairness between children
14. Mother and father at home
15. The parents' tiredness and worry

START HERE

Walking, and staying close

FACTOR 1

Walking, falling and getting up

Most children take their first steps on their own somewhere between nine and seventeen months. Some are walking at thirteen months and some are still holding on to furniture; both are normal.

A new walker's steps are short and uneven. A toddler may fall many times a day and hardly cry, and the child wants to come back to you between each try.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Stop what you are doing and pick the stumbling child up.

> Buraida said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was giving us a sermon when Hasan and Husayn came, both wearing red shirts, stumbling, falling and getting up as they walked. He came down from the pulpit, picked them up, took them up onto the pulpit with him, and said: "Allah spoke the truth: 'Your wealth and your children are only a test' (al-Taghabun 15). I looked at these two and I could not wait." Then he went on with the sermon.
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 1110 (common number 1109) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Keep the small child with you, even while you work.

> Abu Qatada al-Ansari said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray while carrying Umama, the daughter of his daughter Zaynab. When he went down into prostration he put her down, and when he stood up he picked her up again.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 494 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the child stumbles towards you, stop your work, even something important, and pick the child up.
2. Keep the child who is learning to walk on your lap or shoulder while you work: put the child down when you bend, and pick the child up again when you stand.

× **Avoid:** Keeping the child away from you because you are busy or important.

FACTOR 2

Fear, clinging and crying when you leave

Fear of strangers and of being apart from the mother is at its strongest in the first half of this year. The child clings, cries when the mother goes, and checks her face to see whether something is safe.

At eighteen months the child goes off to explore but turns back to check that you are still near. You are the safe base the child works from. Even in good, familiar care, being apart from the mother is never completely free of upset.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Shorten what you are doing when the child cries.

> Anas said: when the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) heard a child crying with its mother during the prayer, he would recite a short surah. In another narration the Prophet said: "I begin the prayer meaning to make it long, then I hear a child crying, so I make it short, because I know how much its crying troubles its mother."

Sahih Muslim, common number 470 · Grade: Sahih

b Have mercy on the child who clings: Allah has more mercy on you.

> Abu Hurayra said: a man came to the Prophet (pbuh) with a small child who kept clinging to him. The Prophet asked: "Do you have mercy on him?" He said: "Yes." The Prophet said: "Then Allah has more mercy on you than you have on him, and He is the most merciful of all who show mercy."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 380 (common number 377) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih al-isnad"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the child cries, shorten what you are doing, thinking of how the mother feels.
2. Be merciful to the child who clings, and remember that Allah is more merciful than you.

FACTOR 3

Showing your love openly

Children whose parents answer them warmly in these years grow up calmer under stress. A secure bond is built by the relationship itself, not passed down in the child's nature, and it can still change a great deal during this year.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Kiss the child and show mercy.

> Abu Hurayra said: al-Aqra bin Habis saw the Prophet (pbuh) kissing Hasan and said: "I have ten sons and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2318 · Grade: Sahih

b Carry the child on your shoulder and say that you love the child.

> Bara bin Azib said: I saw Hasan bin Ali on the shoulder of the Prophet (pbuh), and the Prophet was saying: "O Allah, I love him, so love him too."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2422 · Grade: Sahih

c Hold the children close together.

> Usama bin Zayd said: the Prophet (pbuh) would take me and sit me on one of his thighs, and sit Hasan on the other, then hold us both together to his chest and say: "O Allah, have mercy on these two, for I have mercy on them."

Ibn Abi al-Dunya, Al-Iyal, narration 234 (common number 233) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Show the child your love: kiss the child and take the child in your lap.
2. Carry the child on your shoulder, in your lap and against your chest, and say: "O Allah, I love this child."
- × **Avoid:** Holding back your love, like the man who said: "I have ten sons and have never kissed any of them."

THEN

A will of their own

FACTOR 4

Exploring everything, and putting things in the mouth

In this year the child learns by doing: dropping things again and again to see what happens, trying something many times before it works, and copying what grown-ups did days before.

Everything still goes into the mouth, and each new skill such as climbing or opening lids brings a new need for watching.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Take out gently what the child has put in the mouth.

> Abu Hurayra said: at harvest time dates were brought to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) until there was a heap of them. Hasan and Husayn began to play with the dates, and one of them picked up a date and put it in his mouth. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) saw him, took it out of his mouth, and said: "Do you not know that the family of Muhammad do not eat charity?" In another narration he said "Kakh, kakh!" so the child would spit it out.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1414, 1420 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Whatever the child puts in the mouth that should not be there, take it out yourself, gently.

FACTOR 5

"No", pushing and tantrums

"No" becomes a favourite word. The child wants to do things alone but does not yet have the words or the control, so frustration comes out as tantrums. Most children have at least one tantrum a month at eighteen to twenty-four months, more when tired, hungry or unwell. Tantrums are not a sign that you are a bad parent.

Pushing, grabbing, hitting and biting also begin. By around seventeen months most children do some of this, and it peaks at about two years. Both very harsh parents and parents who set no limits have children with more tantrums.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Choose gentleness: it makes everything beautiful.

> Aisha reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Gentleness is never in anything except that it makes it beautiful, and it is never taken out of anything except that it spoils it." In one narration, Aisha was riding a difficult camel and kept turning it sharply, and the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to her: "Be gentle."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2594 · Grade: Sahih

> Abdullah bin Mughaffal reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Allah is gentle and loves gentleness, and He gives for gentleness what He does not give for harshness."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 476 (common number 472) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

b Make things easy, and do not make them hard.

> Anas reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 69 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose gentleness when the child says "no" or grabs a toy, and explain gently.
2. Make things easy for the child, and do not put the child into hardship.
- × **Avoid:** Harshness: when gentleness is taken out of something, it spoils it.

FACTOR 6

Never "uff", never a hand

Starting every sentence with "don't", "stop" or "leave it", calling the child names such as "bad" or "stupid", and saying "act like a big child" all make a toddler more upset. Children who are hit often at this age are more aggressive later.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Do not say even "uff", and do not question the child harshly.

> Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, he never said 'Why did you do that?', and he never said 'Why did you not do that?'"
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

b Do not strike with the hand.

> Aisha said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) never struck anyone with his hand, not a woman and not a servant, except when fighting in the path of Allah. When someone harmed him he never took revenge for himself; only when something Allah had made sacred was violated would he act, for Allah's sake."
>
> Sahih Muslim, hadith 2328 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the child makes a mistake, do not say even "uff", and do not question the child with "Why did you do that?"
- × **Avoid:** Hitting the child.
- × **Avoid:** Making the child the target of your busyness or your anger.

FACTOR 7

Your own anger

A toddler's tantrum can make a tired parent angry. The books count the parent's own anger as one of the main problems of this year.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek refuge in Allah when anger comes.

> Sulayman bin Surad said: we were sitting with the Prophet (pbuh) when two men began to insult each other, and the face of one of them turned red with anger. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I know a word that, if he said it, his anger would go: 'A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim' (I seek refuge in Allah from the accursed devil)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5764 · Grade: Sahih

b If you are standing, sit down.

> Abu Dharr said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to us: "When one of you becomes angry while standing, let him sit down. If the anger leaves him, good; if not, let him lie down."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4782 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. When anger rises, say "A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim".
2. If you are standing, sit down; if the anger does not go, lie down.
- × **Avoid:** Shouting and showing anger in front of the child.
- × **Avoid:** Staying on your feet while angry.

FACTOR 8

Accidents and mess

Wetting and mess are part of this age. After a long separation many toddlers lose the control they had gained, so how you react matters more than the mess.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Only sprinkle water; do not make a fuss.

> Umm Qays bint Mihsan brought a small son of hers, who was not yet eating food, to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). He sat the child in his lap, and the child passed urine on him. He only sprinkled water over it and did nothing more. In one narration: he asked for water, sprinkled it on his garment, and did not scrub it.

Sahih Muslim, common number 287 · Grade: Sahih

b "Do not frighten him."

> Abu Layla said: I was with the Prophet (pbuh) and Hasan or Husayn was on his chest, and the child passed urine. I got up to take him, and the Prophet said: "Leave my son, do not frighten him." In another report: the Prophet was lying on his back playing with a child on his chest when the child passed urine; a woman got up to lift the child away, and the Prophet said: "Leave him."

Al-Salihi, Subul al-Huda, report 2777 · Seerah report; no grade in this edition, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the child wets or makes a mess, just sprinkle water over it.
2. × **Avoid:** Frightening or scolding the child for an accident or a mess.

THEN

Words and play

FACTOR 9

First words

This is the year words take off: one word at a time at first, then around eighteen months a new word every few hours for many children, then two-word sentences such as "more juice". By two years some children have a hundred words and some have hundreds; both can be normal.

Almost all of a child's words come from the words the parents use, and children learn words far better from a live person than from a screen. How much a home talks with the child makes a large difference.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Speak clearly, each word separate.

> Aisha said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) did not speak quickly, running his words together as you do. He spoke clearly, each word separate, so that whoever sat with him could remember it.

Al-Baghawi, Al-Shamail, narration 213 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Say what matters three times.

> Anas reported that when the Prophet (pbuh) said something, he would repeat it three times so that it was fully understood; and when he came to a people he greeted them three times.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 94-95 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Speak to the child clearly, word by word, and say what matters three times.
2. Let your own speech in front of the child be soft, clear and unhurried.
- × **Avoid:** Fast, rushed speech that the child cannot take in.

FACTOR 10

Playing together

Pretend play begins: feeding a doll, "cooking" what the father cooked. A child can do with a grown-up's help what the child cannot yet do alone.

Flash cards and early-learning programmes add nothing that ordinary play and talk do not give.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Play the child's games, at the child's level.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to put out his tongue for Hasan bin Ali, and the child would see the redness of his tongue and rush towards him with joy.

Akhlaq al-Nabi, narration 185 (common number 184) · Grade: editor's ruling "hasan chain"

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) would take Husayn bin Ali by the hands and stand him on his own feet, saying a children's play rhyme: "Hazaqa, hazaqa, climb up, little one!" Then he said: "O Allah, I love him, so love him too."
>
> Al-Salihi, Subul al-Huda, report 2035 · Seerah report; no grade in this edition, so it is not counted as a hadith

b Joke with the little one and call the child by name.

> Anas said: the Prophet (pbuh) had the best character of all people. I had a little brother called Abu Umayr, who I think had only just been weaned. When the Prophet came he would say: "O Abu Umayr, what did the little bird (nughayr) do?" The nughayr was a small bird he used to play with.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5850 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Join the child's play: put out your tongue, stand the child on your feet and say a play rhyme.
2. Joke with the little one and call the child by name: "What did the little bird do?"
- × **Avoid:** Frightening the child during play.

FACTOR 11

Toys, friends and greeting

Toddlers play side by side but do not yet know how to share or settle a quarrel. Fear of other children they do not know peaks at around eighteen to twenty-one months, and by twenty-three months they manage a shared task with another child much better.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Let the child play with toys, and bring friends to play.

> Aisha said: she used to play with dolls in the Prophet's presence, and when her friends came they would shyly hide from the Prophet, so the Messenger of Allah would send them in to play with her. In one narration: "I used to play with dolls in the house of the Prophet, and they are toys."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2440 · Grade: Sahih

b Greet the children with salam.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed by some children and greeted them with salam. (Thabit, Anas's student, said: Anas also passed by children and greeted them, and said the Prophet used to do this.)

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2168 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Let the child play with toys and dolls, and let friends come and play together.
2. Greet the children with salam.

LAST

"Me", fairness and the family

FACTOR 12

"Me", a good name, and keeping promises

Between eighteen and twenty-four months the child comes to know "me": touching their own nose in the mirror, pointing to themselves in a photo, saying their own name. With "me" come pride, shame and embarrassment.

The child also begins to wait a little and to follow a rule when you are not looking. Children who manage this better at two to four years have a stronger conscience later.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Give the child a good name.

> Ibn Umar reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The names most loved by Allah are Abdullah and Abd al-Rahman."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 4969 (common number 4949) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Keep your promise to the child, even for one date.

> Abdullah bin Amir said: one day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was sitting in our house when my mother called me: "Come here, I will give you something." He asked: "What do you want to give him?" She said: "A date." He said: "If you had not given him anything, a lie would have been written against you."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4991 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Give the child a good name, and call the child by it.
2. When you promise the child something, keep it.
- × **Avoid:** A false promise: "Come, I will give you something", and then giving nothing.

FACTOR 13

Fairness between children

By around sixteen months a child already prefers someone who shares fairly, and is surprised when things are shared unequally. When a new baby comes, the older toddler often clings more, gets angry or acts younger.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Fear Allah and be just between your children.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father gave me a gift. My mother, Amra bint Rawaha, said: "I will not be content until you make the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) a witness." My father went to him and said: "I have given this son of mine a gift, and his mother tells me to make you a witness." He asked: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be just between your children." So my father went back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

b Be fair even in kisses and in the lap.

> Anas said: a man was sitting with the Prophet (pbuh). His son came, and he kissed him and sat him on his lap. Then his daughter came, and he took her and sat her beside him. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "You have not been fair between these two."

Ibn al-Qayyim, Tuhfat al-Mawdud, narration 628 (from Bayhaqi) · Grade: not stated in the edition

c Give the first fruit to the youngest.

> Abu Hurayra said: when the first fruit of the season was brought to the Prophet (pbuh), he would say: "O Allah, bless us in our city, and in our measures, blessing upon blessing." Then he would give it to the youngest child present.

Ibn Abi al-Dunya, Al-Iyal, narration 199 (common number 198) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be just between the children in gifts, kisses and the lap.
2. When new fruit or a treat comes, give it to the youngest first.
- × **Avoid:** Giving a kiss or a gift to one child and not to the other.

FACTOR 14

Mother and father at home

In homes where parents quarrel, children carry more stress, and what harms most is never seeing the parents make up. The mother's bond with the child is shaped by the help or the conflict of the people around her, especially the father.

Children form a bond with the father at the same age as with the mother; fathers often do more of the physical play.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be the best to your family.

> Aisha reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family."

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

b Help with the work of the home.

> Aswad said: I asked Aisha: "What did the Prophet (pbuh) do at home?" She said: "He would be busy helping his family, and when the time for prayer came he would go out to pray."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 644, 5692 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be the best to your family: keep the tie between mother and father gentle at home.
2. Do the work of the home together, and keep the child with you while you do it.

FACTOR 15

The parents' tiredness and worry

A mother's low mood shows in the child: less joy, less play, more stress. Having a toddler is humbling, and the child's hard behaviour is not the parents' failure.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Before sleep, the remembrance the Prophet (pbuh) taught his tired daughter.

> Ali said: Fatima complained of the pain the hand mill caused her hands, and some captives had come to the Prophet (pbuh). She went to ask him but did not find him, so she told Aisha. When he came, Aisha told him. He came to us after we had gone to bed; we began to get up and he said: "Stay where you are." He sat between us until I felt the coolness of his feet on my chest, and said: "Shall I not tell you of something better than what you asked for? When you go to bed, say subhan Allah 33 times, al-hamdu lillah 33 times and Allahu akbar 34 times. That is better for you than a servant."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 5082 (common number 5062) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Seek refuge from worry and grief.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) often made this prayer: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from cowardice and miserliness, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 818 (common number 801) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When tired, before sleep say subhan Allah 33 times, al-hamdu lillah 33 times and Allahu akbar 34 times.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry, grief and the burden of debt.

STAGE 06

Early Childhood

From two years old to six

This stage is for the mother and father of a child from two until six years old, and for the family around them. In these years the child asks "why?", plays pretend, learns right from wrong, makes first friends, and gets ready for school.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Love and closeness

1. Love the child can feel
2. Not pushing the child away while you are busy
3. Welcoming the child back

THEN

Talk, play and feelings

4. Talking with the child, and hearing the child
5. Pretend play and friends
6. Running games
7. Sadness
8. Anger, tantrums and your own temper

THEN

Limits, truth and fairness

9. Limits with gentleness
10. First manners in short words
11. Stopping what is wrong, and saying why
12. Truth and promises
13. Fairness between children
14. Daughters, sons and a good name

LAST

Learning, loss and the home

15. Remembering and learning
16. Loss and grief
17. The home, and the parents' prayers

START HERE

Love and closeness

FACTOR 1

Love the child can feel

Children who believe their parents love them do better, and that warmth softens the harm of hard times. When a parent says goodbye before leaving, a two-year-old cries less than when the parent slips away unseen.

In new situations the child looks at the grown-up's face to know how to react. In the first three years the child needs one or two steady people who are always there.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Hug the child, kiss the child and pray for the child.

Abu Hurayra said: the Prophet (pbuh) went out in the daytime, without speaking to me or I to him, until he reached the market of Banu Qaynuqa. He sat in the courtyard of Fatima's house and said: "Is the little one there? Is the little one there?" She kept him a little while (I thought she was dressing him or washing him). Then he came running, and the Prophet hugged him, kissed him and said: "O Allah, love him, and love whoever loves him."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Buyu, hadith 2016 · Grade: Sahih

b Do not let mercy leave your heart.

> Aisha said: some Bedouins came to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and asked: "Do you kiss your children?" The people said: "Yes." They said: "But by Allah, we do not." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "What can I do if Allah has taken mercy out of your hearts?"

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Fadail, common number 2317 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Take the child in your lap, kiss the child and hug the child.
2. Pray for the child: "O Allah, I love this child, so love this child too."

× **Avoid:** Holding back love, and keeping away from kissing the child.

FACTOR 2

Not pushing the child away while you are busy

At three the child begins to see others as separate people, and love comes with strong feeling and jealousy. Between about three and four the child begins to enjoy talking with brothers, sisters and friends even more than with the mother, but still needs a grown-up close by.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Do not hurry the child, even in prayer.

Shaddad bin al-Had said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came out to us for one of the evening prayers carrying Hasan or Husayn. He put him down, said the takbir and prayed, and in the prayer he made one prostration very long. I raised my head and saw the child on the back of the Messenger of Allah while he was in prostration, so I went back to my prostration. After the prayer the people said: "O Messenger of Allah, you made one prostration so long that we thought something had happened, or that revelation was coming to you." He said: "None of that happened. My son was riding on me, and I did not want to hurry him until he had finished."

Sunan Nasai, Kitab al-Tatbiq, narration 1150 (common number 1141) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Let the child ride on you, and enjoy it.

Ibn Abbas said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was carrying Hasan bin Ali on his shoulder. A man said: "What a fine mount you are riding, boy!" The Prophet said: "And what a fine rider he is."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Manaqib, narration 3791 (common number 3784) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "gharib"; some scholars called one narrator weak in memory

HOW TO DO IT

1. Do not push the child away while you work: keep the child with you, even on your back, and let the child ride on your shoulders.

× **Avoid:** Rushing the child off before the child has had enough.

FACTOR 3

Welcoming the child back

By three, most children settle within a few minutes of being dropped off. What helps is a warm meeting again when you return.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When you come home, go out to the children and lift them up.

> Abdullah bin Ja'far said: when the Prophet (pbuh) came back from a journey, we children would go out to meet him. Whoever reached him first he sat in front of him on his mount. He came to me first and sat me in front of him, then he came to Hasan or Husayn and sat him behind him, and we rode into Madina like that.
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Jihad, narration 2576 (common number 2566) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. When you come back from a journey, meet the children first, and sit whoever reaches you first in front of you.

THEN

Talk, play and feelings

FACTOR 4

Talking with the child, and hearing the child

At two, some children have fifty words and some have five hundred; by six most have around ten thousand. Most of a child's words are the very words the parents use.

Preschoolers ask many questions an hour, most of them to really find out. In homes where talk is mostly "stop" and "no", children learn fewer words, and the parents' tone, warm or harsh, comes out in the child's own speech by three.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Notice the child, ask what is wrong, and speak to the child by name.

> Anas said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to visit us. I had a little brother called Abu Umayr, who had a nughayr (a small bird) that he played with. It died. One day the Prophet saw that he was sad and asked: "What is the matter with him?" They said: "His bird has died." He said: "O Abu Umayr, what did the little bird do?"
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Adab, narration 4989 (common number 4969) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Greet the children with salam.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed by some children and greeted them with salam. (Thabit, Anas's student, said: Anas also passed by children and greeted them, and said the Prophet used to do this.)
>
> Sahih Muslim, hadith 2168 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Speak to the child directly and softly, by name or by a pet name.
2. Listen to the child: ask "What is the matter?" and hear the answer.
3. Greet the children with salam, even when you are only passing by.
- × **Avoid:** Treating talk with the child as too small to bother with.

FACTOR 5

Pretend play and friends

Pretend play peaks at three to four years: a block becomes a phone, a doll becomes a baby. Playing alone is still common at this age and is no cause for worry; imaginary friends are normal.

At first a grown-up starts the pretend game; by about four the child has a "best friend". Children whose fathers play physical games with them without giving orders are among the best liked by other children.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Value the child's own games, and let friends come to play.

> Aisha said: I used to play with dolls in the presence of the Prophet (pbuh), and my friends used to play with me. When the Messenger of Allah came in they would hide out of shyness, and he would send them back to me to play with me.

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5779 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Value the child's own play, with a doll or a pet bird.
2. Let the child's friends come over to play.
- × **Avoid:** Stopping the child's game in a hurry.

FACTOR 6

Running games

Running, jumping and climbing are at their peak at four to five years. By five the child can follow the rules of a game and take turns.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Line the children up for a race, then hug them.

> Abdullah bin al-Harith said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to line up Abdullah, Ubaydullah and Kathir, the sons of al-Abbas, and say: "Whoever reaches me first gets such and such." They would race to him and climb onto his back and chest, and he would kiss them and hold them close.

Musnad Ahmad, narration 1844 (common number 1836) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Line the children up and let them race to you, with a small prize, then hug them when they arrive.

FACTOR 7

Sadness

At this age children show feelings mostly through play. Signs of strain include a change in appetite, bad dreams, headaches or stomach aches, and wetting the bed again.

Children of two already notice when someone is hurt and try to comfort them. Naming a feeling and understanding it settles a child faster than arguing.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a See the child's sadness, ask about it, and lighten it.

> Anas said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to visit us. I had a little brother called Abu Umayr, who had a nughayr (a small bird) that he played with. It died. One day the Prophet saw that he was sad and asked: "What is the matter with him?" They said: "His bird has died." He said: "O Abu Umayr, what did the little bird do?"
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Adab, narration 4989 (common number 4969) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Notice the child's sadness and ask: "What is the matter?"

FACTOR 8

Anger, tantrums and your own temper

Hitting and pushing are at their highest in life at about two years. In the "terrible twos" every other word is "no"; tantrums are common at two and three and fade by four or five.

In the middle of anger, reasoning does not work. At four a child may shout "I hate you!", which means "help me sort out my feelings". Saying sorry begins to make sense at four.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The strong one controls himself in anger.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) asked: "Whom do you count as a strong wrestler among you?" They said: "The one whom people cannot throw down." He said: "No, it is the one who controls himself when he is angry."

Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Adab, narration 4799 (common number 4779) · Grade: not stated in the edition

b "Do not get angry."

Abu Hurayra said: a man came to the Prophet (pbuh) and said: "Teach me something, and do not make it long, so that I may remember it." He said: "Do not get angry." The man asked again several times, and each time he said: "Do not get angry."

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Birr wa al-Sila, narration 2021 (common number 2020) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih gharib"

HOW TO DO IT

1. When anger comes, control yourself.
2. × **Avoid:** Taking revenge or going too far when you are angry.

THEN

Limits, truth and fairness

FACTOR 9

Limits with gentleness

Before three a child can obey only when the instruction fits what the child already wants to do; expecting obedience from a two-year-old is a mistake. At three a child can say a new rule out loud and still follow the old one; this is normal.

Physical punishment brings quick obedience but no change inside, and is linked with aggression, anxiety and a weaker conscience. Shaming a child after an accident teaches hiding, not learning.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Allah gives for gentleness what He does not give for harshness.

> Abdullah bin Mughaffal reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Allah is gentle and loves gentleness, and He gives for gentleness what He does not give for harshness."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 476 (common number 472) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

b Never "uff", never "why did you do that?"

> Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, he never said 'Why did you do that?', and he never said 'Why did you not do that?'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

c He never struck anyone with his hand.

> Aisha said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) never struck anyone with his hand, not a woman and not a servant, except when fighting in the path of Allah. When someone harmed him he never took revenge for himself; only when something Allah had made sacred was violated would he act, for Allah's sake."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2328 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose gentleness: Allah gives for gentleness what He does not give for harshness.
- × **Avoid:** Hitting.
- × **Avoid:** Questioning the child with "Why did you do that?"
- × **Avoid:** Harshness.

FACTOR 10

First manners in short words

Children copy the people they admire. Short, clear words given at the moment work far better at this age than long lectures.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Teach manners in a few clear words.

> Umar bin Abi Salama said: "I was a boy being brought up by the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), and my hand used to wander all over the dish. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to me: 'Boy, say Bismillah, eat with your right hand, and eat from what is in front of you.' After that, that was how I always ate."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Atima, hadith 5061-5063 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Teach eating manners in short sentences: "Say Bismillah, eat with your right hand, eat from what is in front of you."

FACTOR 11

Stopping what is wrong, and saying why

Self-control grows slowly. At four, children understand what they should do but choose the worst way to wait. By five or six many can hide the treat, sing a song or think of something else to help them wait.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Take out what is not allowed at once, and give the reason.

> Abu Hurayra said: at harvest time dates were brought to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) until there was a heap of them. Hasan and Husayn began to play with the dates, and one of them picked up a date and put it in his mouth. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) saw him, took it out of his mouth, and said: "Do you not know that the family of Muhammad do not eat charity?" In another narration he said "Kakh, kakh!" so the child would spit it out.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1414, 1420 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When something not allowed goes into the mouth, take it out at once and give the reason: "Do you not know that..."

FACTOR 12

Truth and promises

Real lying begins around four, when the child understands that another person can be fooled. This is a sign the child is learning that others have minds; four-year-olds are not liars.

Children copy the parents' words more than their deeds, including the parents' own "white lies".

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep your word to the child.

> Abdullah bin Amir said: one day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was sitting in our house when my mother called me: "Come here, I will give you something." He asked: "What do you want to give him?" She said: "A date." He said: "If you had not given him anything, a lie would have been written against you."
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4991 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep every promise you make to the child, even small ones.
2. × **Avoid:** A false promise to calm the child: "Come, I will give you something", and then giving nothing.

FACTOR 13

Fairness between children

Three-year-olds already share equally when they can. By five, children choose equal shares in work, votes and gifts; by six to eight they will throw something away rather than accept an unequal share. Between five and seven they begin to look at intentions and feel sorry for mistakes.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Fear Allah and be just between your children.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father gave me a gift. My mother, Amra bint Rawaha, said: "I will not be content until you make the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) a witness." My father went to him and said: "I have given this son of mine a gift, and his mother tells me to make you a witness." He asked: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be just between your children." So my father went back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

b The first fruit goes to the youngest.

Abu Hurayra said: when people saw the first fruit of the season they brought it to the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). When he took it he said: "O Allah, bless us in our fruit, bless us in our city, and bless us in our measures." Then he would call the youngest child he saw and give that fruit to him.

Jami Tirmidhi, Abwab al-Daawat, narration 3455 (common number 3454) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Give gifts equally to all the children.
2. Give new fruit to the youngest child first.
- × **Avoid:** Giving a gift to one child and leaving the others out.

FACTOR 14

Daughters, sons and a good name

By three a child knows whether they are a boy or a girl, and by four believes "girls are always girls". Parents' sweeping sayings such as "boys don't cry" make these ideas seem fixed by nature.

At this age a child describes themselves by outward things: "I am Tommy, I am four." Children who are patiently encouraged try harder; children who are criticised give up sooner and feel ashamed.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Bring up daughters well.

Aisha said: a woman came to me with her two daughters, asking for something. I had nothing but one date, so I gave it to her. She divided it between her two daughters, then got up and left. When the Prophet (pbuh) came in I told him, and he said: "Whoever is put in charge of any of these daughters and treats them well, they will be a shield for him from the Fire."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Adab, hadith 5649 · Grade: Sahih

b Do not humiliate a daughter or prefer a son over her.

Ibn Abbas reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever has a daughter, and does not bury her alive, does not humiliate her, and does not prefer his son over her, Allah will admit him to Paradise."

Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Adab, narration 5166 (common number 5146) · Grade: not stated in the edition

c Change a name with a bad meaning.

> Ibn Umar reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) changed the name Asiya ("disobedient") and said: "You are Jamila (beautiful)." In another narration: a daughter of Umar was called Asiya, and the Messenger of Allah named her Jamila.
>
> Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Adab, common number 2139 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Bring up a daughter with kindness.
2. Do not prefer a son over a daughter, or a daughter over a son.
3. Give the child a good name, and change a name with a bad meaning.

× **Avoid:** Humiliating a daughter.

LAST

Learning, loss and the home

FACTOR 15

Remembering and learning

A five-year-old remembers what they saw and heard, and carries it for life. Children read to often in the early years use richer language in their own stories by five.

Pushing a child to read before four or five can be too early. By six, the start of school comes next: every lesson at school has a history in what the child learned before.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A five-year-old remembers.

> Mahmud bin al-Rabi said: "I remember the Prophet (pbuh) taking water from a bucket into his mouth and playfully spraying it onto my face, and I was five years old at the time."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Ilm, hadith 77 · Grade: Sahih

b Teach a short remembrance for the morning.

> A daughter of the Prophet (pbuh) said that he used to teach her, saying: "In the morning say: 'Subhan Allah wa bi-hamdih, la quwwata illa billah, ma sha Allah kana wa ma lam yasha lam yakun' (Glory and praise be to Allah; there is no power except with Allah; what Allah wills happens and what He does not will does not happen). Whoever says it in the morning is protected until evening, and whoever says it in the evening is protected until morning."

Sunan Abu Dawud, Kitab al-Adab, narration 5095 (common number 5075) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep even a five-year-old with you: what the child sees and hears is remembered.
2. Teach the child a short prayer or remembrance.

FACTOR 16

Loss and grief

Loss of a pet, a grandparent or a parent comes to some children at this age. Children show grief mostly through play and behaviour. If there is no easing at all four to six weeks after a loss, the books say to get help.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Tears in grief are mercy.

Usama bin Zayd said: a daughter of the Prophet (pbuh) sent word to him that her son was dying and asked him to come. He sent his salam and said: "To Allah belongs what He takes and what He gives, and everything with Him has a fixed term, so let her be patient and hope for reward." She sent again, asking him by oath to come. He got up and went, with Sa'd bin Ubada, Mu'adh bin Jabal, Ubayy bin Ka'b, Zayd bin Thabit and others. The child was lifted up to the Messenger of Allah, his breath rattling, and the Prophet's eyes flowed with tears. Sa'd said: "O Messenger of Allah, what is this?" He said: "This is mercy that Allah has placed in the hearts of His servants, and Allah has mercy only on those of His servants who are merciful."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Janaiz, hadith 1224 · Grade: Sahih

Anas bin Malik said: we went with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) to Abu Sayf the blacksmith, the husband of the woman nursing Ibrahim. The Messenger of Allah took Ibrahim, kissed him and smelled him. Later we went again, and Ibrahim was dying, and tears began to flow from the eyes of the Messenger of Allah. Abd al-Rahman bin Awf said: "You too, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "O Ibn Awf, this is mercy." Then he said: "The eye sheds tears and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. O Ibrahim, we are saddened by your parting."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab al-Janaiz, hadith 1241 · Grade: Sahih

b Keep the grieving child close with love.

After his mother died, Abd al-Muttalib (the Prophet's grandfather) kept the Prophet (pbuh) with him and was gentler with him than with his own children. He kept him close, in private and at bedtime. When the boy sat on his bed and others moved him, Abd al-Muttalib would say: "Leave my son." Before eating he would say: "Bring me my son." The Prophet was later asked: "Do you remember the death of Abd al-Muttalib?" He said: "Yes, I was eight years old then"; Umm Ayman saw him crying behind the funeral bier.

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat · Seerah report; no grade in this edition, so it is not counted as a hadith

A rug was spread for Abd al-Muttalib in the shade of the Kaaba, and out of respect his sons sat around it and no one sat on it. The Prophet (pbuh), a sturdy little boy, would come and sit on it; his uncles began to move him away, and Abd al-Muttalib would say: "Leave my son. By Allah, he has a standing." Then he would sit him beside him on the rug, stroke his back, and be pleased with whatever he saw him do.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade in this edition, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Hug the child who comes back after being lost.

A man doing tawaf heard Abd al-Muttalib praying and asked who he was. He was told: "Abd al-Muttalib; he sent his grandson to look for a lost camel, and whatever task he sends him on, the boy completes it." Soon the boy came back, and his grandfather hugged him and said: "I will not send you on any errand again."

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat · Seerah report; no grade in this edition, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. In grief, let tears come: "This is mercy."
2. When a child loses a parent, keep the child close with love.
3. When a lost child is found, hug the child.

FACTOR 17

The home, and the parents' prayers

At five, a father's involvement was linked with more empathy in the child many years later. The tone of the home, warm or harsh, is what the child takes in.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Help with the work of the home.

> Aswad said: I asked Aisha: "What did the Prophet (pbuh) do at home?" She said: "He would be busy helping his family, and when the time for prayer came he would go out to pray."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 644, 5692 · Grade: Sahih

b A father's prayer for his child is answered.

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Three prayers are answered, there is no doubt about them: the prayer of the one who is wronged, the prayer of the traveller, and the prayer of a father for his child."

Sunan Ibn Majah, Kitab al-Dua, narration 3865 (common number 3862) · Grade: not stated in the edition

c Do not pray against your children.

Jabir said: we went out with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) on the expedition of Buwat. A man of the Ansar, whose turn it was to ride a camel, made it kneel and mounted it; when it was slow to rise he said: "Go on, may Allah curse you!" The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Who is this cursing his camel? Get down from it, and do not travel with us on a cursed animal. Do not pray against yourselves, do not pray against your children, and do not pray against your wealth, in case it falls at a moment when Allah is asked and He answers your prayer."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Zuhd, common number 3009 · Grade: Sahih

d Seek Allah's protection for the children.

Ibn Abbas said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to seek protection for Hasan and Husayn, saying: "Your forefather (Ibrahim) used to seek protection for Ismail and Ishaq with these words: I seek refuge for you in the perfect words of Allah from every devil and every harmful creature, and from every evil eye."

Sahih Bukhari, Kitab Ahadith al-Anbiya, hadith 3191 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Help with the work of the home, and get up when it is time for prayer.
2. Pray for your children: a father's prayer for his child is answered.
3. Seek protection for the children with the prayer: "I seek refuge for you in the perfect words of Allah..."
- × **Avoid:** Praying against your own children.

STAGE 07

Middle Childhood

From seven years old to twelve

This stage is for the mother and father of a child from seven until twelve years old, and for the family around them. In these years the child learns to read and to work, makes real friends, builds a conscience, and comes to the edge of puberty.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Learning and real work

1. Reading and learning
2. Work, skills and responsibility

THEN

Guiding behaviour

3. Gentle discipline, no hitting
4. Promises and honesty
5. Anger and self-control
6. Morals and conscience

THEN

Friends, feelings and fairness

7. Friends, peers and bullying
8. Feelings, grief and loss
9. Fairness and siblings
10. Respect, voice and choice

LAST

Growing up

11. Father time and trust
12. Puberty and body safety
13. Phones and screens
14. New settings and home stress

START HERE

Learning and real work

FACTOR 1

Reading and learning

At seven and eight the main task is decoding: turning letters into sounds and sounds into words. A child who still cannot sound out words at the end of seven very often still reads poorly at nine or ten.

Around nine the task changes from learning to read to reading to learn, and many children slip for a while. The strongest way to study is to answer questions from memory, not to read the same page again. Long sessions at once tire the child and make them dislike learning.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a 'Tell me the tree that is like a Muslim'

Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) asked: "There is a tree whose leaves do not fall, and it is like a Muslim. Tell me, which is it?" People began naming desert trees. It came to my mind that it was the date palm, but I was too shy to speak (in front of the elders). They said: "Tell us, Messenger of Allah." He said: "It is the date palm." Later I told my father Umar what had come to my mind. He said: "If you had said it, that would have been dearer to me than such-and-such (a great treasure)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 61, 72, 131 · Grade: Sahih

b He repeated things three times to be understood

> Anas reports that when the Prophet (pbuh) said something he would repeat it three times so that it was fully understood, and when he came to a group of people he greeted them three times.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 94-95 · Grade: Sahih

c The Badr captives' ransom: teach children to write

> Ibn Sa'd (from Amir al-Sha'bi): the ransom for the captives of Badr was up to 4,000. A captive who had no money was told to teach the children of the Ansar to write; the people of Makka could write and the people of Madina could not. Each such captive was given ten children of Madina, and when they had become skilled (at writing), that was his ransom. (Zayd bin Thabit was one of those who learned this way.)

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 2:15-16 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

d He held Ibn Abbas to his chest: a prayer for knowledge

> Ibn Abbas said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) held me to his chest and said: 'O Allah, teach him the Book.'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 75 · Grade: Sahih

e 'The most beloved deed is the regular one, even if small'

Aisha said: the Prophet (pbuh) was asked: "Which deed is most beloved to Allah?" He said: "The most regular, even if it is small." And he said: "Take on only as much as you are able to."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6100 · Grade: Sahih

f Zayd bin Thabit learned a new script in half a month

Zayd bin Thabit said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) told me to learn the writing of the Jews, saying: "By Allah, I do not trust the Jews with my letters." Half a month had not passed before I had learned it. After that, when he wrote to the Jews I wrote for him, and when they wrote to him I read their letters to him.

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2715 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Start lessons with a question: 'tell me, which is it?', then give the answer
2. Say the important thing three times, clearly
3. A little every day, never skipped, only as much as he can bear
4. Hold him and pray: 'O Allah, teach him the Book'
5. Treat teaching him to read and write as a great task; if you can't teach it, find someone who can
6. For a new language or script, a clear purpose and daily practice

× **Avoid:** Saying it once in a hurry and assuming he understood

× **Avoid:** Piling on more than he can bear in one day

× **Avoid:** Accepting a shy child's silence

FACTOR 2

Work, skills and responsibility

For these years the big question in the child's mind is: can I do real things? Real work with a real result makes a child feel capable. Constant failure or comparison makes a child feel "I am no good at anything".

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The Prophet (pbuh) herded sheep for wages

> Abu Hurayra reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Allah did not send any prophet who did not herd sheep." His companions asked: "And you too?" He said: "Yes. I used to herd the sheep of the people of Makka for a few qirats (a small wage)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2143 · Grade: Sahih

b Anas: 'I was ten when the Prophet (pbuh) came to Madina'

> Anas said: "I was ten years old when the Prophet (pbuh) came to Madina, and I served him for ten years (until his death)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5884 · Grade: Sahih

c He showed a boy how to skin a sheep: 'Move aside, let me show you'

> Abu Sa'id said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed a boy who was skinning a sheep. He said to him: "Move aside, let me show you." He put his hand between the skin and the flesh and pushed it in until his arm disappeared up to the armpit. Then he went and led the people in prayer.

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 185 · Grade: not stated in the edition

d Anas forgot his errand to play: 'Unays, did you go?'

Anas said: one day the Prophet (pbuh) sent me on an errand. I said, "By Allah, I won't go", though in my heart I meant to go. I set out, and passed some boys playing in the market (and stopped there). Suddenly the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of the back of my neck from behind. I turned and he was laughing. He said: "Unays (his pet name), did you go where I sent you?" I said: "Yes, I am going now, Messenger of Allah." Anas also said: "I served him for nine years, and I do not remember him ever saying about anything I did, 'why did you do that?', or about anything I left, 'why didn't you do that?'"

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2310 · Grade: Sahih

e At home he was busy serving his family

Al-Aswad said: I asked Aisha: "What did the Prophet (pbuh) do at home?" She said: "He was busy serving his family, and when the time for prayer came he went out to pray."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 644, 5692 · Grade: Sahih

f Anas: ten years of service, never an 'uff'

Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, and he never said 'why did you do that?' or 'why didn't you do that?'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

g He taunted a man about his mother: 'you have ignorance in you'

Al-Ma'rur said: I saw Abu Dharr wearing the same kind of garment as his servant. I asked about it and he said: I insulted a man and taunted him about his mother. The Prophet (pbuh) said to me: "Abu Dharr, did you taunt him about his mother? You are a man who still has some of the ways of ignorance (jahiliyya) in you. Your servants are your brothers... feed them from what you eat, clothe them from what you wear, and do not burden them with more than they can bear; if you do, help them."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 30 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Give real work with a real result (like herding sheep), with a small wage if you can
2. Around ten, let him serve alongside an adult in the house's work
3. Teach a skill by doing it in front of him: 'move aside, let me show you', then let him do it
4. Send him on errands; if he forgets, remind him with a smile: 'did you go?'
5. Father does housework himself

× **Avoid:** 'Why did you do that? Why didn't you do that?' after a task

× **Avoid:** Tasks beyond his strength; if you give one, help him

THEN

Guiding behaviour

FACTOR 3

Gentle discipline, no hitting

The best results come from warmth, clear limits and an explanation together. Hitting and shaming are linked with harm. Telling a child how their action made someone else feel is what builds a conscience.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a 'Boy, say Bismillah, eat with your right hand'

> Umar bin Abi Salama said: "I was a boy in the care of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh), and my hand used to wander all over the dish. The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to me: 'Boy, say Bismillah, eat with your right hand, and eat from what is in front of you.' After that, that was always how I ate."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5061-5063 · Grade: Sahih

b He never struck a servant with his hand

> Aisha said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) never struck anyone with his hand, not a woman and not a servant, except when fighting in the path of Allah. When someone harmed him he never took revenge for himself; only when something Allah had made sacred was violated would he act, for Allah's sake."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2328 · Grade: Sahih

c 'Gentleness beautifies whatever it is in'

Aisha reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Gentleness is not in anything except that it beautifies it, and it is not taken out of anything except that it spoils it." In one narration Aisha was riding a stubborn camel and kept jerking it around, and the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to her: "Be gentle."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2594 · Grade: Sahih

d 'Make things easy, not hard'

Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 69 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Correct with one short sentence that says what to do: 'Say Bismillah, eat with your right hand, eat from in front of you'
2. Remind about a forgotten task with a smile: 'Unays, did you go?'
3. Gentleness in everything, especially when he is defiant
4. Make religion and learning easy, give good news
- × **Avoid:** Hitting
- × **Avoid:** 'Uff', 'why did you do that?', 'why didn't you?'
- × **Avoid:** Harshness that drives him away from religion or home

FACTOR 4

Promises and honesty

In homes where promises are broken, a child learns that waiting is pointless. One lie or one act of cheating is common at this age; honesty depends on the situation as well as on character.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a 'Come, I'll give you something': a false promise is a lie

> Abdullah bin Amir said: one day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was sitting in our house when my mother called me: "Come here, I'll give you something." He asked her: "What did you mean to give him?" She said: "A date." He said: "Listen: if you had given him nothing, a lie would have been written against you."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4991 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b By young manhood his people called him 'al-Amin'

> Ibn Sa'd: (raised by Abu Talib) he grew up to be the most dignified of his people, the best in character, the best neighbour, the most forbearing, the most truthful and the most trustworthy; he kept away from foul talk and from harming others, and never fought or quarrelled with anyone, until his people named him "al-Amin" (the trustworthy).

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:95-97 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c 'Whoever cheats is not of me'

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed a heap of grain, put his hand into it and his fingers came out damp. He said: "What is this, owner of the grain?" He said: "Rain fell on it, Messenger of Allah." He said: "Then why didn't you put it on top so people could see it? Whoever cheats is not of me."
>
> Sahih Muslim, hadith 102 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. If you tell him 'I'll give you something', give it, even if it is one date
2. Be truthful and trustworthy yourself; make honesty the household's name
3. Speak plainly about cheating in tests and games: 'whoever cheats is not of us'
- × **Avoid:** False promises to call him or quiet him

FACTOR 5

Anger and self-control

Self-restraint grows fast between six and ten. Strong, uncontrolled impulsiveness at ten, especially in boys, points to later trouble far more than school ability does.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Words for the moment of anger: 'A'udhu billah'

Sulayman bin Surad said: we were sitting with the Prophet (pbuh) when two men began insulting each other; one of them was red in the face with anger. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I know a phrase which, if he said it, would take away what he feels: 'A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim' (I seek refuge in Allah from the accursed devil)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5764 · Grade: Sahih

b When angry, sit; if not enough, lie down

Abu Dharr said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) told us: "When one of you becomes angry while standing, let him sit down. If the anger leaves him (good); if not, let him lie down."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4782 · Grade: not stated in the edition (Abu Dawud: the mursal version is sounder)

c The strong one controls himself in anger

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong one is not the one who throws others in wrestling; the strong one is the one who controls himself when he is angry."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5763 · Grade: Sahih

d 'Do not get angry' (repeated)

Abu Hurayra said: a man said to the Prophet (pbuh): "Advise me." He said: "Do not get angry." The man asked again several times, and each time he said: "Do not get angry."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5765 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Teach him to say 'A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim' when angry
2. When angry: if standing, sit; if it doesn't pass, lie down
3. Teach what real strength is: holding yourself back; praise that, not winning
4. Keep advice short and repeated: 'do not get angry'
- × **Avoid:** Answering anger with insults and anger
- × **Avoid:** 'Be a man, hit him back'

FACTOR 6

Morals and conscience

In these years a child moves from "avoid being punished" to "be good and keep the rules". The child learns standards when the grown-up lives by them; fear of what people think does not build a conscience inside.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Advice to young Ibn Abbas, riding behind him

> Ibn Abbas said: one day I was riding behind the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and he said: "Boy, I will teach you some words. Guard Allah (His commands) and He will guard you; guard Allah and you will find Him in front of you. When you ask, ask Allah; when you seek help, seek help from Allah. Know that if the whole nation gathered to benefit you, they could only benefit you with what Allah has already written for you; and if they gathered to harm you, they could only harm you with what Allah has already written against you. The pens have been lifted and the pages have dried."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2516 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

b Ibn Abbas at the night prayer: moved gently to the right place

> Ibn Abbas said: I spent the night at the house of my aunt Maymuna (the Prophet's wife). The Prophet (pbuh) got up to pray at night, and I stood up to pray with him, on his left. He took hold of my head (during the prayer) and moved me round to his right.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 665-667 · Grade: Sahih

c Prayer at seven, firmness at ten, separate beds

> Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather: the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Command your children to pray when they are seven, strike them over it when they are ten, and separate their beds." (In Sabra's narration, 494: "when he completes his tenth year.")

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 494-495 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Alone, walking or riding together, short words: 'guard Allah and He will guard you'
2. Let him see you worship; if he stands in the wrong place, gently move him to the right one
3. Command prayer from seven
4. Do it first yourself: housework, and prayer on time

× **Avoid:** Scolding or mocking his mistakes in prayer

THEN

Friends, feelings and fairness

FACTOR 7

Friends, peers and bullying

Friends are the strongest influence outside the home in these years. Some children stay without a friend year after year. The quality of friendships at ten is linked with how a person values themselves in their twenties. Around eleven, cliques and bullying rise.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a 'A person follows the way of his close friend'

> Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A person is on the way (religion) of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2378 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

b A good friend is a perfume seller, a bad one a blacksmith's bellows

> Abu Musa reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A good companion and a bad companion are like the one carrying musk and the one blowing a blacksmith's bellows. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy some, or at least you will enjoy a pleasant smell. The one with the bellows will either burn your clothes or you will get a foul smell from him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5214 · Grade: Sahih

c He passed some boys and greeted them

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed by some children and greeted them with salam. (Thabit adds that Anas did the same when he passed children, and said the Prophet (pbuh) used to do it.)
>
> Sahih Muslim, hadith 2168 · Grade: Sahih

d 'Want for your brother what you want for yourself'

> Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of you (truly) believes until he wants for his brother what he wants for himself."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 13 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Know his friends and help him choose: 'look at whom you befriend'
2. Tell him the perfume seller and the bellows
3. Greet boys at play when you pass them
4. Teach him: want for your friend what you want for yourself

× **Avoid:** Taunts about someone's mother, colour, family or poverty

FACTOR 8

Feelings, grief and loss

Recognising a feeling, naming it and listening to it teaches a child to manage it. Children of eight to eleven often blame themselves for a death or for a family breaking apart. Low mood starts to rise between ten and thirteen.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a His grandfather's love; at 8 he wept behind the bier

Ibn Sa'd: after his mother's death his grandfather Abd al-Muttalib took him in and was gentler with him than with his own children; he kept him beside him in private and when he slept. Before eating he would say: "Bring me my son." The Prophet (pbuh) was asked: "Do you remember Abd al-Muttalib's death?" He said: "Yes, I was eight." Umm Ayman saw him weeping behind his grandfather's bier.

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:94-95 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

b Abu Talib: poor, yet kept him close and took him on the journey

Ibn Sa'd: after his grandfather, Abu Talib took him in. Abu Talib was poor, but loved him more than his own children; the boy slept beside his bed, and wherever Abu Talib went he took him along. Food at home was scarce, yet Abu Talib would say: "Wait until my son comes" (and then they all ate together). Ibn Hisham: when Abu Talib set out for Syria, the boy clung to him, and Abu Talib said: "By Allah, I will take him with me; he will not be parted from me, and I will never be parted from him."

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:95-97; Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira 1:318-319 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c His son Ibrahim's death: 'the eye weeps, the heart grieves'

> Anas said: we went with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) to (his son) Ibrahim as he was dying, and tears began to flow from the eyes of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). Abd al-Rahman bin Awf said: "You too, Messenger of Allah?" He said: "Ibn Awf, this is mercy." Then he said: "The eye weeps and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. Ibrahim, we are saddened by your parting."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1241 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Don't hide tears in grief; let him see you weep and say 'the eye weeps, the heart grieves'
2. Don't keep him away from grief; include him at the funeral and in the prayers
3. After a loss, one warm adult stays close: let him sleep near you, take him with you
- × **Avoid:** Advice to hold back tears (Ibn Awf asked 'you too?' and he answered 'this is mercy')
- × **Avoid:** Leaving him alone in the days of grief

FACTOR 9

Fairness and siblings

Rivalry between brothers and sisters rises in these years, and so does a fierce sense of fairness, around ten. Favouritism and comparison do lasting damage.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Nu'man's gift: 'be fair between your children'

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father gave me a gift. My mother, Amra bint Rawaha, said: "I will not accept it until you make the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) a witness." My father went to him and said: "I have given this son of mine a gift, and his mother asked me to make you a witness." He asked: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be fair between your children." My father came back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

b The cup: he asked the youngest boy's permission

Sahl bin Sa'd said: a cup was brought to the Prophet (pbuh) and he drank from it. On his right was the youngest boy present, and the elders were on his left. He said: "Boy, will you allow me to give this to the elders first?" The boy said: "Messenger of Allah, I will not give anyone preference over myself in my share from you." So he handed the cup to him.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2224, 5297 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Gifts, money, things: equal for all the children
2. Don't give away what is one child's right without asking him
- × **Avoid:** Giving to one child and not the others

FACTOR 10

Respect, voice and choice

Parents and child now begin to share control: the parents watch over, and the child makes everyday decisions. Asking the child's opinion and giving them a voice builds self-respect; a shy child needs chances little by little.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a His grandfather's mat: 'Leave my son alone'

Ibn Hisham: a mat was spread for Abd al-Muttalib in the shade of the Ka'ba; his sons sat around it out of respect and no one sat on it. The Prophet (pbuh), then a boy, would come and sit on it. His uncles would try to move him, and Abd al-Muttalib would say: "Leave my son alone; by Allah, he has a standing." Then he would seat him beside him on the mat, stroke his back, and be pleased with whatever he saw him do.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira 1:305 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

b To little Abu Umayr: 'What happened to the nughayr?'

Anas said: the Prophet (pbuh) had the best character of all people. I had a little brother called Abu Umayr, who (I think) had just been weaned. Whenever the Prophet (pbuh) came he would say: "Abu Umayr, what did the nughayr do?" (The nughayr was a little bird he used to play with.)

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5850 · Grade: Sahih

c The boy Zayd bin Haritha was given the choice

> Ibn Hisham: Zayd bin Haritha was a boy when he was brought to Makka as a slave; Khadija gave him to the Prophet (pbuh), who freed him and took him as his son. When Zayd's father came searching for him, the Prophet (pbuh) gave Zayd the choice: "If you wish, stay with me; if you wish, go with your father." Zayd said: "I will stay with you."

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira 2:86-87 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the right is his, ask his permission and accept his 'no'
2. Give him a place among the elders: 'leave my son alone'
3. Encourage the shy one: 'I wish you had said it'
4. Ask about what he loves, by an affectionate name
5. Where the decision is his, give him the choice and honour it

× **Avoid:** Moving him out of the elders' place

LAST

Growing up

FACTOR 11

Father time and trust

What protects a child from going wrong is that the parents know where the child is and with whom, and that knowledge comes from the child telling them, not from spying. A father's warm presence matters a great deal at this age.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a He seated young Abdullah bin Ja'far behind him and told him a secret

Abdullah bin Ja'far said: "One day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) seated me behind him on his mount and told me something in confidence, which I have never told anyone."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2429 · Grade: Sahih

b Anas kept the Prophet's (pbuh) secret, even from his mother

Anas said: I was playing with the boys when the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came, greeted us, and sent me on an errand. I was late getting home. My mother asked: "What kept you?" I said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) sent me on an errand." She asked: "What was it?" I said: "It is a secret." She said: "Then never tell anyone the secret of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh)."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2482 · Grade: Sahih

c He kissed Hasan: 'whoever shows no mercy...'

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) kissed (his grandson) Hasan bin Ali while al-Aqra' bin Habis was sitting with him. Al-Aqra' said: "I have ten children and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) looked at him and said: "Whoever shows no mercy is shown no mercy."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5651 · Grade: Sahih

d 'Each of you is a shepherd'

> Ibn Umar reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Each of you is a shepherd and each of you will be asked about his flock... A man is the shepherd of his household and will be asked about them; a woman is the shepherd of her husband's house and children and will be asked about them."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2416 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Take him riding with you, behind you, and talk alone
2. Trust him with something small: a secret, a task
3. Kiss him and hug him, even as he grows
4. Treat watching over the household as your own job: 'I will be asked'

× **Avoid:** The 'I have ten children and never kissed one' attitude

× **Avoid:** Pressuring him to reveal something he was trusted with

FACTOR 12

Puberty and body safety

Puberty usually begins around eleven in boys and earlier in girls, and the first attractions come around ten. Harm to a child's body comes mostly from people the child knows, rarely from strangers.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Al-Fadl's gaze strayed: he quietly turned his face

> Ibn Abbas said: (on the Farewell Pilgrimage) al-Fadl (bin Abbas) was riding behind the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). A woman of the tribe of Khath'am came to ask a question. Al-Fadl began looking at her and she at him, and the Prophet (pbuh) kept turning al-Fadl's face to the other side, and answered the woman's question.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1442, 1755 · Grade: Sahih

b Ibn Umar: refused at 14, allowed at 15

> Ibn Umar said: "The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) reviewed me on the day of Uhud when I was fourteen, and did not allow me (to join the army). Then he reviewed me on the day of the Trench when I was fifteen, and allowed me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2521 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Separate beds at ten
2. If his gaze strays, quietly turn him away; never shame him in front of others
3. New responsibility matched to his age

FACTOR 13

Phones and screens

Children of eight to twelve spend hours a day on screens for entertainment. The books argue for less screen time, devices out of the bedroom at night, and a later first smartphone, though this is debated. The parents' own phone habits count too.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Two blessings: health and free time

> Ibn Abbas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "There are two blessings in which many people are at a loss: health and free time."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6049 · Grade: Sahih

b Leaving what does not concern you

> Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Part of the excellence of a person's Islam is leaving what does not concern him."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2317 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "gharib"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Treat free time as a blessing and fill it with something of benefit
2. Teach him to leave what is of no use to him

FACTOR 14

New settings and home stress

At eleven or twelve the move to a new school often hits marks, interests and self-esteem. Hardship and stress at home affect learning and behaviour. The strongest protection is at least one warm, steady grown-up.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a At 12, the journey to Syria with his uncle

Ibn Sa'd: at twelve the Prophet (pbuh) went to Syria with his uncle Abu Talib (in a trading caravan). Another report: when Abu Talib was leaving, the boy said: "Uncle, with whom are you leaving me here? I have no mother to raise me and no one to shelter me." Abu Talib's heart softened and he seated him behind him and took him along. At Busra the monk Bahira told Abu Talib: "Do not take him further; there is danger from the Jews", so Abu Talib finished his trading quickly and brought him back to Makka.

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:95-97, 120-121 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

b 'I and the one who cares for an orphan will be like this in Paradise'

Sahl bin Sa'd reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "I and the one who looks after an orphan will be in Paradise like this", and he held up his index and middle fingers together.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5659 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. In poverty or hardship, don't let love and closeness shrink; eat together
2. The first time he enters a big new world, a trusted adult goes with him; if there is danger, bring him back
3. Be the support of an orphan or lonely child in the family

× **Avoid:** Leaving him alone in a new setting

STAGE 08

The Teenage Years

From thirteen to eighteen

This stage is for a young person from thirteen until eighteen years old, and for the mother and father beside them. In these years the body changes, the mind learns to think like an adult, friends matter most, and the young person begins to ask "who am I?"

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

A body and mind that are changing

1. Puberty and privacy
2. A brain being rebuilt, and hot decisions
3. Moods, anger and stress

THEN

Home and friends

4. With the parents
5. Friends and peers

THEN

Who I am

6. Attraction, the gaze and modesty
7. Who I am, and what I stand for
8. Faith
9. School, learning and first work

LAST

Risks to guard against

10. Intoxicants
11. Mental health
12. Hard experiences

START HERE

A body and mind that are changing

FACTOR 1

Puberty and privacy

The order of puberty is almost always the same, but the age can vary by several years; it usually takes about four years from start to finish. Height and weight jump, and the first feelings of attraction come.

Long stress at home and quarrels with the mother are linked with puberty coming earlier; a good bond between father and daughter is linked with it coming later. At the start of puberty many girls lose self-esteem, and remarks about the body, even in fun, make it worse.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Separate the beds, and keep the habit of prayer.

> Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather: the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Command your children to pray when they are seven, strike them over it when they are ten, and separate their beds." (In Sabra's narration, 494: "when he completes his tenth year.")
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 494-495 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Separate the beds, and keep the habit of prayer.

FACTOR 2

A brain being rebuilt, and hot decisions

The brain does not grow bigger in these years; it reorganises itself. The part that plans and holds back is the last to mature, in the mid-twenties, so teenagers need more effort for the same self-control.

Feelings and friends act like an accelerator that runs ahead of the brakes. Rewards feel sweeter at this age, and teenagers learn less from punishment than from reward, so encouragement works better than fear. Teenagers also see themselves through others' eyes for the first time, and self-consciousness is at its highest.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Teach thinking through questions.

Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) asked: "There is a tree whose leaves do not fall, and it is like a Muslim. Tell me, which is it?" People began naming desert trees. It came to my mind that it was the date palm, but I was too shy to speak (in front of the elders). They said: "Tell us, Messenger of Allah." He said: "It is the date palm." Later I told my father Umar what had come to my mind. He said: "If you had said it, that would have been dearer to me than such-and-such (a great treasure)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 61, 72, 131 · Grade: Sahih

b Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

> Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Teach the young person to think by asking questions first, then giving the answer.
2. Before a big decision, pray istikhara.

FACTOR 3

Moods, anger and stress

Storm and stress are not every teenager's fate: serious problems come to a minority, and most parent-teen bonds stay close. Good moods come mostly with friends and in chosen activities, bad moods in places run by adults.

The teenage brain reacts most strongly to frightening faces and keeps tracking emotional faces even when attention is elsewhere. Feelings may be at their strongest around eighteen.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The strong one controls himself in anger.

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong one is not the one who throws others in wrestling; the strong one is the one who controls himself when he is angry."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5763 · Grade: Sahih

b A word that takes anger away.

Sulayman bin Surad said: we were sitting with the Prophet (pbuh) when two men began insulting each other; one of them was red in the face with anger. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I know a phrase which, if he said it, would take away what he feels: 'A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim' (I seek refuge in Allah from the accursed devil)."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5764 · Grade: Sahih

c Sit down, and if needed lie down.

Abu Dharr said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) told us: "When one of you becomes angry while standing, let him sit down. If the anger leaves him (good); if not, let him lie down."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4782 · Grade: not stated in the edition (Abu Dawud: the mursal version is sounder)

d Seek refuge from worry and grief.

> Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When anger rises, control yourself: that is real strength.
2. When anger climbs, say "A'udhu billahi min al-shaytan al-rajim".
3. If standing, sit down; if it still does not pass, lie down.
4. Make the prayer for refuge from worry, grief and helplessness.

THEN

Home and friends

FACTOR 4

With the parents

Quarrels with parents rise with puberty until mid-adolescence, mostly over everyday things such as curfew and clothes. What changes is the balance of power, not the closeness.

Pulling away from parents is linked with low mood; teenagers can be independent and close at the same time. Warmth and control are different things: controlling to dominate does harm, keeping order does not, and firmness can go together with warmth. Teenagers see clothes, hair, diary and friends as their own area, and interference there brings quarrels.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a After prayer on time, the most loved deed is being good to parents.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "Prayer on its time." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Then being good to parents." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Striving in the path of Allah."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 504 · Grade: Sahih

b Never "why did you do that?"

Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, and he never said 'why did you do that?' or 'why didn't you do that?'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

c Gentleness makes everything beautiful.

Aisha reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Gentleness is not in anything except that it beautifies it, and it is not taken out of anything except that it spoils it." In one narration Aisha was riding a stubborn camel and kept jerking it around, and the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to her: "Be gentle."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 2594 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Pray on time, and then be good to your parents.
2. When the younger one makes a mistake, the elders do not question harshly with "Why did you do that?"; they are gentle.
3. Keep talk gentle.
- × **Avoid:** Questioning and shaming over every mistake.
- × **Avoid:** Raising a hand.
- × **Avoid:** Swearing and taunts such as "your mother...", and bad names, for one's own child as well as others.

FACTOR 5

Friends and peers

Friendship now centres on closeness and sharing secrets. Friends become alike in identity, hopes, low mood and drug use, both because like chooses like and because they shape each other.

Girls more often spend time "just talking", boys doing something together. Having no friend is a risk for low mood, and being left out with no friend raises it sharply; friends protect against bullying.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A good friend is like the perfume seller.

Abu Musa reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A good companion and a bad companion are like the one carrying musk and the one blowing a blacksmith's bellows. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy some, or at least you will enjoy a pleasant smell. The one with the bellows will either burn your clothes or you will get a foul smell from him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5214 · Grade: Sahih

b A person follows the way of his close friend.

> Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A person is on the way (religion) of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2378 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

c Want for your friend what you want for yourself.

> Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of you (truly) believes until he wants for his brother what he wants for himself."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 13 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose a good companion: the perfume seller, not the bellows.
2. Once a week, talk about who the friends are and how they affect you.
3. Want for your brother or friend what you want for yourself.

THEN

Who I am

FACTOR 6

Attraction, the gaze and modesty

Attraction and romance begin in these years, and with them new pressures. The books report that the order of puberty is fixed but its timing is not, so some feel these pulls much earlier than their friends.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When the gaze strays, quietly turn the face.

Ibn Abbas said: (on the Farewell Pilgrimage) al-Fadl (bin Abbas) was riding behind the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). A woman of the tribe of Khath'am came to ask a question. Al-Fadl began looking at her and she at him, and the Prophet (pbuh) kept turning al-Fadl's face to the other side, and answered the woman's question.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1442, 1755 · Grade: Sahih

b The look is the zina of the eye.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Allah has written for the son of Adam his share of zina, which he will certainly meet: the zina of the eye is the look, the zina of the tongue is speech; the self wishes and desires, and the private parts confirm it or deny it."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6238 · Grade: Sahih

c Modesty is part of faith.

Salim reported from his father Abdullah bin Umar: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed by a man of the Ansar who was telling his brother off for being too shy. The Messenger of Allah said: "Leave him, for modesty is part of faith."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 24 · Grade: Sahih

d The young man who says "I fear Allah".

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Seven people Allah will shade in His shade on the day when there is no shade but His: a just leader; a young man who grew up worshipping his Lord; a man whose heart is attached to the mosques; two people who love each other for Allah's sake, meeting for that and parting for that; a man invited by a woman of position and beauty who says, 'I fear Allah'; a man who gives charity so secretly that his left hand does not know what his right hand gave; and a man who remembers Allah when alone and his eyes overflow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 629 · Grade: Sahih

e Whoever can marry, let him marry; if not, fast.

> Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: "We were young men with the Prophet (pbuh) and we had nothing. The Messenger of Allah said: 'O young men, whoever of you is able to marry, let him marry, for it lowers the gaze more and guards chastity more; and whoever is not able, let him fast, for it is a shield for him.'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4778-4779 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the gaze strays, turn the face away, as the Prophet (pbuh) turned al-Fadl's face.
2. Guard the gaze: the zina of the eye is the look.
3. Hold on to modesty: it is part of faith.
4. Be the young man who, invited by a woman of beauty, says "I fear Allah".
5. Whoever is able to marry should marry; whoever is not, should fast.

FACTOR 7

Who I am, and what I stand for

The big question of these years is identity: exploring first, then committing. For most it is not a crisis. The share of young people who have found their own settled identity grows slowly from fifteen to twenty-one.

Identity grows best with love together with freedom; neglect leaves a young person drifting, and close but over-protective parents can leave them with borrowed answers. Most teenagers judge right and wrong by being good and keeping the rules; reasoning is needed for this but is not enough, and empathy and guilt matter too.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Truthfulness leads to goodness.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Truthfulness leads to goodness, and goodness leads to Paradise. A person keeps telling the truth until he is written down as truthful. Lying leads to wrongdoing, and wrongdoing leads to the Fire. A person keeps lying until he is written down with Allah as a liar."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5743 · Grade: Sahih

b Whoever cheats is not of us.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed a heap of grain, put his hand into it and his fingers came out damp. He said: "What is this, owner of the grain?" He said: "Rain fell on it, Messenger of Allah." He said: "Then why didn't you put it on top so people could see it? Whoever cheats is not of me."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 102 · Grade: Sahih

c Be known for truth and trust, as he was.

> Ibn Sa'd: (raised by Abu Talib) he grew up to be the most dignified of his people, the best in character, the best neighbour, the most forbearing, the most truthful and the most trustworthy; he kept away from foul talk and from harming others, and never fought or quarrelled with anyone, until his people named him "al-Amin" (the trustworthy).
>
> Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:95-97 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. Speak the truth: truthfulness leads to goodness.
2. Do not cheat: "Whoever cheats is not of me."
3. In youth, build a name for truthfulness and trust.
- × **Avoid:** Cheating.

FACTOR 8

Faith

For most young people faith matters. Its effect is good but modest: less risk-taking, less low mood, more well-being, less drug use and less give-in to peer pressure.

Doubt is normal in this search. Seeing hardship as Allah punishing brings more problems; trusting, hopeful faith in hardship brings fewer.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a At the night prayer he gently moved Ibn Abbas to the right place.

> Ibn Abbas said: I spent the night at the house of my aunt Maymuna (the Prophet's wife). The Prophet (pbuh) got up to pray at night, and I stood up to pray with him, on his left. He took hold of my head (during the prayer) and moved me round to his right.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 665-667 · Grade: Sahih

b "Guard Allah and He will guard you."

> Ibn Abbas said: one day I was riding behind the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) and he said: "Boy, I will teach you some words. Guard Allah (His commands) and He will guard you; guard Allah and you will find Him in front of you. When you ask, ask Allah; when you seek help, seek help from Allah. Know that if the whole nation gathered to benefit you, they could only benefit you with what Allah has already written for you; and if they gathered to harm you, they could only harm you with what Allah has already written against you. The pens have been lifted and the pages have dried."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2516 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep the habit of prayer, and be the young man who grew up worshipping his Lord.
2. Stand the young person beside you in the night prayer, and gently move them to the right place.
3. Teach: "Guard Allah and He will guard you."

FACTOR 9

School, learning and first work

Marks drop at the move to middle and high school, especially for those with several problems. When school runs against what a teenager needs, freedom and real adult relationships, motivation falls.

Teachers matter more with age, and are the biggest influence on how far a young person hopes to go in learning.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seeking knowledge is a duty.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Seeking knowledge is a duty on every Muslim."
>
> Sunan Ibn Majah, narration 224 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Give the quick learner a new skill to learn.

> Zayd bin Thabit said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) told me to learn the writing of the Jews, saying: "By Allah, I do not trust the Jews with my letters." Half a month had not passed before I had learned it. After that, when he wrote to the Jews I wrote for him, and when they wrote to him I read their letters to him.
>
> Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2715 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

c Share knowledge: the captives of Badr taught children to write.

> Ibn Sa'd (from Amir al-Sha'bi): the ransom for the captives of Badr was up to 4,000. A captive who had no money was told to teach the children of the Ansar to write; the people of Makka could write and the people of Madina could not. Each such captive was given ten children of Madina, and when they had become skilled (at writing), that was his ransom. (Zayd bin Thabit was one of those who learned this way.)

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 2:15-16 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

d Give the young real responsibility.

> In his last illness he came to the pulpit and said: "Send out Usama's army. By my life, if you object to his command, you objected before to the command of his father; he is fit to lead, as his father was fit."

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira; Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. Seek knowledge: it is a duty.
2. Give the quick learner a new skill or language to learn.
3. Share knowledge with others.
4. Give the young person real responsibility, as Usama was given command.

LAST

Risks to guard against

FACTOR 10

Intoxicants

The earlier drinking starts, the more dangerous it is; most people who become addicted started before eighteen, so delaying the first use is a strategy in itself. Those who only try are often healthy and sociable; those who go on to abuse were often impulsive from childhood.

Alcohol harms the parts of the brain for memory and self-control.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Every intoxicant is forbidden.

> Aisha reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Every drink that intoxicates is forbidden."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 239 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Every intoxicating thing is forbidden: keep away.
2. Keep away from a bad companion.
- × **Avoid:** Anything that intoxicates.

FACTOR 11

Mental health

Most mental illnesses begin in these years: the average start is about fourteen, and three in four begin before twenty-four. Low mood is the most common problem of adolescence, and most get no help because it is seen as "just a phase". Girls suffer low mood about twice as often; boys die by suicide three to four times as often.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek treatment: every illness has a cure.

> Usama bin Sharik said: I came to the Prophet (pbuh); some Bedouins came and asked: "Messenger of Allah, should we seek treatment?" He said: "Seek treatment, for Allah has not made a disease without making a cure for it, except one disease: old age."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 3855 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b The strong believer does not say "if only".

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong believer is better and more loved by Allah than the weak believer, and in both there is good. Be eager for what benefits you, seek help from Allah, and do not give up. If something befalls you, do not say 'If only I had done such and such, it would have been so', but say 'Allah decreed, and He did what He willed', for 'if only' opens the door to the work of the devil."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Qadar, common number 2664 · Grade: Sahih

c Do not wish for death because of hardship.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Let none of you wish for death because of a hardship that has struck him. If he must say something, let him say: O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me, and take me when death is better for me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5347 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When there is illness, seek treatment.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.
3. Be a strong believer: when hardship strikes, do not say "if only".
4. Do not wish for death because of a hardship.

FACTOR 12

Hard experiences

Hard experiences in childhood carry a heavy cost in the teenage years: the more of them, the higher the risk of self-harm and drug use. What makes the difference is a calm, caring grown-up who buffers the stress. In adolescence the harm of childhood stress can take its most serious form.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.

STAGE 09

Young Adulthood

From eighteen to thirty

This stage is for a young man or woman from eighteen until thirty years old, and for the parents and family around them. In these years a person leaves home, studies, starts work, chooses a partner, and settles who they are.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Standing on your own feet

1. A new bond with the parents
2. Study and learning
3. Work and money

THEN

Love and marriage

4. Attraction, choosing a partner and marriage

THEN

Friends, self and faith

5. Friends and loneliness
6. Who I am, and what I stand for
7. Faith and purpose
8. Neighbours and the wider community

LAST

Risks to guard against

9. Intoxicants
10. Mental health
11. Hard experiences, and healing

START HERE

Standing on your own feet

FACTOR 1

A new bond with the parents

Leaving home does not end the bond; it changes it. Most parents say they now talk with their grown child as adults, with more respect and more like friends, and many are in touch every day.

Tension is common too, with money the most frequent quarrel, and some feel their parents are too involved. Many young adults move back home at least once, and moving back can make them feel less grown-up.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a After prayer on time, the most loved deed is being good to parents.

> Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "Prayer on its time." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Then being good to parents." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Striving in the path of Allah."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 504 · Grade: Sahih

b The loss of the one who finds his parents old and does not enter Paradise.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "May his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust." He was asked: "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "The one who finds his parents in their old age, one or both of them, and still does not enter Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2551 · Grade: Sahih

c Mercy to the young, honour to the old.

Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather, reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our young and does not know the honour of our old." (In Anas's narration an old man wanted to reach the Prophet and people were slow to make room for him, and then he said this.)

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 1922 (common number 1920) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be good to your parents.
2. Serve your parents as they grow old: whoever finds them in old age and does not enter Paradise has lost.
3. Show mercy to the young and honour to the old.

FACTOR 2

Study and learning

The brain finishes maturing from the bottom up and back to front; the part for planning, judgement and handling feelings is the last. The twenties are a sensitive time for building habits, and having a mature older person to lean on helps while one's own judgement is still settling.

Many who start a degree do not finish it. Study brings clearer thinking and less rigid views; working steadily and lightly alongside study works best.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seeking knowledge is a duty.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Seeking knowledge is a duty on every Muslim."

Sunan Ibn Majah, narration 224 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Give the quick learner a new skill to learn.

> Zayd bin Thabit said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) told me to learn the writing of the Jews, saying: "By Allah, I do not trust the Jews with my letters." Half a month had not passed before I had learned it. After that, when he wrote to the Jews I wrote for him, and when they wrote to him I read their letters to him.

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2715 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

c Share knowledge: the captives of Badr taught children to write.

> Ibn Sa'd (from Amir al-Sha'bi): the ransom for the captives of Badr was up to 4,000. A captive who had no money was told to teach the children of the Ansar to write; the people of Makka could write and the people of Madina could not. Each such captive was given ten children of Madina, and when they had become skilled (at writing), that was his ransom. (Zayd bin Thabit was one of those who learned this way.)

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 2:15-16 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

d Give the young real responsibility.

> In his last illness he came to the pulpit and said: "Send out Usama's army. By my life, if you object to his command, you objected before to the command of his father; he is fit to lead, as his father was fit."

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira; Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. Seek knowledge: it is a duty.
2. Give the quick learner a new skill or language to learn.
3. Share knowledge with others.
4. Give the young person real responsibility, as Usama was given command.

FACTOR 3

Work and money

Most young adults want work they enjoy more than work that pays more, and work that does some good. People who have more control over their work are more engaged; few say they are truly engaged at work.

Autonomy, growing skill and a sense of purpose drive people; rewards given as "do this and get that" lower the joy in the work itself. Loans and debt weigh on many in these years.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Each of you is a shepherd.

Abdullah bin Umar said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Each of you is a shepherd, and each of you will be asked about his flock: the leader is a shepherd and responsible for his people; a man is the shepherd of his family; a woman is the shepherd of her husband's house; a servant is the shepherd of his master's wealth."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 853, 2278 · Grade: Sahih

b Know each person's strength.

Anas reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The most merciful of my community to my community is Abu Bakr; the firmest in Allah's command is Umar; the truest in modesty is Uthman; the one who knows the lawful and unlawful best is Mu'adh bin Jabal; the greatest scholar of inheritance is Zayd bin Thabit; the best reciter of the Qur'an is Ubayy bin Ka'b; and the trustworthy one of this community is Abu Ubayda bin al-Jarrah."

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 3797-3798 (common number 3790-3791) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih" (one chain "gharib")

c Allah loves work done well.

> At the burial of his son Ibrahim, the Prophet (pbuh) saw a gap between the bricks and told them to close it, saying: "This neither harms nor benefits, but when a person does a piece of work, Allah loves that he does it well."

Al-Baladhuri, Ansab al-Ashraf, narration 984 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

d Make things easy.

> Abu Burda said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) sent Abu Musa and Mu'adh bin Jabal to Yemen, each to a region, and said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4086-4088 · Grade: Sahih

e Begin with those you support.

> Hakim bin Hizam reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The upper hand is better than the lower hand. Begin with those you support. The best charity is that given out of plenty. Whoever tries to keep from asking, Allah keeps him from it; and whoever seeks to be free of need, Allah makes him free of need."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1360-1361 · Grade: Sahih

f It is a sin to neglect those you feed.

> Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is enough of a sin for a man to neglect those he is responsible for feeding."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 1697 (common number 1692) · Grade: not stated in the edition

g He kept back a year's food for his family.

> Umar said that the Prophet (pbuh) used to sell the dates of the palm groves of Banu Nadir and keep back for his family enough food for their year. He would spend on his family for the year from this, and then put what remained where Allah's wealth is spent; he did this all his life.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5042-5043 · Grade: Sahih (the words of the Prophet)

h He sought refuge from debt.

> Aisha said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray in his prayer: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from sin and from debt." Someone asked: "How often you seek refuge from debt!" He said: "When a man falls into debt, he speaks and lies, and he promises and breaks it."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2267, 798 · Grade: Sahih

i Keep away from interest.

> Jabir said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) cursed the one who consumes interest, the one who pays it, the one who writes it down and its two witnesses, and said: "They are all the same."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1598 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember that you are a shepherd, answerable for what is in your care.
2. Recognise each person's particular skill.
3. Do your work thoroughly and well.
4. Make things easy for others, and do not make them hard.
5. Give charity out of plenty, and begin with those you support.
6. Keep back enough for your family's year.
7. Seek refuge from debt.
8. Keep away from interest.

× **Avoid:** Staying stuck in debt.

× **Avoid:** Working with interest, or borrowing on it.

× **Avoid:** Cheating.

THEN

Love and marriage

FACTOR 4

Attraction, choosing a partner and marriage

By early adulthood a romantic relationship matters more than friendship, and a steady relationship goes with better well-being. Most hope for a soul mate, and many want to be settled with money first.

A match arranged through the family can bring as much satisfaction as one chosen alone, and love grows with commitment. Marrying very young is the strongest predictor of divorce. A lasting marriage needs maturity, likeness between the two, fairness, and both closeness and room for each.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a When the gaze strays, quietly turn the face.

Ibn Abbas said: (on the Farewell Pilgrimage) al-Fadl (bin Abbas) was riding behind the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). A woman of the tribe of Khath'am came to ask a question. Al-Fadl began looking at her and she at him, and the Prophet (pbuh) kept turning al-Fadl's face to the other side, and answered the woman's question.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1442, 1755 · Grade: Sahih

b The look is the zina of the eye.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Allah has written for the son of Adam his share of zina, which he will certainly meet: the zina of the eye is the look, the zina of the tongue is speech; the self wishes and desires, and the private parts confirm it or deny it."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6238 · Grade: Sahih

c Modesty is part of faith.

Salim reported from his father Abdullah bin Umar: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed by a man of the Ansar who was telling his brother off for being too shy. The Messenger of Allah said: "Leave him, for modesty is part of faith."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 24 · Grade: Sahih

d The young man who says "I fear Allah".

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Seven people Allah will shade in His shade on the day when there is no shade but His: a just leader; a young man who grew up worshipping his Lord; a man whose heart is attached to the mosques; two people who love each other for Allah's sake, meeting for that and parting for that; a man invited by a woman of position and beauty who says, 'I fear Allah'; a man who gives charity so secretly that his left hand does not know what his right hand gave; and a man who remembers Allah when alone and his eyes overflow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 629 · Grade: Sahih

e Whoever can marry, let him marry; if not, fast.

> Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: "We were young men with the Prophet (pbuh) and we had nothing. The Messenger of Allah said: 'O young men, whoever of you is able to marry, let him marry, for it lowers the gaze more and guards chastity more; and whoever is not able, let him fast, for it is a shield for him.'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4778-4779 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When the gaze strays, turn the face away.
2. Guard the gaze: the zina of the eye is the look.
3. Hold on to modesty: it is part of faith.
4. When invited to wrong, say "I fear Allah".
5. Whoever is able to marry should marry; whoever is not, should fast.

THEN

Friends, self and faith

FACTOR 5

Friends and loneliness

Loneliness is often at its worst in young adulthood, and many fall into the trap of trying to manage everything alone. Loneliness strains the body as much as a physical attack does.

The number of people with no one to confide in has grown, and time spent with friends has fallen. Men tend to be friends side by side, women face to face; shared challenges bind friends together.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A good friend is like the perfume seller.

Abu Musa reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A good companion and a bad companion are like the one carrying musk and the one blowing a blacksmith's bellows. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy some, or at least you will enjoy a pleasant smell. The one with the bellows will either burn your clothes or you will get a foul smell from him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5214 · Grade: Sahih

b A person follows the way of his close friend.

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A person is on the way (religion) of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2378 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

c Want for your friend what you want for yourself.

> Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of you (truly) believes until he wants for his brother what he wants for himself."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 13 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose a good companion: the perfume seller, not the bellows.
2. Look at whom you befriend: a person follows the way of his close friend.
3. Want for your brother or friend what you want for yourself.

FACTOR 6

Who I am, and what I stand for

Identity is still opening up in these years and will be revisited through life. Many say chance events shaped their career. Building a life story that makes sense, especially one where early pain leads to later growth, helps well-being.

Personality ripens: people become calmer, kinder and more dependable, mostly between eighteen and thirty. Most adults judge right and wrong by keeping the rules of society; discussion, role-taking and taking part in fair institutions move moral thinking forward.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Truthfulness leads to goodness.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Truthfulness leads to goodness, and goodness leads to Paradise. A person keeps telling the truth until he is written down as truthful. Lying leads to wrongdoing, and wrongdoing leads to the Fire. A person keeps lying until he is written down with Allah as a liar."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5743 · Grade: Sahih

b Whoever cheats is not of us.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) passed a heap of grain, put his hand into it and his fingers came out damp. He said: "What is this, owner of the grain?" He said: "Rain fell on it, Messenger of Allah." He said: "Then why didn't you put it on top so people could see it? Whoever cheats is not of me."

Sahih Muslim, hadith 102 · Grade: Sahih

c Be known for truth and trust, as he was.

Ibn Sa'd: (raised by Abu Talib) he grew up to be the most dignified of his people, the best in character, the best neighbour, the most forbearing, the most truthful and the most trustworthy; he kept away from foul talk and from harming others, and never fought or quarrelled with anyone, until his people named him "al-Amin" (the trustworthy).

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat 1:95-97 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. Speak the truth: truthfulness leads to goodness.
2. Do not cheat.
3. In youth, build a name for truthfulness and trust.

FACTOR 7

Faith and purpose

Religious practice is often at its lowest between eighteen and twenty-five. Young people raised by warm and firm parents often keep a faith like theirs, and religious young adults are better adjusted. Those who attend worship more are better neighbours, giving more to charity and their community.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be in this world like a stranger or a traveller.

> Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of both my shoulders and said: "Be in this world as if you were a stranger or a traveller passing through."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6053 · Grade: Sahih

b Make the most of five before five.

> Amr bin Maymun al-Awdi said that the Prophet (pbuh), advising a man, said: "Make the most of five before five: your youth before your old age, your health before your illness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before you are busy, and your life before your death."

Ibn al-Mubarak, Al-Zuhd, narration 2 · Grade: not stated; the chain skips a companion (mursal)

c "Shall I not be a grateful servant?"

Al-Mughira said: the Prophet (pbuh) stood in prayer until both his feet swelled. He was told: "Allah has forgiven you your past and future sins!" He said: "Shall I not be a grateful servant?" Aisha said: when he grew heavier in body, he would pray sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4556-4557, 1078 · Grade: Sahih

d Think well of Allah.

Jabir said: I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say, three days before he died: "Let none of you die except while thinking well of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2877 · Grade: Sahih

e Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Live in this world like a stranger or a traveller.
2. Make the most of five before five: youth before old age, health before illness, wealth before poverty, free time before busyness, and life before death.
3. Be a grateful servant.
4. Think well of Allah.
5. Pray istikhara before an important decision.

FACTOR 8

Neighbours and the wider community

Trust in others and voting have fallen across generations, and fewer students see public life as a purpose. Taking part in community depends a great deal on the networks a young person falls into, such as a place of worship near home.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The believers are like one body.

> Nu'man bin Bashir reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The believers, in their love, mercy and kindness to one another, are like one body: when one part of it hurts, the rest of the body joins it in sleeplessness and fever."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2586 · Grade: Sahih

b The pact to stand with the wronged.

After the war of Fijar, the clans of Banu Hashim, Zuhra and Taym made a pact in Allah's name at the house of Abdullah bin Jud'an: "We will stand with the one who is wronged until he gets his right." The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I would not like to have red camels in exchange for breaking this pact; if I were called to it now, I would answer."

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat; Bayhaqi, Dalail al-Nubuwwa · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him say what is good or keep silent; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his neighbour; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his guest." In another narration: "...let him not harm his neighbour."

Sahih Muslim, narration 206-207 · Grade: Sahih

d Visit the sick.

Thawban reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Whoever visits a sick person remains in the harvest of Paradise until he returns." He was asked: "What is the harvest of Paradise?" He said: "Its fruits."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6510-6513 · Grade: Sahih

e Charity never decreases wealth.

> The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Charity never decreased any wealth; Allah only increases a servant in honour for forgiving; and whoever humbles himself for Allah's sake, Allah raises him."
>
> Sahih Muslim, common number 2588 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be like one body with the believers: when one part hurts, the whole body shares it.
2. Stand with the one who is wronged until he gets his right.
3. Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.
4. Visit the sick.
5. Give charity: it never decreases wealth.

LAST

Risks to guard against

FACTOR 9

Intoxicants

Drug and alcohol use peaks between nineteen and twenty-five, then most people grow out of it, and by twenty-five to thirty drinking is usually moderate. About half of those treated slip back within months. Most smokers want to stop, and most who try go back within six months.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Every intoxicant is forbidden.

> Aisha reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Every drink that intoxicates is forbidden."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 239 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Every intoxicating thing is forbidden: keep away.
2. Keep away from a bad companion.

FACTOR 10

Mental health

Several illnesses begin at this age: mood disorders most often start in the early twenties. At the same time, for most people well-being rises and low mood falls between eighteen and twenty-six. Women suffer low mood about twice as often as men; men more often turn to crime, drugs and risky driving.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek treatment: every illness has a cure.

> Usama bin Sharik said: I came to the Prophet (pbuh); some Bedouins came and asked: "Messenger of Allah, should we seek treatment?" He said: "Seek treatment, for Allah has not made a disease without making a cure for it, except one disease: old age."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 3855 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Seek refuge from worry and grief.

Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

c The strong believer does not say "if only".

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong believer is better and more loved by Allah than the weak believer, and in both there is good. Be eager for what benefits you, seek help from Allah, and do not give up. If something befalls you, do not say 'If only I had done such and such, it would have been so', but say 'Allah decreed, and He did what He willed', for 'if only' opens the door to the work of the devil."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Qadar, common number 2664 · Grade: Sahih

d Do not wish for death because of hardship.

Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Let none of you wish for death because of a hardship that has struck him. If he must say something, let him say: O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me, and take me when death is better for me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5347 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When there is illness, seek treatment.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.
3. Be a strong believer: when hardship strikes, do not say "if only".
4. Do not wish for death because of a hardship.

FACTOR 11

Hard experiences, and healing

Hard childhood experiences show their cost in young adulthood, in low mood and in self-harm. Yet becoming a partner or a parent is a sensitive time when old wounds can heal; it is never too late, and love and a child can redraw a person's inner map.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.

STAGE 10

Settling Down

From thirty to forty-five

This stage is for a man or woman from thirty until forty-five years old. In these years a person puts down roots: career, marriage and young children, with ageing parents beginning to need care, and around forty a time of looking back over life.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Work and pressure

1. Work, money and burnout
2. Stress, and how you cope

THEN

Marriage and children

3. Marriage and the home
4. Becoming parents

THEN

Parents, friends and community

5. Caring for ageing parents
6. Friends and loneliness
7. Neighbours and the community

LAST

Purpose and the inner life

8. Purpose and giving
9. Faith
10. Mental health
11. The weight of childhood

START HERE

Work and pressure

FACTOR 1

Work, money and burnout

People often feel more absorbed at work than in their free time, yet still wish they were doing something else. Career decisions settle with age; many reach their career peak in their forties, and earnings rise most in the first ten years of work.

Stress at work comes most from high demands with little control; it is not only the bosses who suffer, and middle managers often carry the most.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Each of you is a shepherd.

Abdullah bin Umar said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Each of you is a shepherd, and each of you will be asked about his flock: the leader is a shepherd and responsible for his people; a man is the shepherd of his family; a woman is the shepherd of her husband's house; a servant is the shepherd of his master's wealth."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 853, 2278 · Grade: Sahih

b Know each person's strength.

> Anas reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The most merciful of my community to my community is Abu Bakr; the firmest in Allah's command is Umar; the truest in modesty is Uthman; the one who knows the lawful and unlawful best is Mu'adh bin Jabal; the greatest scholar of inheritance is Zayd bin Thabit; the best reciter of the Qur'an is Ubayy bin Ka'b; and the trustworthy one of this community is Abu Ubayda bin al-Jarrah."

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 3797-3798 (common number 3790-3791) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih" (one chain "gharib")

c Allah loves work done well.

> At the burial of his son Ibrahim, the Prophet (pbuh) saw a gap between the bricks and told them to close it, saying: "This neither harms nor benefits, but when a person does a piece of work, Allah loves that he does it well."

Al-Baladhuri, Ansab al-Ashraf, narration 984 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

d Make things easy.

> Abu Burda said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) sent Abu Musa and Mu'adh bin Jabal to Yemen, each to a region, and said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4086-4088 · Grade: Sahih

e Begin with those you support.

Hakim bin Hizam reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The upper hand is better than the lower hand. Begin with those you support. The best charity is that given out of plenty. Whoever tries to keep from asking, Allah keeps him from it; and whoever seeks to be free of need, Allah makes him free of need."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1360-1361 · Grade: Sahih

f It is a sin to neglect those you feed.

Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is enough of a sin for a man to neglect those he is responsible for feeding."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 1697 (common number 1692) · Grade: not stated in the edition

g He kept back a year's food for his family.

Umar said that the Prophet (pbuh) used to sell the dates of the palm groves of Banu Nadir and keep back for his family enough food for their year. He would spend on his family for the year from this, and then put what remained where Allah's wealth is spent; he did this all his life.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5042-5043 · Grade: Sahih (the words of the Prophet)

h He sought refuge from debt.

> Aisha said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray in his prayer: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from sin and from debt." Someone asked: "How often you seek refuge from debt!" He said: "When a man falls into debt, he speaks and lies, and he promises and breaks it."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2267, 798 · Grade: Sahih

i Keep away from interest.

> Jabir said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) cursed the one who consumes interest, the one who pays it, the one who writes it down and its two witnesses, and said: "They are all the same."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1598 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember that you are a shepherd, answerable for what is in your care.
2. Recognise each person's particular skill.
3. Do your work thoroughly and well.
4. Make things easy for others, and do not make them hard.
5. Give charity out of plenty, and begin with those you support.
6. Keep back enough for your family's year.
7. Seek refuge from debt.
8. Keep away from interest.

× **Avoid:** Borrowing on interest.

× **Avoid:** Neglecting those whose keep depends on you.

FACTOR 2

Stress, and how you cope

The body's stress response was made for a few minutes of danger, not for months; people keep it running by thinking about mortgages, work and relationships. Long stress harms the heart.

Personality is now very stable: people change only a little from year to year, and big life events change it less than expected. How a person copes matters more than what happens.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek refuge from worry and grief.

> Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

b The strong believer does not say "if only".

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong believer is better and more loved by Allah than the weak believer, and in both there is good. Be eager for what benefits you, seek help from Allah, and do not give up. If something befalls you, do not say 'If only I had done such and such, it would have been so', but say 'Allah decreed, and He did what He willed', for 'if only' opens the door to the work of the devil."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Qadar, common number 2664 · Grade: Sahih

c The strong one controls himself in anger.

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong one is not the one who throws others in wrestling; the strong one is the one who controls himself when he is angry."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5763 · Grade: Sahih

d A little, done steadily.

Aisha said: the Prophet (pbuh) was asked: "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "The one done most regularly, even if it is small." And he said: "Take on only as many deeds as you can manage."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6100 · Grade: Sahih

e A believer is not stung twice from the same hole.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A believer is not stung from the same hole twice."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5782; Sahih Muslim, common number 2998 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make the prayer for refuge from worry, grief, helplessness, laziness and the burden of debt.
2. Be eager for what benefits you; when hardship strikes, do not say "if only".
3. Control yourself in anger.
4. Do a little, but steadily, as much as you can manage.
5. Learn from a mistake: a believer is not stung twice from the same hole.

THEN

Marriage and children

FACTOR 3

Marriage and the home

The steadiest finding of a study that followed people for over eighty years: good relationships are linked more than anything with health and long life. But it is the quality of the marriage that counts; an unhappy marriage goes with more illness.

Satisfaction often falls after the early years, falls further with a new baby and young children, and rises again when the children leave. Half of divorces happen in the first seven years, often while the children are small.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The best of you is the best to his family.

Aisha reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family."

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

b He helped with the work of the home.

Al-Aswad said: I asked Aisha what the Prophet (pbuh) did at home. She said: "He would be busy with the work of his family, serving them, and when the time for prayer came he would go out to pray."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 644 · Grade: Sahih

c Choose a partner for religion.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A woman is married for four things: her wealth, her family, her beauty and her religion. So choose the one with religion, may your hands be covered in dust."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4802 · Grade: Sahih

d Khadija's comfort in his hardest hour.

> Aisha said: the revelation began with true dreams. Then solitude was made dear to him; he would stay alone in the cave of Hira worshipping for some nights before returning to his family, and then go back to Khadija. The angel came and said "Read!"... He came to Khadija with his heart trembling and said: "Cover me", then: "I feared for myself." Khadija said: "Never! Allah will never disgrace you. You keep ties with your relatives, carry the burdens of others, earn for those who have nothing, honour the guest and help in times of real hardship." Then she took him to Waraqa bin Nawfal.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be the best to your family.
2. Help with the work of the home.
3. In choosing a partner, put religion first.
4. In hard times, support and comfort each other, as Khadija comforted him.

FACTOR 4

Becoming parents

After the first baby, satisfaction drops sharply for about two in three couples; for one in three it does not, and for half of those it gets better. What decides it is not whether the baby is colicky or whether the mother works, but whether the husband goes with his wife into the new world of the baby or is left behind.

Fathers' and mothers' roles drift apart most in the years of young children, even in couples who shared everything before.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Whoever shows no mercy is shown none.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) kissed Hasan bin Ali while al-Aqra bin Habis was sitting with him. Al-Aqra said: "I have ten children and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) looked at him and said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5651 · Grade: Sahih

b Never "why did you do that?"

Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, and he never said 'why did you do that?' or 'why didn't you do that?'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

c Be fair between your children.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father gave me a gift. My mother, Amra bint Rawaha, said: "I will not accept it until you make the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) a witness." My father went to him and said: "I have given this son of mine a gift, and his mother asked me to make you a witness." He asked: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be fair between your children." My father came back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

d A false promise to a child is a lie.

Abdullah bin Amir said: one day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was sitting in our house when my mother called me: "Come here, I'll give you something." He asked her: "What did you mean to give him?" She said: "A date." He said: "Listen: if you had given him nothing, a lie would have been written against you."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4991 · Grade: not stated in the edition

e Enter the child's world.

Anas said: the Prophet (pbuh) had the best character of all people. I had a little brother called Abu Umayr, who (I think) had just been weaned. Whenever the Prophet (pbuh) came he would say: "Abu Umayr, what did the nughayr do?" (The nughayr was a little bird he used to play with.)

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5850 · Grade: Sahih

f He lengthened his prostration for a child.

Shaddad bin al-Had said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came out for one of the evening prayers carrying Hasan or Husayn. He put him down and led the prayer, and made one prostration very long. I raised my head and the child was on his back. After the prayer people asked about it, and he said: "My son was riding on me, and I did not want to hurry him."

Sunan Nasai, narration 1150 (common number 1141) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Kiss your child and show your love.
2. When the child makes a mistake, do not question with "Why did you do that, why did you not do that?"
3. Be just between your children in gifts.
4. Keep your promise to the child; a false promise is a lie.
5. Enter the child's world, and take the child's play seriously.
6. Do not hurry the child, even if it makes your prayer longer.

THEN

Parents, friends and community

FACTOR 5

Caring for ageing parents

Many in these years begin caring for parents while still raising children. Many people lose a first parent between thirty-five and forty-five.

The strain of caregiving is physical as well as emotional, and caregivers are at risk of low mood. Women carry far more of the hours of care than men.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The loss of the one who finds his parents old and does not enter Paradise.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "May his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust." He was asked: "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "The one who finds his parents in their old age, one or both of them, and still does not enter Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2551 · Grade: Sahih

b He honoured the old father of Abu Bakr.

At the conquest of Makka, Abu Bakr brought his father Abu Quhafa, who had lost his sight, leading him by the hand. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Why did you not leave the old man at home, so that I could go to him myself?" Abu Bakr said: "He has more right to come to you." The Prophet sat him in front of him, passed his hand over his chest and invited him to Islam, and he became a Muslim.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Being good to parents comes after prayer.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "Prayer on its time." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Then being good to parents." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Striving in the path of Allah."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 504 · Grade: Sahih

d Honouring the grey-haired is honouring Allah.

> Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Part of honouring Allah is honouring the grey-haired Muslim, the one who carries the Qur'an without going to extremes in it or neglecting it, and the just ruler."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 4863 (common number 4843) · Grade: not stated in the edition; Nawawi called it hasan

e Mercy to the young, honour to the old.

> Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather, reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our young and does not know the honour of our old." (In Anas's narration an old man wanted to reach the Prophet and people were slow to make room for him, and then he said this.)

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 1922 (common number 1920) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Serve your parents in their old age.
2. Honour the old: the Prophet (pbuh) would have gone to Abu Quhafa himself, and sat him in front of him.
3. Be good to your parents.
4. Honour the grey-haired Muslim.
5. Show mercy to the young and honour to the old.

FACTOR 6

Friends and loneliness

Marriage and children eat up time with friends; married people tend to stay at home. Yet people are in their best mood with friends, and a best friend adds to well-being. Social isolation harms health as much as smoking or high blood pressure.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A good friend is like the perfume seller.

Abu Musa reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A good companion and a bad companion are like the one carrying musk and the one blowing a blacksmith's bellows. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy some, or at least you will enjoy a pleasant smell. The one with the bellows will either burn your clothes or you will get a foul smell from him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5214 · Grade: Sahih

b A person follows the way of his close friend.

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A person is on the way (religion) of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."

Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2378 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

c Want for your friend what you want for yourself.

Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of you (truly) believes until he wants for his brother what he wants for himself."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 13 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose a good companion: the perfume seller, not the bellows.
2. Look at whom you befriend.
3. Want for your brother or friend what you want for yourself.

FACTOR 7

Neighbours and the community

Children are a doorway into community life, through schools, youth groups and places of worship. Taking part in civic life fell sharply for people in their thirties over the decades, through busy work, long commutes and television.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The believers are like one body.

> Nu'man bin Bashir reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The believers, in their love, mercy and kindness to one another, are like one body: when one part of it hurts, the rest of the body joins it in sleeplessness and fever."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2586 · Grade: Sahih

b The pact to stand with the wronged.

After the war of Fijar, the clans of Banu Hashim, Zuhra and Taym made a pact in Allah's name at the house of Abdullah bin Jud'an: "We will stand with the one who is wronged until he gets his right." The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I would not like to have red camels in exchange for breaking this pact; if I were called to it now, I would answer."

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat; Bayhaqi, Dalail al-Nubuwwa · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him say what is good or keep silent; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his neighbour; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his guest." In another narration: "...let him not harm his neighbour."

Sahih Muslim, narration 206-207 · Grade: Sahih

d Visit the sick.

Thawban reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Whoever visits a sick person remains in the harvest of Paradise until he returns." He was asked: "What is the harvest of Paradise?" He said: "Its fruits."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6510-6513 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be like one body with the believers.
2. Stand with the one who is wronged until he gets his right.
3. Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.
4. Visit the sick.

LAST

Purpose and the inner life

FACTOR 8

Purpose and giving

The task of these years is generativity: giving of oneself to the next generation, caring for the young while respecting their freedom, learning to "hold loosely". Its opposite is shutting others out of one's care.

People in middle adulthood are more generative than young adults; having children raises it in both men and women, and those without children can be just as generative.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Three deeds that go on after death.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "When a person dies, his deeds come to an end except for three: ongoing charity, knowledge that people benefit from, or a righteous child who prays for him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1631 · Grade: Sahih

b Learn and teach.

Uthman reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who learns the Qur'an and teaches it." Abu Abd al-Rahman al-Sulami taught the Qur'an from the time of Uthman until the time of al-Hajjaj, and said: "This hadith is what sat me in this place."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4739-4740 · Grade: Sahih

c Pass on, even one verse.

Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Pass on from me, even one verse."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3274 · Grade: Sahih

d Plant the seedling, even at the Hour.

Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "If the Hour comes while one of you has a palm seedling in his hand, and he is able to plant it before the Hour comes, let him plant it."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 483 (common number 479) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

e Charity never decreases wealth.

The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Charity never decreased any wealth; Allah only increases a servant in honour for forgiving; and whoever humbles himself for Allah's sake, Allah raises him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2588 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Leave behind ongoing charity, useful knowledge and a righteous child who prays for you.
2. Learn, and teach.
3. Pass on what you have learned, even one verse.
4. Plant the seedling, even if the Hour is coming.
5. Give charity: it never decreases wealth, and humility raises a person.

FACTOR 9

Faith

Religious people are on average happier, through their relationships and a sense of being connected to something beyond themselves. Religious practice often weakens in middle age under the weight of responsibilities, and returns later in life. Its strength lies in belonging as much as believing.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be in this world like a stranger or a traveller.

> Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of both my shoulders and said: "Be in this world as if you were a stranger or a traveller passing through."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6053 · Grade: Sahih

b Make the most of five before five.

Amr bin Maymun al-Awdi said that the Prophet (pbuh), advising a man, said: "Make the most of five before five: your youth before your old age, your health before your illness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before you are busy, and your life before your death."

Ibn al-Mubarak, Al-Zuhd, narration 2 · Grade: not stated; the chain skips a companion (mursal)

c "Shall I not be a grateful servant?"

Al-Mughira said: the Prophet (pbuh) stood in prayer until both his feet swelled. He was told: "Allah has forgiven you your past and future sins!" He said: "Shall I not be a grateful servant?" Aisha said: when he grew heavier in body, he would pray sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4556-4557, 1078 · Grade: Sahih

d Think well of Allah.

Jabir said: I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say, three days before he died: "Let none of you die except while thinking well of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2877 · Grade: Sahih

e Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

> Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Live in this world like a stranger or a traveller.
2. Make the most of five before five.
3. Be a grateful servant.
4. Think well of Allah.
5. Pray istikhara before an important decision.

FACTOR 10

Mental health

Low mood often shows not as sadness but as tiredness, guilt and waking too early; the first sign is often broken sleep. Men are less likely to seek help and are taught that it is "unmanly".

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek treatment: every illness has a cure.

> Usama bin Sharik said: I came to the Prophet (pbuh); some Bedouins came and asked: "Messenger of Allah, should we seek treatment?" He said: "Seek treatment, for Allah has not made a disease without making a cure for it, except one disease: old age."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 3855 · Grade: not stated in the edition

b Do not wish for death because of hardship.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Let none of you wish for death because of a hardship that has struck him. If he must say something, let him say: O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me, and take me when death is better for me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5347 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. When there is illness, seek treatment.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.
3. Do not wish for death because of a hardship.

FACTOR 11

The weight of childhood

Hard childhood experiences can show up in the body in these years. But they are not fate: a warm childhood protects, and a bleak childhood does not condemn. Their effect fades with the years of adult life.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.

STAGE 11

Middle Age

From forty-five to sixty-five

This stage is for a man or woman from forty-five until sixty-five years old. In these years a person gives to the next generation, sees grown children leave home, cares for very old parents, feels the first clear changes of an ageing body, and comes to the doorstep of retirement.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Body, stress and work

1. An ageing body, and keeping going
2. Stress, and how you cope
3. Work, money and the road to retirement

THEN

Marriage, children and parents

4. Marriage in the long run
5. Grown children leaving home
6. Caring for very old parents

THEN

Friends, community and purpose

7. Friends and loneliness
8. Giving to the community
9. Purpose and what you leave behind

LAST

Faith and old wounds

10. Faith
11. The weight of childhood

START HERE

Body, stress and work

FACTOR 1

An ageing body, and keeping going

Some ageing comes to everyone, timed by the genes; much of the rest comes from how a person lives. Many of the illnesses of these years grow out of habits started decades earlier.

Exercise is the clearest protection: the more activity each week, the lower the chance of dying in the years ahead, and it helps mood too. Yet many middle-aged people sit most of the day, and many who start exercising stop within six months.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a He sought refuge from laziness and feeble old age.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to seek refuge, saying: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from laziness, I seek refuge in You from cowardice, I seek refuge in You from feeble old age, and I seek refuge in You from miserliness."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6010 · Grade: Sahih

b Seek treatment: every illness has a cure except old age.

> Usama bin Sharik said: I came to the Prophet (pbuh); some Bedouins came and asked: "Messenger of Allah, should we seek treatment?" He said: "Seek treatment, for Allah has not made a disease without making a cure for it, except one disease: old age."
>
> Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 3855 · Grade: not stated in the edition

c As he grew older, he prayed the night prayer sitting.

> Aisha said she never saw the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray the night prayer sitting until he grew old; then he would recite sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite about thirty or forty verses, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1067, 1068, 1097 · Grade: Sahih

d He walked to Quba every Saturday.

> Ibn Umar said: "The Prophet (pbuh) used to come to the mosque of Quba every Saturday, on foot and riding"; in another narration: "and he would pray two rak'ahs there."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1134-1136 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make the prayer for refuge from laziness, cowardice, feeble old age and miserliness.
2. Seek treatment when ill: every illness has a cure except old age.
3. As age grows, adjust worship to the body: recite sitting, then stand to bow.
4. Keep a regular walk, as he walked to Quba every Saturday.

FACTOR 2

Stress, and how you cope

With age the body copes less well with stress: the response is weaker when needed, or stays high for too long. Social support is a strong protection. Middle-aged people tend to be more realistic and better at preparing; switching flexibly between solving the problem and handling the feelings works best.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Seek refuge from worry and grief.

> Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

b The strong believer does not say "if only".

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong believer is better and more loved by Allah than the weak believer, and in both there is good. Be eager for what benefits you, seek help from Allah, and do not give up. If something befalls you, do not say 'If only I had done such and such, it would have been so', but say 'Allah decreed, and He did what He willed', for 'if only' opens the door to the work of the devil."

Sahih Muslim, Kitab al-Qadar, common number 2664 · Grade: Sahih

c The strong one controls himself in anger.

Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The strong one is not the one who throws others in wrestling; the strong one is the one who controls himself when he is angry."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5763 · Grade: Sahih

d A little, done steadily.

Aisha said: the Prophet (pbuh) was asked: "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "The one done most regularly, even if it is small." And he said: "Take on only as many deeds as you can manage."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6100 · Grade: Sahih

e A believer is not stung twice from the same hole.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A believer is not stung from the same hole twice."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5782; Sahih Muslim, common number 2998 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make the prayer for refuge from worry, grief, helplessness, laziness and the burden of debt.
2. When hardship strikes, do not say "if only".
3. Control yourself in anger.
4. Do a little, but steadily.
5. Learn from a mistake: do not be stung twice from the same hole.

FACTOR 3

Work, money and the road to retirement

Older workers report being the most satisfied with their jobs, though burnout is common in the helping professions. Losing a job after forty comes "off-time", and unemployment with money troubles brings a risk of low mood and illness.

Many in their fifties and sixties want to work less, but few manage it.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Each of you is a shepherd.

Abdullah bin Umar said: I heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) say: "Each of you is a shepherd, and each of you will be asked about his flock: the leader is a shepherd and responsible for his people; a man is the shepherd of his family; a woman is the shepherd of her husband's house; a servant is the shepherd of his master's wealth."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 853, 2278 · Grade: Sahih

b Allah loves work done well.

At the burial of his son Ibrahim, the Prophet (pbuh) saw a gap between the bricks and told them to close it, saying: "This neither harms nor benefits, but when a person does a piece of work, Allah loves that he does it well."

Al-Baladhuri, Ansab al-Ashraf, narration 984 · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Make things easy.

> Abu Burda said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) sent Abu Musa and Mu'adh bin Jabal to Yemen, each to a region, and said: "Make things easy and do not make them hard; give good news and do not drive people away."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4086-4088 · Grade: Sahih

d Begin with those you support.

> Hakim bin Hizam reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The upper hand is better than the lower hand. Begin with those you support. The best charity is that given out of plenty. Whoever tries to keep from asking, Allah keeps him from it; and whoever seeks to be free of need, Allah makes him free of need."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1360-1361 · Grade: Sahih

e It is a sin to neglect those you feed.

> Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is enough of a sin for a man to neglect those he is responsible for feeding."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 1697 (common number 1692) · Grade: not stated in the edition

f He kept back a year's food for his family.

> Umar said that the Prophet (pbuh) used to sell the dates of the palm groves of Banu Nadir and keep back for his family enough food for their year. He would spend on his family for the year from this, and then put what remained where Allah's wealth is spent; he did this all his life.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5042-5043 · Grade: Sahih (the words of the Prophet)

g He sought refuge from debt.

> Aisha said that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray in his prayer: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from sin and from debt." Someone asked: "How often you seek refuge from debt!" He said: "When a man falls into debt, he speaks and lies, and he promises and breaks it."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2267, 798 · Grade: Sahih

h Keep away from interest.

> Jabir said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) cursed the one who consumes interest, the one who pays it, the one who writes it down and its two witnesses, and said: "They are all the same."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1598 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember that you are a shepherd, answerable for what is in your care.
2. Do your work thoroughly and well.
3. Make things easy for others.
4. Give charity out of plenty, and begin with those you support.
5. Keep back enough for your family's year.
6. Seek refuge from debt.
7. Keep away from interest.

× **Avoid:** Neglecting the family whose keep depends on you.

THEN

Marriage, children and parents

FACTOR 4

Marriage in the long run

Couples who last are held together by love, trust and joy. One long study named four parts of a lasting marriage: care for the next generation, commitment, tolerance and humour; the bumps smooth out over the decades.

Couples with empathy and affection are more likely to stay together, and a husband's empathy matters especially. A person can be lonely inside a marriage.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The best of you is the best to his family.

> Aisha reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best of you to my family."

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 3902 (common number 3895) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

b He helped with the work of the home.

> Al-Aswad said: I asked Aisha what the Prophet (pbuh) did at home. She said: "He would be busy with the work of his family, serving them, and when the time for prayer came he would go out to pray."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 644 · Grade: Sahih

c Khadija's comfort in his hardest hour.

> Aisha said: the revelation began with true dreams. Then solitude was made dear to him; he would stay alone in the cave of Hira worshipping for some nights before returning to his family, and then go back to Khadija. The angel came and said "Read!"... He came to Khadija with his heart trembling and said: "Cover me", then: "I feared for myself." Khadija said: "Never! Allah will never disgrace you. You keep ties with your relatives, carry the burdens of others, earn for those who have nothing, honour the guest and help in times of real hardship." Then she took him to Waraqa bin Nawfal.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be the best to your family.
2. Help with the work of the home.
3. In hard times, support and comfort each other.

FACTOR 5

Grown children leaving home

Most parents are in touch with their grown children several times a week. Children who are "off-time", not doing what their age usually brings, are a strain on parents, and children who move back home are harder when they do not take responsibility.

Parents' self-esteem rises with their children's success, but tying one's happiness too closely to how the children are doing brings too much joy and too much sorrow.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Whoever shows no mercy is shown none.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) kissed Hasan bin Ali while al-Aqra bin Habis was sitting with him. Al-Aqra said: "I have ten children and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) looked at him and said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5651 · Grade: Sahih

b Never "why did you do that?"

Anas said: "I served the Prophet (pbuh) for ten years. He never once said 'uff' to me, and he never said 'why did you do that?' or 'why didn't you do that?'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5691 · Grade: Sahih

c Be fair between your children.

Nu'man bin Bashir said: my father gave me a gift. My mother, Amra bint Rawaha, said: "I will not accept it until you make the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) a witness." My father went to him and said: "I have given this son of mine a gift, and his mother asked me to make you a witness." He asked: "Have you given the same to all your other children?" He said: "No." He said: "Fear Allah and be fair between your children." My father came back and took his gift back.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2446-2447 · Grade: Sahih

d A false promise to a child is a lie.

> Abdullah bin Amir said: one day the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) was sitting in our house when my mother called me: "Come here, I'll give you something." He asked her: "What did you mean to give him?" She said: "A date." He said: "Listen: if you had given him nothing, a lie would have been written against you."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 4991 · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep showing your love to your children, even grown.
2. Do not question their mistakes with "Why did you do that?"
3. Be just between your children in gifts.
4. Keep your promises to them.

FACTOR 6

Caring for very old parents

The middle of life is crowded: in one hospital study, no woman was admitted for the tiredness of caring for small children, but several were for the tiredness of caring for sick parents.

The advice from the books: cope, get support, do not give up your work, take breaks; be patient and supportive, but resist doing for your parents what they can still do for themselves.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The loss of the one who finds his parents old and does not enter Paradise.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "May his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust." He was asked: "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "The one who finds his parents in their old age, one or both of them, and still does not enter Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2551 · Grade: Sahih

b He honoured the old father of Abu Bakr.

At the conquest of Makka, Abu Bakr brought his father Abu Quhafa, who had lost his sight, leading him by the hand. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Why did you not leave the old man at home, so that I could go to him myself?" Abu Bakr said: "He has more right to come to you." The Prophet sat him in front of him, passed his hand over his chest and invited him to Islam, and he became a Muslim.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Being good to parents comes after prayer.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "Prayer on its time." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Then being good to parents." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Striving in the path of Allah."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 504 · Grade: Sahih

d Honouring the grey-haired is honouring Allah.

Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Part of honouring Allah is honouring the grey-haired Muslim, the one who carries the Qur'an without going to extremes in it or neglecting it, and the just ruler."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 4863 (common number 4843) · Grade: not stated in the edition; Nawawi called it hasan

e Mercy to the young, honour to the old.

Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather, reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our young and does not know the honour of our old." (In Anas's narration an old man wanted to reach the Prophet and people were slow to make room for him, and then he said this.)

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 1922 (common number 1920) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Serve your parents in their old age.
2. Honour the old: go to them yourself rather than make them come to you.
3. Be good to your parents.
4. Honour the grey-haired Muslim.
5. Show mercy to the young and honour to the old.

THEN

Friends, community and purpose

FACTOR 7

Friends and loneliness

Most people have eight to eleven close people around them. Loneliness is about the gap between the contact you want and what you have, and it raises the risk of death two to four times.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a A good friend is like the perfume seller.

> Abu Musa reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "A good companion and a bad companion are like the one carrying musk and the one blowing a blacksmith's bellows. The one with musk will either give you some, or you will buy some, or at least you will enjoy a pleasant smell. The one with the bellows will either burn your clothes or you will get a foul smell from him."
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5214 · Grade: Sahih

b A person follows the way of his close friend.

> Abu Hurayra reports that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "A person is on the way (religion) of his close friend, so let each of you look at whom he befriends."
>
> Jami Tirmidhi, hadith 2378 · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan gharib"

c Want for your friend what you want for yourself.

Anas reports that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of you (truly) believes until he wants for his brother what he wants for himself."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 13 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose a good companion.
2. Look at whom you befriend.
3. Want for your brother or friend what you want for yourself.

FACTOR 8

Giving to the community

Taking part in civic life rises through youth, levels off in middle age and then slowly falls. In the late fifties, care for the next generation goes with civic and religious involvement, and volunteering adds to well-being. Among older couples, those who gave help lived longer; receiving help was not linked with long life.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The believers are like one body.

Nu'man bin Bashir reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The believers, in their love, mercy and kindness to one another, are like one body: when one part of it hurts, the rest of the body joins it in sleeplessness and fever."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2586 · Grade: Sahih

b The pact to stand with the wronged.

After the war of Fijar, the clans of Banu Hashim, Zuhra and Taym made a pact in Allah's name at the house of Abdullah bin Jud'an: "We will stand with the one who is wronged until he gets his right." The Prophet (pbuh) said: "I would not like to have red camels in exchange for breaking this pact; if I were called to it now, I would answer."

Ibn Sa'd, Al-Tabaqat; Bayhaqi, Dalail al-Nubuwwa · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him say what is good or keep silent; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his neighbour; whoever believes in Allah and the Last Day, let him honour his guest." In another narration: "...let him not harm his neighbour."

Sahih Muslim, narration 206-207 · Grade: Sahih

d Visit the sick.

Thawban reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Whoever visits a sick person remains in the harvest of Paradise until he returns." He was asked: "What is the harvest of Paradise?" He said: "Its fruits."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6510-6513 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Be like one body with the believers.
2. Stand with the one who is wronged.
3. Honour your neighbour, and do not harm him.
4. Visit the sick.

FACTOR 9

Purpose and what you leave behind

The task now is to give: in children, in work and in what one creates, all the strengths of earlier life pass to the next generation. Later comes the role of "keeper of the meaning", passing on wisdom and fairness without taking sides.

Achievement is most meaningful when it is tied to relationships; a man who earns much but is starved of affection is poorer than he looks. Long-held anger is stress; deciding to act as if one has forgiven lets the feelings follow.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Three deeds that go on after death.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "When a person dies, his deeds come to an end except for three: ongoing charity, knowledge that people benefit from, or a righteous child who prays for him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1631 · Grade: Sahih

b Learn and teach.

Uthman reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who learns the Qur'an and teaches it." Abu Abd al-Rahman al-Sulami taught the Qur'an from the time of Uthman until the time of al-Hajjaj, and said: "This hadith is what sat me in this place."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4739-4740 · Grade: Sahih

c Pass on, even one verse.

Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Pass on from me, even one verse."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3274 · Grade: Sahih

d Plant the seedling, even at the Hour.

Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "If the Hour comes while one of you has a palm seedling in his hand, and he is able to plant it before the Hour comes, let him plant it."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 483 (common number 479) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

e Charity never decreases wealth; forgiving raises honour.

The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Charity never decreased any wealth; Allah only increases a servant in honour for forgiving; and whoever humbles himself for Allah's sake, Allah raises him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2588 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Leave behind ongoing charity, useful knowledge and a righteous child who prays for you.
2. Learn, and teach.
3. Pass on what you have learned, even one verse.
4. Plant the seedling, even if the Hour is coming.
5. Give charity and forgive: Allah raises the one who forgives and is humble.

LAST

Faith and old wounds

FACTOR 10

Faith

Religious people are on average happier, through the bonds of community and a sense of something beyond the self. For some, middle age brings a deeper and more personal faith.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be in this world like a stranger or a traveller.

> Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of both my shoulders and said: "Be in this world as if you were a stranger or a traveller passing through."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6053 · Grade: Sahih

b Make the most of five before five.

Amr bin Maymun al-Awdi said that the Prophet (pbuh), advising a man, said: "Make the most of five before five: your youth before your old age, your health before your illness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before you are busy, and your life before your death."

Ibn al-Mubarak, Al-Zuhd, narration 2 · Grade: not stated; the chain skips a companion (mursal)

c "Shall I not be a grateful servant?"

Al-Mughira said: the Prophet (pbuh) stood in prayer until both his feet swelled. He was told: "Allah has forgiven you your past and future sins!" He said: "Shall I not be a grateful servant?" Aisha said: when he grew heavier in body, he would pray sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4556-4557, 1078 · Grade: Sahih

d Think well of Allah.

Jabir said: I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say, three days before he died: "Let none of you die except while thinking well of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2877 · Grade: Sahih

e Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

> Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Live in this world like a stranger or a traveller.
2. Make the most of five before five.
3. Be a grateful servant.
4. Think well of Allah.
5. Pray istikhara before an important decision.

FACTOR 11

The weight of childhood

Hard childhood experiences still show in these years, in illness and in long-lasting low mood. Men who went through great hardship as boys had more health problems, tiredness and heavy drinking around forty. But it is never too late to change how one responds to stress.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.

STAGE 12

Later Life

From sixty-five to eighty

This stage is for a man or woman from sixty-five until eighty years old, and for the children and family around them. In these years a person retires, sorts out what matters most, becomes a grandparent, faces loss, and looks back over a whole life.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

Body, mind and feelings

1. Keeping body and mind active
2. Feelings, loneliness and grief

THEN

Family across the generations

3. Being a grandparent
4. Grown children, and honour for the old

LAST

Purpose, faith and affairs in order

5. Retirement and purpose
6. Looking back, and faith
7. A will, and putting affairs in order

START HERE

Body, mind and feelings

FACTOR 1

Keeping body and mind active

Much of what is called old age is really the effect of sitting still. Physical activity is the single most important thing linked with ageing well; it delays disability by years, and moving at least twice a week was linked with half the risk of dementia. The biggest gain comes from going from nothing to a little: even a ten-minute slow walk a day.

Thinking slows, but older people are no less accurate. Remembering names gets harder, while emotional memories stay safe. Dementia is not normal ageing.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a He sought refuge from laziness and feeble old age.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to seek refuge, saying: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from laziness, I seek refuge in You from cowardice, I seek refuge in You from feeble old age, and I seek refuge in You from miserliness."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6010 · Grade: Sahih

b Seek treatment: every illness has a cure except old age.

Usama bin Sharik said: I came to the Prophet (pbuh); some Bedouins came and asked: "Messenger of Allah, should we seek treatment?" He said: "Seek treatment, for Allah has not made a disease without making a cure for it, except one disease: old age."

Sunan Abu Dawud, hadith 3855 · Grade: not stated in the edition

c As he grew older, he prayed the night prayer sitting.

Aisha said she never saw the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray the night prayer sitting until he grew old; then he would recite sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite about thirty or forty verses, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1067, 1068, 1097 · Grade: Sahih

d When he grew heavier, he prayed sitting, and was a grateful servant.

Al-Mughira said: the Prophet (pbuh) stood in prayer until both his feet swelled. He was told: "Allah has forgiven you your past and future sins!" He said: "Shall I not be a grateful servant?" Aisha said: when he grew heavier in body, he would pray sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4556-4557, 1078 · Grade: Sahih

e He walked to Quba every Saturday.

> Ibn Umar said: "The Prophet (pbuh) used to come to the mosque of Quba every Saturday, on foot and riding"; in another narration: "and he would pray two rak'ahs there."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1134-1136 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make the prayer for refuge from laziness, cowardice, feeble old age and miserliness.
2. Seek treatment when ill: every illness has a cure except old age.
3. As age grows, recite sitting, then stand to bow.
4. When the body is heavy, pray sitting.
5. Keep a regular walk, as he walked to Quba every Saturday.

FACTOR 2

Feelings, loneliness and grief

Over sixty-five, low mood is at its lowest of any age and feelings are better managed; with a shorter time ahead, people choose what matters and forgive more. But long, heavy stress weighs on older people more.

Being alone is risky; living alone is not, in itself. Isolation raises the risk of death two to four times. After the death of a husband or wife, grief comes in overlapping phases: numbness, longing and anger, despair, and then rebuilding. A sudden or untimely death, a quarrel before the death, and many stresses at once make it harder.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

b "The eye weeps and the heart grieves."

Anas said: we went with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) to (his son) Ibrahim as he was dying, and tears began to flow from the eyes of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). Abd al-Rahman bin Awf said: "You too, Messenger of Allah?" He said: "Ibn Awf, this is mercy." Then he said: "The eye weeps and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. Ibrahim, we are saddened by your parting."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1241 · Grade: Sahih

c Umm Sulaym's patience, and his prayer for them.

Anas bin Malik said: a son of Abu Talha fell ill and died while Abu Talha was away. When his wife saw that the boy had died, she prepared food and laid the boy in a corner of the house. When Abu Talha came he asked: "How is the boy?" She said: "His soul is at rest, and I hope he has found ease." In the morning she told him the boy had died. He prayed with the Prophet (pbuh) and told him what had happened, and the Prophet said: "Perhaps Allah will bless the two of you in this night of yours." A man of the Ansar said: "I saw nine sons of theirs, all of whom had learned the Qur'an."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1239 · Grade: Sahih

d The reward for losing children with patience.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to some women of the Ansar: "None of you loses three children and hopes for reward, except that she will enter Paradise." One of the women asked: "O Messenger of Allah, and two?" He said: "Or two."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6657 · Grade: Sahih

e Mourning has a limit.

Zaynab bint Abi Salama said: when news came of the death of Abu Sufyan, Umm Habiba on the third day asked for perfume, put it on her cheeks and arms, and said: "I have no need of this, but I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say: 'It is not lawful for a woman who believes in Allah and the Last Day to mourn for a dead person for more than three days, except for a husband, for whom she mourns four months and ten days.'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1220-1222 · Grade: Sahih

f Seek refuge from worry and grief.

> Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

g Do not wish for death because of hardship.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Let none of you wish for death because of a hardship that has struck him. If he must say something, let him say: O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me, and take me when death is better for me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5347 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Let tears come: "The eye weeps, the heart grieves"; weeping is mercy.
3. Be patient at a child's death, and hope for the reward.
4. Keep mourning within its limit: three days, and for a husband four months and ten days.
5. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.
- × **Avoid:** Wishing for death because of a hardship.

THEN

Family across the generations

FACTOR 3

Being a grandparent

The second peak of looking after children comes at sixty-five to seventy-four. Grandparents who help, without taking over, do best; raising a grandchild full-time is exhausting.

Grandparents can shield a child from a depressed mother's low mood and buffer a child's stress. Across many societies, no carer made a bigger difference to a child's survival than a grandmother.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a He prayed carrying his granddaughter.

> Abu Qatada al-Ansari said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to pray while carrying Umama bint Zaynab, his granddaughter. When he prostrated he put her down, and when he stood he picked her up.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 494; Sahih Muslim, common number 543 · Grade: Sahih

b He lengthened his prostration for his grandson.

> Shaddad bin al-Had said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) came out for one of the evening prayers carrying Hasan or Husayn. He put him down and led the prayer, and made one prostration very long. I raised my head and the child was on his back. After the prayer people asked about it, and he said: "My son was riding on me, and I did not want to hurry him."

Sunan Nasai, narration 1150 (common number 1141) · Grade: not stated in the edition

c Whoever shows no mercy is shown none.

> Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) kissed Hasan bin Ali while al-Aqra bin Habis was sitting with him. Al-Aqra said: "I have ten children and I have never kissed any of them." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) looked at him and said: "Whoever does not show mercy is not shown mercy."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5651 · Grade: Sahih

d Mercy to the young, honour to the old.

> Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather, reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our young and does not know the honour of our old." (In Anas's narration an old man wanted to reach the Prophet and people were slow to make room for him, and then he said this.)

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 1922 (common number 1920) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. Carry your grandchild, even in prayer.
2. Do not hurry the grandchild who climbs on you.
3. Kiss the grandchild and show mercy.
4. Show mercy to the young.

FACTOR 4

Grown children, and honour for the old

In their sixties and seventies, parents still give more than they receive, in money and practical help. Mixed feelings are common between old parents and grown children; it goes best when the old accept help with thanks.

Most long-term care comes from family, usually a daughter. Harm to older people is under-reported, and most of it comes from family, often a grown child who depends on the parent. Ageist ideas, that the old are senile, rigid and dependent, are all wrong; people with a positive view of ageing lived years longer.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The loss of the one who finds his parents old and does not enter Paradise.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "May his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust." He was asked: "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "The one who finds his parents in their old age, one or both of them, and still does not enter Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2551 · Grade: Sahih

b He honoured the old father of Abu Bakr.

At the conquest of Makka, Abu Bakr brought his father Abu Quhafa, who had lost his sight, leading him by the hand. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Why did you not leave the old man at home, so that I could go to him myself?" Abu Bakr said: "He has more right to come to you." The Prophet sat him in front of him, passed his hand over his chest and invited him to Islam, and he became a Muslim.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Being good to parents comes after prayer.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I asked the Prophet (pbuh): "Which deed is most loved by Allah?" He said: "Prayer on its time." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Then being good to parents." I asked: "Then which?" He said: "Striving in the path of Allah."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 504 · Grade: Sahih

d Honouring the grey-haired is honouring Allah.

Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Part of honouring Allah is honouring the grey-haired Muslim, the one who carries the Qur'an without going to extremes in it or neglecting it, and the just ruler."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 4863 (common number 4843) · Grade: not stated in the edition; Nawawi called it hasan

HOW TO DO IT

1. For the children: serve your parents in their old age.
2. Honour the old: go to them yourself, and sit them in front of you.
3. Be good to your parents.
4. Honour the grey-haired Muslim.
5. Show honour to the old.

LAST

Purpose, faith and affairs in order

FACTOR 5

Retirement and purpose

For most people retirement leaves mental health steady; for some it is hard, especially when it is forced, money is tight, it comes through illness, or work was the whole of life.

About a third of people in their sixties and seventies volunteer, and volunteering is linked with less low mood and better health. The first few years of retirement are the best time to start.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Three deeds that go on after death.

> Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "When a person dies, his deeds come to an end except for three: ongoing charity, knowledge that people benefit from, or a righteous child who prays for him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 1631 · Grade: Sahih

b Learn and teach.

> Uthman reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "The best of you is the one who learns the Qur'an and teaches it." Abu Abd al-Rahman al-Sulami taught the Qur'an from the time of Uthman until the time of al-Hajjaj, and said: "This hadith is what sat me in this place."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4739-4740 · Grade: Sahih

c Pass on, even one verse.

Abdullah bin Amr reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Pass on from me, even one verse."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3274 · Grade: Sahih

d Plant the seedling, even at the Hour.

Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "If the Hour comes while one of you has a palm seedling in his hand, and he is able to plant it before the Hour comes, let him plant it."

Al-Adab al-Mufrad, narration 483 (common number 479) · Grade: editor's ruling "sahih"

e Charity never decreases wealth.

The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Charity never decreased any wealth; Allah only increases a servant in honour for forgiving; and whoever humbles himself for Allah's sake, Allah raises him."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2588 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Leave behind ongoing charity, useful knowledge and a righteous child who prays for you.
2. Learn, and teach.
3. Pass on what you have learned, even one verse.
4. Plant the seedling, even if the Hour is coming.
5. Give charity: it never decreases wealth.

FACTOR 6

Looking back, and faith

The question of this age is: has my life been meaningful? Accepting it as "the only life I could have led" brings peace; despair often shows as anger and contempt for others. Looking back over one's life with a guide raises self-esteem and purpose.

For most people over sixty-five faith matters a great deal, and religious practice rises again in the sixties and seventies. Active taking part helps more than attending alone.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be in this world like a stranger or a traveller.

> Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of both my shoulders and said: "Be in this world as if you were a stranger or a traveller passing through."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6053 · Grade: Sahih

b Make the most of five before five.

> Amr bin Maymun al-Awdi said that the Prophet (pbuh), advising a man, said: "Make the most of five before five: your youth before your old age, your health before your illness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before you are busy, and your life before your death."

Ibn al-Mubarak, Al-Zuhd, narration 2 · Grade: not stated; the chain skips a companion (mursal)

c Think well of Allah.

> Jabir said: I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say, three days before he died: "Let none of you die except while thinking well of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2877 · Grade: Sahih

d Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

> Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Live in this world like a stranger or a traveller.
2. Make the most of what remains before it goes.
3. Be a grateful servant.
4. Think well of Allah.
5. Pray istikhara before an important decision.

FACTOR 7

A will, and putting affairs in order

Preparing for the last decisions belongs to these years: understanding where things stand, naming fears and hopes, and choosing the way ahead. Families who talked this through with a parent found relief.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep your will written.

> Abdullah bin Umar reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is not right for a Muslim who has something to leave in a will to spend two nights without having his will written down with him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2587 · Grade: Sahih

b A third at most; leave heirs well off.

> Sa'd bin Abi Waqqas said: in the year of the Farewell Pilgrimage the Prophet (pbuh) visited me when I was near death. I said: "I am wealthy and my only heir is one daughter; shall I give two thirds in charity?" He said: "No." "Half?" "No." He said: "A third, and a third is a lot. To leave your heirs rich is better than to leave them in need, holding out their hands to people. Whatever you spend seeking Allah's pleasure you will be rewarded for, even the morsel you put in your wife's mouth."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1233, 3721 · Grade: Sahih

c Do not die leaving debt.

Salama bin al-Akwa said: a funeral was brought, and the Prophet (pbuh) asked: "Does he owe any debt?" They said no, so he prayed over him. Another owed a debt but had left three dinars, so he prayed over him. A third had left nothing and owed three dinars; he said: "Pray over your companion yourselves." Abu Qatada said: "Pray over him, and his debt is on me," so the Prophet prayed over him.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2168, 2173 · Grade: Sahih

d Give charity while healthy.

Abu Hurayra said: a man asked: "O Messenger of Allah, which charity has the greatest reward?" He said: "That you give charity while you are healthy, eager for wealth, afraid of poverty and hoping to be rich. Do not delay until the soul reaches the throat and you say 'so much for this one, so much for that one', when it already belongs to them."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1353; Sahih Muslim, common number 1032 · Grade: Sahih

e Keep the land, give its produce.

Ibn Umar said: Umar bin al-Khattab got land at Khaybar and came to the Prophet (pbuh) for advice: "I have land more valuable than anything I have ever had; what do you tell me to do?" He said: "If you wish, keep the land itself and give its produce in charity." So Umar gave it in charity on the condition that it would not be sold, given away or inherited, for the poor, relatives, slaves, the path of Allah, travellers and guests.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2586, 2620-2621 · Grade: Sahih

f Give what you love to your relatives.

> Anas said: when the verse came down, "You will never reach goodness until you spend from what you love", Abu Talha said: "I make you my witness that I have given my land Bayruha for Allah." The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Give it to your relatives." So he divided it between Hassan bin Thabit and Ubayy bin Ka'b.

Musnad Ahmad, narration 14031 (common number 14036) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep your will written and with you.
2. Leave at most a third; leaving heirs well off is better than leaving them in need.
3. Do not die leaving debt.
4. Give charity while you are healthy, before the soul reaches the throat.
5. Keep the source, and give its income in charity.
6. Give what you love most to your relatives.

STAGE 13

The Last Part of Life

From eighty onwards, the last days, and those left behind

This stage is for a man or woman of eighty and beyond, for the family who care for them, and for those who are left behind after a death. It covers the oldest years, the last days of a life, and grief.

GO IN THIS ORDER

START HERE

The oldest years

1. The oldest years
2. Faith, and the fear of death
3. Family, and honour for the very old

THEN

Affairs in order, and the last days

4. Putting affairs in order
5. The last days

LAST

Those left behind

6. Grief, for those left behind

START HERE

The oldest years

FACTOR 1

The oldest years

People over eighty-five are the fastest-growing part of the population. Many in this age still say their health is very good. Most who reach eighty still have their minds; "senility" is usually an illness, not normal ageing.

What older people fear is not so much death as dying: hopelessness, helplessness and being alone. Losing a sense of control predicts frailty and dependence more strongly than income or health. Help that encourages is better than doing everything for the person.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a He sought refuge from feeble old age.

> Anas bin Malik said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) used to seek refuge, saying: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from laziness, I seek refuge in You from cowardice, I seek refuge in You from feeble old age, and I seek refuge in You from miserliness."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6010 · Grade: Sahih

b He fitted his prayer to his ageing body.

> Aisha said she never saw the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray the night prayer sitting until he grew old; then he would recite sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite about thirty or forty verses, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1067, 1068, 1097 · Grade: Sahih

c "Shall I not be a grateful servant?"

> Al-Mughira said: the Prophet (pbuh) stood in prayer until both his feet swelled. He was told: "Allah has forgiven you your past and future sins!" He said: "Shall I not be a grateful servant?" Aisha said: when he grew heavier in body, he would pray sitting, and when he wanted to bow he would stand, recite, and then bow.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 4556-4557, 1078 · Grade: Sahih

d The best: a long life with good deeds.

> A man asked: "O Messenger of Allah, which people are best?" He said: "The one whose life is long and whose deeds are good." He asked: "And which people are worst?" He said: "The one whose life is long and whose deeds are bad."

Sunan al-Darimi, narration 2753 (common number 2742) · Grade: not stated in the edition

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make the prayer for refuge from feeble old age, laziness and miserliness.
2. Fit worship to the body: recite sitting, then stand to bow; do not give the deed up, change the way.
3. Be a grateful servant.
4. Let a long life be a life of good deeds.

FACTOR 2

Faith, and the fear of death

Fear of death is lowest in old age. What gives meaning to life helps more than religious ties alone, and those whose belief and practice match fear death least.

The last task of life is integrity: wisdom in the face of death itself. In the eighties and nineties, despair can be a close companion.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Be in this world like a stranger or a traveller.

Abdullah bin Umar said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) took hold of both my shoulders and said: "Be in this world as if you were a stranger or a traveller passing through."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6053 · Grade: Sahih

b Think well of Allah.

Jabir said: I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say, three days before he died: "Let none of you die except while thinking well of Allah."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2877 · Grade: Sahih

c Ask Allah for the good before a big decision.

> Jabir said: the Prophet (pbuh) used to teach us to ask Allah for the good (istikhara) in all our affairs, as he taught us a surah of the Qur'an: "When one of you intends to do something, let him pray two rak'ahs, then say: O Allah, I ask You for the good through Your knowledge, and I ask You for strength through Your power, and I ask You from Your great bounty. You have power and I have none; You know and I do not know; You know the unseen. O Allah, if You know that this matter is good for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then decree it for me; and if You know that it is bad for me in my religion, my living and the end of my affairs, then turn it away from me and turn me away from it, and decree for me the good wherever it is, then make me content with it." And he should name his need.
>
> Sahih Bukhari, hadith 6019 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Live in this world like a stranger or a traveller.
2. Think well of Allah, to the very end.
3. Pray istikhara before an important decision.

FACTOR 3

Family, and honour for the very old

About half of those over eighty-five live alone, and most of them are widows. Being alone is risky, living alone is not, in itself. The oldest people often make new close friends, and friends matter more to their life satisfaction than younger family members.

Caring for a very old parent is heavy, and harm to the very old comes mostly from family. In most societies the old are clearly honoured, but their standing falls quickly when the mind declines.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a The loss of the one who finds his parents old and does not enter Paradise.

Abu Hurayra reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "May his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust, may his nose be rubbed in dust." He was asked: "Who, O Messenger of Allah?" He said: "The one who finds his parents in their old age, one or both of them, and still does not enter Paradise."

Sahih Muslim, common number 2551 · Grade: Sahih

b He honoured the old father of Abu Bakr.

At the conquest of Makka, Abu Bakr brought his father Abu Quhafa, who had lost his sight, leading him by the hand. The Prophet (pbuh) said: "Why did you not leave the old man at home, so that I could go to him myself?" Abu Bakr said: "He has more right to come to you." The Prophet sat him in front of him, passed his hand over his chest and invited him to Islam, and he became a Muslim.

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

c Honouring the grey-haired is honouring Allah.

Abu Musa al-Ash'ari reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Part of honouring Allah is honouring the grey-haired Muslim, the one who carries the Qur'an without going to extremes in it or neglecting it, and the just ruler."

Sunan Abu Dawud, narration 4863 (common number 4843) · Grade: not stated in the edition; Nawawi called it hasan

d Mercy to the young, honour to the old.

> Amr bin Shu'ayb, from his father, from his grandfather, reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "He is not one of us who does not show mercy to our young and does not know the honour of our old." (In Anas's narration an old man wanted to reach the Prophet and people were slow to make room for him, and then he said this.)

Jami Tirmidhi, narration 1922 (common number 1920) · Grade: Tirmidhi's ruling "hasan sahih"

HOW TO DO IT

1. For the children: serve your parents in their old age.
2. Honour the very old: go to them yourself, and sit them in front of you.
3. Honour the grey-haired Muslim.
4. Show honour to the old.

THEN

Affairs in order, and the last days

FACTOR 4

Putting affairs in order

The books advise hard conversations while there is still time: what the person understands of their condition, their fears and hopes, which trade-offs they will accept, and how they want to spend their time. Where people were asked these questions early, most had their wishes written down and followed.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Keep your will written.

Abdullah bin Umar reported that the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "It is not right for a Muslim who has something to leave in a will to spend two nights without having his will written down with him."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2587 · Grade: Sahih

b Do not die leaving debt.

Salama bin al-Akwa said: a funeral was brought, and the Prophet (pbuh) asked: "Does he owe any debt?" They said no, so he prayed over him. Another owed a debt but had left three dinars, so he prayed over him. A third had left nothing and owed three dinars; he said: "Pray over your companion yourselves." Abu Qatada said: "Pray over him, and his debt is on me," so the Prophet prayed over him.

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 2168, 2173 · Grade: Sahih

c Give charity while healthy.

Abu Hurayra said: a man asked: "O Messenger of Allah, which charity has the greatest reward?" He said: "That you give charity while you are healthy, eager for wealth, afraid of poverty and hoping to be rich. Do not delay until the soul reaches the throat and you say 'so much for this one, so much for that one', when it already belongs to them."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1353; Sahih Muslim, common number 1032 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Keep your will written and with you.
2. Do not die leaving debt.
3. Give charity while you are healthy, before the soul reaches the throat.

FACTOR 5

The last days

Care at the end is about easing pain of body, mind, family and spirit, with the patient and the family cared for together. Hope stays to the last moment in almost everyone; the door to it can be left open without lying.

Children and families are confused by soft words for death such as "gone to sleep"; plain words are better.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Do not wish for death because of hardship.

> Anas bin Malik reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Let none of you wish for death because of a hardship that has struck him. If he must say something, let him say: O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me, and take me when death is better for me."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5347 · Grade: Sahih

b Illness sheds sins like a tree sheds leaves.

Abdullah bin Mas'ud said: I went to the Prophet (pbuh) while he had a high fever. I touched him and said: "You have a high fever." He said: "Yes, I suffer as much as two of you." I said: "That is because you have a double reward." He said: "Yes. No Muslim is struck by any hurt, a thorn or more, except that Allah removes his sins because of it, as a tree sheds its leaves."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5323; Sahih Muslim, common number 2571 · Grade: Sahih

c Prompt the dying to say La ilaha illa Allah.

The Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said: "Prompt your dying ones to say 'La ilaha illa Allah' (there is no god but Allah)."

Sahih Muslim, narration 2106 · Grade: Sahih

d Visit the sick.

Thawban reported that the Prophet (pbuh) said: "Whoever visits a sick person remains in the harvest of Paradise until he returns." He was asked: "What is the harvest of Paradise?" He said: "Its fruits."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6510-6513 · Grade: Sahih

e In his last illness he spoke from the heart to his daughter.

> Aisha said: in the illness in which he died, the Prophet (pbuh) called his daughter Fatima, said "Welcome, my daughter!", sat her beside him and whispered to her, and she wept; then he whispered again and she laughed. After his death Fatima said: "He told me: 'Jibril used to go over the Qur'an with me once a year, and this year he did it twice; I think my time has come, and you will be the first of my family to join me.' So I wept. Then he said: 'Are you not pleased to be the leader of the women of Paradise?' So I laughed."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 3426-3427 · Grade: Sahih

f His last moments, among his family.

> Aisha softened a green tooth-stick of Abd al-Rahman's and gave it to him, and he cleaned his teeth with it well. Then he grew heavy, his eyes stayed open, and he said: "Rather, the highest companion in Paradise," and his soul was taken. Aisha said: "He died against my chest, on my day."

Ibn Hisham, Al-Sira · Seerah report; no grade, so it is not counted as a hadith

HOW TO DO IT

1. Do not wish for death; say: "O Allah, keep me alive as long as life is better for me."
2. Remember that illness sheds sins, as a tree sheds its leaves.
3. Gently prompt the dying person to say "La ilaha illa Allah".
4. Visit the sick.
5. In the last days, speak from the heart with your family.
6. Let the last moments be among the family.

× **Avoid:** Wishing for death because of a hardship.

LAST

Those left behind

FACTOR 6

Grief, for those left behind

Grief comes in overlapping phases: numbness, longing and searching with anger, despair, and then rebuilding. The tasks are to accept the loss, go through the pain, adjust to a world without the one who died, and keep an inner bond while moving on.

Most people are resilient; some grieve for years, and some show no grief at all. A sudden or untimely death, a quarrel before the death, and many stresses at once make grief harder. Where the wider family quickly helps, disabling grief is less.

GUIDANCE FROM THE LIFE OF THE PROPHET (PBUH)

a Patience is at the first blow.

Anas bin Malik said: the Prophet (pbuh) passed by a woman weeping at a grave and said: "Fear Allah and be patient." She said: "Leave me alone; you have not been struck by a loss like mine," not knowing who he was. She was told it was the Prophet, so she came to his door, found no doorkeeper there, and said: "I did not recognise you." He said: "Patience is at the first blow."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1223 · Grade: Sahih

b "The eye weeps and the heart grieves."

Anas said: we went with the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) to (his son) Ibrahim as he was dying, and tears began to flow from the eyes of the Messenger of Allah (pbuh). Abd al-Rahman bin Awf said: "You too, Messenger of Allah?" He said: "Ibn Awf, this is mercy." Then he said: "The eye weeps and the heart grieves, but we say only what pleases our Lord. Ibrahim, we are saddened by your parting."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1241 · Grade: Sahih

c Umm Sulaym's patience, and his prayer for them.

Anas bin Malik said: a son of Abu Talha fell ill and died while Abu Talha was away. When his wife saw that the boy had died, she prepared food and laid the boy in a corner of the house. When Abu Talha came he asked: "How is the boy?" She said: "His soul is at rest, and I hope he has found ease." In the morning she told him the boy had died. He prayed with the Prophet (pbuh) and told him what had happened, and the Prophet said: "Perhaps Allah will bless the two of you in this night of yours." A man of the Ansar said: "I saw nine sons of theirs, all of whom had learned the Qur'an."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1239 · Grade: Sahih

d The reward for losing children with patience.

Abu Hurayra said: the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) said to some women of the Ansar: "None of you loses three children and hopes for reward, except that she will enter Paradise." One of the women asked: "O Messenger of Allah, and two?" He said: "Or two."

Sahih Muslim, narration 6657 · Grade: Sahih

e Mourning has a limit.

Zaynab bint Abi Salama said: when news came of the death of Abu Sufyan, Umm Habiba on the third day asked for perfume, put it on her cheeks and arms, and said: "I have no need of this, but I heard the Prophet (pbuh) say: 'It is not lawful for a woman who believes in Allah and the Last Day to mourn for a dead person for more than three days, except for a husband, for whom she mourns four months and ten days.'"

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 1220-1222 · Grade: Sahih

f Seek refuge from worry and grief.

Anas said: I often heard the Messenger of Allah (pbuh) pray: "O Allah, I seek refuge in You from worry and grief, from weakness and laziness, from miserliness and cowardice, from the burden of debt and from being overpowered by people."

Sahih Bukhari, hadith 5109 · Grade: Sahih

HOW TO DO IT

1. Remember: patience is at the first blow.
2. Let tears come: weeping is mercy.
3. Be patient at a child's death, and hope for the reward.
4. Keep mourning within its limit: three days, and for a husband four months and ten days.
5. Make the prayer for refuge from worry and grief.